CHRISTIAN AND PAGAN IN THE ROMAN EMPIRE

The Witness of Tertullian



Edited by

ROBERT D. SIDER

Christian and Pagan in the Roman Empire

Selections from the Fathers of the Church

VOLUME 2

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For Lura Mae
my wife, companion, and incomparable friend

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The numbers placed in parentheses in Tertullian's texts below are section numbers from the original Fathers of the Church translations; these numbers do not appear in *Testimony of the Soul* because they do not appear in the original Fathers of the Church translation of this work.

Saskatoon, St. Nicholas' Day, 1999

GENERAL INTRODUCTION

Of the life of Tertullian little can be said with certainty. He was an African, obviously educated—he wrote both Latin and Greek and had studied rhetoric, philosophy, and medicine. During the years of his known literary productivity, he appears to have lived in Roman Carthage. One gathers from his writings that he grew up a pagan, but we know nothing about the time and circumstances of his conversion to Christianity. He appears on the literary scene with his first treatises in 197. He wrote voluminously for more than one decade, and possibly more than two. The last of his works that can be securely tied to a date is the letter to Scapula, the proconsul in Africa in 212/213, but his treatise *On Modesty* has been dated by some as late as the early 220s. He began his literary career as a staunch defender of the tradition embodied in the emerging Catholic Church, but in the course of his career he became ever more assertive of Montanism, a Christian charismatic movement originating in Asia Minor. It is, however, debated whether his commitment to Montanism entailed a schismatic departure from the Church of his first faith. He disappears from our view without a trace of the course of his life after his last literary compositions. The date, place, and manner of his death are utterly unknown; we have only legend and conjecture to fill in the details.[1]

1. Timothy David Barnes, *Tertullian: A Historical and Literary Study* (reissued with corrections and a Postscript, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1985), 1–59, 242–59, 324–25, provides a critical analysis of the details available for a biographical reconstruction of the life of Tertullian. Pagination in this edition is identical with that of the original edition (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971) except for the added pages (321–39) of the Postscript.

The importance of Tertullian in the development of early Christian thought, and his significance for our understanding of early Christianity, cannot be overestimated. Though he was certainly not the first Christian to write Latin, he is the first Christian Latin author from whom we have a major literary corpus. While he played a considerable role in shaping a Christian Latin vocabulary and provided formulae that became decisive in Western Christological reflection, it is as "witness" that his work will inspire a broadly based interest: witness in the first place to the kind of reflection current within the Church and, indeed, within forms of Christianity, such as the gnostic sects, that were thriving outside the emerging Catholic Church in the early third century; witness also to the inner life of the Church in its myriad aspects at this period; witness to the Church's relationship to its contextual world of paganism; and, finally, witness to aspects of the pagan world itself—albeit a prejudicial witness, illuminating only those parts of that world that were germane to his themes, and then always with his own colored light.

The selections from Tertullian presented here have been chosen and edited to reveal the light Tertullian's writings cast upon his world and upon himself as a Christian responding to his world. One should, perhaps, speak of his "worlds," for he lived within a "Christian world"—the community of Christians—very self-conscious about its presence in the surrounding "pagan world." Thus we shall find here both the presuppositions for, and the explication of, the nascent Christian theology that was developing within Tertullian's Christian world. The *Apology*, for example, offers in abbreviated form a Christology based upon a logos theology. In this collection we shall see both in the *Apology* and elsewhere an appeal to the important distinction between general and special revelation, and we shall discover the presuppositions that give authenticity to the Scriptures and authority to the role they play in special revelation. In the writings presented here, there are repeated allusions to, even lengthy descriptions of, the demonic, and we shall see how the age-old question of blindness in the face of the obvious finds a "Christian" explanation by appeal to the insidious role of the demons as corruptors and perverters. Moreover, the waters

of baptism did not wash from Tertullian's mind the philosophy of Stoicism so deeply imbued from his pagan education; hence, we can observe the appeal to reason, so integral to Stoicism as a fundamental factor in the discussion of philosophical questions, growing ever sharper with time as we move from Tertullian's earlier to his later work. For Tertullian the divine is rational and the rational divine, and the closer he drew to Montanism the more his writings witness to the force with which Montanism's "Paraclete," that is, the Holy Spirit, drove him to express his thought in forms of argumentation like the syllogism, whose rationality seemed to demand assent to an inescapable truth, though in Tertullian's hands the argumentation was often reckless and the apparent validity specious. Hence, from our perspective, the more Tertullian boasted of reason, and the more insistently he attempted to place issues on the foundation of reason, the more irrational his argument seems to have become. In sum, the mind of Tertullian bubbles and seethes with presuppositions, imagery, and arguments often reflective in some manner of the Christian thinking of his time, though no doubt generally reshaped by his own predilections, subservient to his own purposes, and expressed in a manner as well as in terms that owe much to his pagan formation.

The selections given here also offer some vivid vignettes of Christian life in the late second and early third centuries. Few of these pictures are photographic reproductions, so to speak; most may seem impressionistic portraits or studies in perspective. One thinks, for example, of the highly idealistic portrait of Christian society in *Apology* 39. But Tertullian's argument sometimes allows us to read between the lines and to construct a picture of our own that is perhaps a little closer to reality: making some sort of compromise with their world, Christians clearly did attend the pagan shows against which Tertullian thundered; confessors who had endured tortures before the proconsul succumbed rather easily to the temptation to engage in unpleasant quarrels with their fellow confessors in prison; the legendary fearlessness of Christians in the face of persecution was matched by widespread anxiety; and it is clear from Tertullian's writing that some Christians were prepared to buy their way out of danger. In spite of the Church's apparently absolute

prohibition of both idolatry and murder, Christians found ways of serving in the military force. Thus from the searing rhetoric of Tertullian's often intransigent demands upon his fellow Christians there emerges, though sometimes by inference, the portrait of a Christian society struggling to define its identity in relation to the world and to establish the limits of compromise with the surrounding paganism.

Again, these pages are also witness to some aspects of contemporary pagan life, though the picture they afford is no doubt generally distorted by the Christian lens that Tertullian forces the reader to wear. The *Apology,* in particular, is rich in its allusiveness. Tertullian portrays a contemporary populace careless of evidence, eager for gossip, ready to believe the worst—even that their Christian neighbors are cannibals! In civic life the populace and the upper classes are alike of doubtful loyalty and greedy enough to betray an emperor for a fresh donative. They are degraded to the point that national celebrations are occasions for the most dissolute behavior. The portrait of pagan society in the *Spectacles* is no more flattering: the madness of the circus, the lewdness of the theater, the violence of stadium and amphitheater reflect the perversions of pagans. Such portraits are intended to force a contrast between Christians and pagans, and they may well be hyperbolic. But the anguished question of *Flight in Time of Persecution*, whether Christians could buy their freedom from persecution, implies an unflattering picture of those pagans who were willing to blackmail neighbors or acquaintances, and sometimes, perhaps, even individuals entirely unknown to them: they would threaten to inform against these Christians unless a sufficiently high fee was paid for their silence.

We can, however, gather hints of a more responsible element in pagan society. The gossips of the *Apology* are worthy only of our disdain, but the general charges made by pagans—that the Christians do not worship the gods and do not sacrifice on behalf of the emperor—must reflect a genuine element of concern on the part of Roman citizens for the welfare of the state, perhaps analogous to our own contemporary concern that citizens be, to some degree, integrated into a nation's culture, appreciate and adopt as their own the myths that appear to have made a nation great.

Thus a careful reading of the selections offered here should serve to bring the reader face to face with many aspects of the pagan world that provided the context for Christianity, along with the Christian response to that world. It should serve as well to illuminate the interior life and thought of the early Church of the late second and early third centuries—critical years, indeed, in the life of the Church, as it was a period of rapid expansion as well as a time when Church structures and theological understanding experienced considerable development.

In the Fathers of the Church (FOTC) series only two volumes (10 and 40) have been devoted to the work of Tertullian. Though these two volumes—from which, following editorial policy, our selections were chosen—do not by any means contain the full record of Tertullian's witness to pagan and Christian life in his world, they are a remarkably fertile source for our project and offer a fair representation of the theme as it can be found in Tertullian.

This series is intended to present selections that focus on a theme, without necessarily preserving the structure of the works from which the excerpts are taken. But in the case of Tertullian the treatises are so completely forged in the fire of rhetoric that generally one cannot disengage the themes from the structure without losing the force of argument that is so essential to the revelation of Tertullian's thought. In this volume, therefore, it has been a primary aim to preserve the fundamental structure and argument of the individual treatises. At the same time, I have abbreviated the treatises by omission in such a way that the argument is, I hope, actually facilitated: digressions have been omitted, examples and illustrative material radically reduced. In so doing I have not, of course, attempted to "improve" Tertullian; I should be pleased, however, if I have succeeded in making his writings more easily accessible to readers who wish to have some experience of early Christianity, but who have perhaps not yet acquired the intellectual context or the methodological tools to penetrate and understand literature that not only seems foreign, but is, in fact, when unadapted, sometimes quite complex and often very difficult.

The treatises of Tertullian in the FOTC volumes were translated by Rudolph Arbesmann, O.S.A., Sister Emily Joseph Daley, C.S.J., and Edwin A. Quinn, S.J. The translators chose a gen-

erally free style of translation which I have only lightly revised; normally, I have done so on the basis of the texts provided by Corpus Christianorum, series latina (CCSL) I, II (Turnhout: Brepols, 1954), though occasionally I have adopted a reading from a more recent critical edition. I have sometimes, and without notice to the reader, inserted into the FOTC text a word or phrase that seemed essential to form a proper bridge between two passages that otherwise joined a little harshly when the intervening material had been omitted. Very occasionally, I have rearranged clauses and phrases in an FOTC sentence.

A brief introduction to each piece establishes a context for the reader. In the footnotes I have attempted not only to identify allusions, but briefly to suggest how Tertullian stands in the intellectual traditions both of pagan and of Christian thought, and I have pointed the reader to some basic sources in both traditions that may help to establish lines of cultural continuity reaching to the intellectual worlds that both precede and follow Tertullian. The reader will thus be in a better position to appreciate the ways in which Tertullian may be viewed as a witness to the age to which he belonged. The notes also identify certain expressions that seem to be of special importance for an appreciation of Tertullian's vision of the two worlds, pagan and Christian, in which he found himself: expressions such as "Christian" and "pagan"; "sacrament"—both a pagan and a Christian word; words for "Scripture" that both distinguish Christian literature from and identify it with pagan literature; and some words that are of inherent interest for Christian readers. Assuming a generally educated but not a specialist readership, I have offered in the notes bibliographical references—primarily but not exclusively studies written in English—that will facilitate the identification of some of the basic perennial problems as well as some issues of current interest raised by the representation of our theme in these treatises.

An appendix contains for the convenience of the reader a translation of the correspondence between Pliny and Trajan to which Tertullian appeals in the *Apology* and which constitutes a fundamental point of departure for understanding the official behavior of pagans toward Christians.

To sharpen the context of the treatises as represented here,

I have assigned a date to the composition of each of them as follows:

197: *To the Martyrs, Apology, Spectacles*
198: *The Testimony of the Soul*
211: *The Crown*
212 (or 208): *Flight in Time of Persecution*

The dating of many of Tertullian's treatises is highly problematical, however, and it has not been my intent, nor does it seem appropriate here, to establish and justify in a necessarily complex argument the dates I have assigned.[2]

2. For a discussion of the problems of dating the treatises, see Barnes, *Tertullian*, 30–56, and, in the Postscript, the important reconsideration of and revisions to the dates Barnes originally assigned to the treatises. For the dating of the treatises represented in this selection, see esp. pp. 325 and 328.

Christian and Pagan in the Roman Empire

1

APOLOGY

Introduction

Very few documents from early Christianity reveal more vividly than Tertullian's *Apology* the perspectives from which Christians might look upon the pagan world that surrounded them, and the presuppositions they brought to the justification of their own role in society. Indeed, the modern reader is forced into the hurly-burly of the Roman world by the very form of the *Apology*, for this "apology" for Christianity takes shape around the fictive image of a forensic trial. The image of the trial is consistently maintained with such lively force that the reader is captivated by the vivid thrust and parry of argument, and one easily imagines oneself as an attendant in a court of law in the last years of the last decade of the second century A.D.

The image of the trial furnished a literary rationale for listing the charges against Christians that pagans might make in a variety of circumstances: whether they were intent on having Christians brought before the governor to be put on trial for their faith, whether they were indulging in dinner-table gossip among their pagan friends, or whether they were personally confronting Christians in what might well have been an honest and friendly attempt to understand Christian faith. Novel forms of religious behavior invite from outsiders conceptions that are

sometimes wildly imaginative, even malicious. Tertullian would have us believe that in their gossip pagans of the second century turned the Christian Eucharist into a cannibalistic feast and the Christian love-feast into a sex orgy. It is possible that such rumors as were reported by the Christian Tertullian were exaggerated—both in the literary art of Tertullian and in the popular Christian mind; but they undoubtedly reflect a fertile seedbed of suspicion among pagans from which substantive charges against Christians could grow. Indeed, Tertullian reports two charges that were indeed substantive: first, that Christians did not worship the gods of the state, and, second, that Christians neither offered incense to the genius of the emperor nor participated in pagan celebrations in honor of state and empire. In ancient Rome the view was pervasive that the prosperity of the Roman state—a prosperity that had brought Rome dominion over the entire world—was the result of Roman devotion to the gods; to refuse to worship these gods was to threaten the security of the entire community, which was, in effect, to betray the commonwealth. Similarly, to refuse to participate in the community's celebrative occasions suggested a malicious intent to undermine the state, or, at the least, signaled an unwillingness to play one's legitimate role as a loyal and supportive citizen. Such concerns were intensified by a further complaint that Christians, by withdrawing their support from pagan religion, undermined a major sector of the Roman economy, thus becoming a financial liability to the state.

The image of the trial also served a symbolic function, for in the Greco-Roman world the trial had offered a context in which to practice the sophisticated skills society had developed for discerning truth; as the obverse of this, the trial could also stand as a symbol of the justice based on truth so confidently discovered by such skills. Thus, in the *Apology* Tertullian was able, by placing his exposition of Christianity within the framework of an imagined trial, to parade all the skills commonly used to bring a judgment in an actual court case. Thus he was able to invite pagans to affirm a Christianity whose truth had been established by the finest techniques of rational demonstration known in antiquity, where finely tuned arguments from probability and conjecture and appeals to the first-hand evidence of

witnesses and testimony were the accepted grounds of evidence.

Because concern for the discovery of truth lay at the heart of the image of the trial, in adopting this image Tertullian found an appropriate arena in which to present the knowledge of the truth as the central issue between paganism and Christianity. On the one hand, he could affirm the capacity of pagans as pagans to glimpse the truth—if only in part; because they could do so, he could legitimately proceed to sketch for them the outline of Christian truth. On the other hand, he was compelled to explain why pagans had missed the truth in part. Pagans would have understood the basic problem Tertullian was, at this point, raising, for the concern about the nature and causes of human blindness had had a long history in the records of classical literature. The inability of people to see the obvious found representation in the epics of Homer; it became an anxious and tortured problem among the Greek tragedians of the fifth century B.C., and it motivated lengthy discussions by the philosophers. While Tertullian's fundamental solution to the problem—demonic perversion—must have, in his particular application of it, seemed novel and strange to pagans, one could recall that even in the poetry of Homer an action whose evil consequences were unforeseen could be attributed to the intervention of some "daimon."[1] At some points Tertullian offers provisional solutions to the problem that would have had a familiar psychological ring: people are unable to know the truth because passion in the form of hatred prevents them; or again because some people (pagans) wish to foist upon others (Christians) the guilty image they do not wish to see in themselves. Thus, pagans were in a position to recognize the irony in the trial image: because of their perversions, they failed to see the truth in spite of their efforts to find it; in not seeing the truth, they made the trial of the Christians, as the proud prelude to a supposedly just judgment, the twisted path to injustice.

Through the image of the trial, then, Tertullian sought to address pagans on their own ground and from their own presuppositions. The trial implicitly acknowledged the achievement of Greco-Roman society in devising methods that could confi-

1. See, e.g., *Odyssey* 12.295; 14.488.

dently ascertain the "facts of the case." The trial image also offered, ironically, a venue wherein one could account for the failure of those very methods, and from which Tertullian was able to appeal to another time-honored strain in Greco-Roman thought: the inevitability of human blindness. The reader will discover that in other respects, too, the advocate acknowledged the plaintiff's presuppositions, in particular, that the Roman empire is the gift of God (if not the gods), that its security is essential to the welfare of humanity, and that genuinely foreign elements are indeed a threat to its security.[2]

As we have just seen, the trial as the central symbol of the *Apology* invited Tertullian to elucidate a theology that accounts for human perversity. The *Apology* also witnesses to the early presence of other themes central in the history of Christian theology. Of special interest is the distinction between general and special revelation, as well as a Christology based upon a logos theology. It is, however, not only to the theological reflection of the second century that the *Apology* witnesses; it describes as well more practical aspects of Christian life as the second century was moving into the third. The portrait of the early Christian "assembly" will pique the interest of amateur and professional historians alike, as will the general picture of the day-to-day relations of Christians with pagans in the world at this time.

The literary structure of the *Apology*, based on classical rhetorical precedents, is complex, and it has frequently been studied in detail.[3] It is sufficient here to trace a brief outline to help the reader see the work thematically as a whole.

2. This account of the decisive way in which Tertullian adopted pagan assumptions to address pagans, affirming thereby the value of pagan intellectual achievements, challenges attempts like that of Richard Niebuhr in his *Christ and Culture* (New York, N.Y.: Harper and Brothers, 1951), 51–55 (but cf. 72–78), to make Tertullian representative of those who see the Christian in unqualified conflict with secular culture. For a positive interpretation of Tertullian's relation to culture, see Jean-Claude Fredouille, *Tertullien et la conversion de la culture antique* (Paris: Études Augustiniennes, 1972), *passim*, and Robert D. Sider, *Ancient Rhetoric and the Art of Tertullian* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1971), esp. 126–30.

3. For a brief study see Robert D. Sider, "On Symmetrical Composition in Tertullian," *Journal of Theological Studies* 24 (1973): 405–23, and especially 408–18; see also *Ancient Rhetoric and the Art of Tertullian* (see "*Apologeticum*" in

I. Introduction (1–6).
   A. The irrational procedure in the trial of Christians is evidence for the perversion of pagan justice (1–3).
   B. Preliminary consideration: to those who appeal to the law that it is illegal to be a Christian, there is a simple answer—unjust laws can and must be changed (4–6).

II. Charges based on "rumor" answered (7–9).
   A. The charge: Christians participate in cannibalistic feasts and incestuous orgies.
   B. The response: there is no evidence for these rumors.

III. Charges of "more manifest crimes" answered (10–45).
   A. The first charge: "Christians do not worship the gods" (10–28.3).
   B. The response:
      1. Regarding the gods of the pagans (10–15).
         a. The gods of the pagans do not exist (10–12).
         b. Even pagans, who claim the gods exist, act as though they do not exist (13–15).
      2. Regarding the God of the Christians: an exposition of Christian belief in God which shows that the Christians do indeed worship God (16–21).
         a. False views of the Christians' God denied (16).
         b. The true characterization of the Christians' God affirmed (17–21).
      3. What the gods of the pagans really are—demonic spirits (22–24).
      4. Proof that the pagan gods did not give the Romans their empire (25–26).
      5. Summary comments regarding the first charge (27).
   C. The second charge—treason: "Christians do not give the honors due to the Emperor and they endanger the security of the state" (28–45).
   D. The response:
      1. Christians do not sacrifice to the Emperor, but they pray for him (29–34).

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the "Index of references," p. 141). For an extensive study of the structure of the *Apologeticum*, readers of German may consult Gunther Eckert, *Orator Christianus: Untersuchungen zur Argumentationskunst in Tertullians Apologeticum*, Palingenesia, vol. 46 (Stuttgart: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1993).

2. Christians do not celebrate national holidays in the pagan manner, but their loyalty is unswerving; it is, in fact, pagans who are disloyal (35–38).
3. Christian gatherings represent a model of creative community; Christians are not an assembly of conspirators; a true description of the Christian "assembly" offered (39).
4. It is, in fact, pagans who are destroying the state; Christians genuinely support civic life (40–45).

IV. Concluding considerations.

A. Christians distinguished from philosophers (46–47).

B. The ultimate and universal trial on the Last Day when God, the Judge who knows all, will dispense an absolute justice (48–50).

It may be helpful to say a few words about the term "apology" and about the relation of Tertullian's *Apology* to the genre as it developed in early Christianity. The Latin *apologia* is a transliteration of the Greek word ἀπολογία, which designates a speech of defense in the law courts.[4] Thus Plato's record of Socrates' defense before the Athenian jurors is called the *Apology* of Socrates. When Christians undertook to defend their name, their society, their beliefs, and their manner of life against pagan suspicions and attacks, they found in the classical model of the defense speech a useful form for adaptation. An impressive line of Christian apologetic literature preceded Tertullian's *Apology*, which was written in 197. Of this literature two distinguished examples, both written in Greek, are the first *Apology* of Justin Martyr (ca. 156–160) and the *Plea* of Athenagoras (ca. 176). Tertullian's *Apology* reflects much that can be found in these two works, but it achieves a higher level of literary sophistication than either of them through the tight logic of

4. *Apologia* as a Latin word, transliterated from the Greek, appears only in Late Antiquity, and then seldom—primarily in Jerome. It appears that, in the case of Tertullian's *Apology*, the title was bestowed on the work after its publication. Neither the noun *apologia* nor its adjectival analogue *apologeticus* appears in the text of the *Apology*. In the fourth century, however, Lactantius apparently knew the work as the *Apologeticum*—see *Divine Institutes* 5.4.3 (*Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum* [CSEL], vol. 19, ed., Samuel Brandt [Vienna: C. Gerald Filium, 1890], 411); and Jerome speaks of it as Tertullian's [*liber*] *apologeticus*, "apologetic [book]"—see *Ep.* 70.5 (CSEL, vol. 54, ed., Isidorus Hilberg [Vienna: C. Gerald Filium, 1910], 707). The manuscript tradition favors the term *Apologeticum* as the Latin title.

its structure, the powerfully climactic arrangement of its argument, the relentless retortion of the charges whereby the accusations are hurled back upon the accusers, and a narrative that is at once caustic in style and enlivened by a close-packed array of sharply chiseled images.

However, Tertullian's defense of the Christians also carries implicitly an "appeal" to the pagans—particularly in its recognition of shared presuppositions, in its exposition of Christian doctrine, in its vindication of the Christian way of life, and in its threat of the Final Judgment—and so it becomes in some measure also an exhortation to the pagans to respond affirmatively to the Christian revelation. In this respect it reflects another literary genre represented in, for example, the *Protrepticus (Exhortation to the Greeks)* of Clement of Alexandria, Tertullian's contemporary; this was a genre visible in embryonic form in Paul's speech on the Areopagus (Acts 17:22–31).

Because the similarities between Tertullian's *Apology* and those of Justin and Athenagoras reflect a common Christian approach to the paganism of the period, the notes will frequently refer the reader to these two predecessors of Tertullian.[5] Occasional references will be made to other apologists of late antiquity, including Minucius Felix, whose *Octavius* resembles closely in its themes the *Apology* of Tertullian. Indeed the similarities are so close and so numerous that scholars generally accept that one of the two is dependent on the other. There is not, unfortunately, agreement on which is the predecessor, but perhaps a majority of scholars assign the role to Tertullian's book.[6]

5. For the Christian apologetic literature Tertullian used as sources for his own *Apology*, see Robert M. Grant, *Greek Apologists of the Second Century* (London: SCM Press, 1988), 187–88. For an excellent discussion of apologetic literature as a genre, see Jean-Claude Fredouille, "L'apologetique chrétienne antique: naissance d'un genre littéraire," *Revue des études augustiniennes* 38 (1992): 219–34. See also Jean Daniélou, *Gospel Message and Hellenistic Culture,* ed. and trans. by John Austin Baker (Philadelphia, Penn.: Westminster Press, 1973), 7–37. For the origins of the Christian apology, see Robert M. Grant, *Augustus to Constantine: The Thrust of the Christian Movement into the Roman World* (New York, N.Y.: Harper and Row, 1970), 88–90.

6. For the dating of the *Octavius,* see G. W. Clarke, *The Octavius of Minucius Felix*, Ancient Christian Writers, vol. 39 (New York, N.Y.: Newman Press, 1974), 9–12. Clarke places the *Octavius* after Tertullian's *Apology*, somewhere in the first third of the third century A.D.

If, as is widely agreed, the *Apology* was written in 197, it is possible to conjecture the immediate circumstances that might have motivated its composition. The emperor Septimius Severus had in that year finally subdued the last of his rivals. In Rome his victory was followed by a savage purge from the Senate of those who had supported Severus' enemies, and in some cases of those whose loyalty was questionable. One can imagine that beyond Rome as well officials would have looked for the public affirmation of loyalty to the regime of the victor. Christians who stood aloof from pagan celebrations and public affirmations of support for the emperor would have readily been open to suspicion, and suspicion would have given rise to charges. Certainly from *Apology* 1.1 it is clear that some Christians had been arrested and tried without adequate opportunity for defense. It was necessary to protest their unjust fate and to affirm the loyalty of all Christians. This Tertullian attempted to do in the *Apology*.[7]

The Text

[The Address]

CHAPTER 1

(1) Magistrates of the Roman Empire, seated as you are before the eyes of all, in almost the highest position in the state to pronounce judgment:[8] if you are not allowed to conduct an open and public examination and inquiry as to what the real truth is with regard to the Christians; if, as happened lately in

7. See Barnes, *Tertullian,* 109.

8. Since Tertullian had cast his treatise in the form of a speech of defense at a trial, it was appropriate that he address the magistrates of the Roman province of Africa—the proconsul, who was governor and judge at criminal trials, and his officials. These officials had their seat on the Byrsa, the administrative center established on the hill ("almost the highest position") that dominated Carthage. But Tertullian would have had a larger audience in mind, above all the cultured classes from whom the magistrates of the empire came (see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 109–10). Moreover, it is likely that he wrote his *Apology* with some expectation of a Christian audience also, who would find the irony, as well as the mockery of paganism, pleasing, and the case made for Christianity reassuring.

the Proconsul's secretariat, hatred of this group has all too effectively blocked its defense[9]—then let the truth reach your ears by the private and quiet avenue of literature.

[The irrational procedure of the pagans in the trial of Christians is unjust; it stems from ignorance and perverts justice.]

(2) Truth does not wonder at her present condition. She knows that she plays the role of an alien on earth, that among strangers she readily discovers enemies, but that she has her origin, abode, hope, recompense, and honor in heaven.[10] Meanwhile, there is one thing for which she strives: that she be not condemned without a hearing. (3) As for the laws, if they condemn her without a hearing, they will incur the stigma of acting unjustly.

(4) This, then, is the first grievance we lodge against you, the injustice of the hatred you have for the name of Christian. The motive that appears to excuse this injustice is precisely that which both aggravates and convicts it; namely, ignorance. For, what is more unjust than that people should hate what they do not know? (5) People remain in ignorance as long as they hate, and they hate unjustly as long as they remain in ignorance. (6) The proof of their ignorance is this: in the case of all who formerly indulged in hatred because of their ignorance of the nature of what they hated, their hatred comes to an end as soon as their ignorance ceases. From this group come the Christians;[11] and Christians are really as numerous as you allege us to be. (7) People cry that the state is besieged, that Christians are in the country, in the villages, on the islands; men and women, of every age, of every state and rank of life, are transferring to this group, and this they lament as if it were some personal injury.[12]

9. The incident is otherwise unknown. For "Proconsul's secretariat" see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 109 n. 5.

10. These phrases echo the language of such passages as Heb. 11:13; 1 Pet. 2:11; Phil. 3:20; 1 Pet. 1:4.

11. Literally, "from these Christians are made." "Are made" *(fiunt)* acquires a special significance below; see nn. 19 and 79.

12. See Pliny's letter (*Ep.* 10. 96) to Trajan, translated in the appendix to this volume. Tertullian's statement here, which implies a vast number of Chris-

In spite of this fact, people's minds are not directed to the consideration of some underlying good. (8) They are not permitted to surmise more accurately; they do not choose to investigate more closely. Here only does human curiosity lack its keenness. These delight in their ignorance, while others rejoice in their knowledge. (9) They prefer to remain ignorant because they are already filled with hatred. (10) "But," says one, "a thing is not considered good simply because it wins many converts." Who denies that? Yet, if a thing is really evil, not even those whom it attracts dare to defend it as good. All evil is drenched with fear or shame by nature. (11) For example, evildoers are anxious to remain in hiding. They shun the light. They tremble when caught. They deny when accused. When condemned, they lament. (12) In what respect are Christians like this? None of them is ashamed, none has any regrets, except for the fact that one was not a Christian earlier. If a charge is brought against them, they glory in it. If they are accused, they offer no defense. When questioned, they confess of their own accord. For the word of condemnation they give thanks.[13] (13) What kind of evil is this that has none of the natural signs of evil?

CHAPTER 2

(1) If, then, it is decided that we are the most wicked of human beings, why do you treat us so differently from all other criminals? The same treatment ought to be meted out for the same crime. (2) When others are charged with the same crimes as we, they are given full liberty to answer the charge and to cross-question, since it is unlawful for anyone to be condemned without defense or without a hearing. (3) Christians alone are

tians in the Roman empire in the late second century, is undoubtedly a rhetorical exaggeration, though the statement has often been used in attempts to calculate the Christian population at this time. On the question of the size of the Christian population, see Keith Hopkins, "Christian Number and its Implications," *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 6 (1998): 185–226. Cf. n. 125, below.

13. It was customary for Christians to give thanks to God when judgment was given against them by the official presiding at their trial. See, for example, the accounts of the trials of the Scillitan martyrs and of Cyprian in Herbert Musurillo, *Acts of the Christian Martyrs* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972), 89 and 173.

permitted to say nothing that would clear their name, vindicate the truth, and help the judge to come to a fair decision. One thing only is what they wait for; this is the only thing necessary to feed public hatred: the confession of the name of Christian, not an investigation of the charge. (4) Yet, suppose you are trying any other criminal. If he confesses to the crime of murder, sacrilege, incest, or treason—the indictments hurled against us—you are not satisfied to pass sentence immediately; you weigh the attendant circumstances, the character of the deed, the number of times it was committed, the time, the place, the witnesses, and the partners-in-crime. (5) In our case there is nothing of this sort, though the charges falsely brought against us ought to be investigated in the same determined manner.

(6) On the other hand, we find that it has been forbidden to search us out. For when Pliny the Younger was in charge of his province and had condemned certain Christians, he consulted Trajan, emperor at the time, as to what he should do thereafter. He explained that, apart from their obstinate refusal to offer sacrifice, he had learned nothing about their religious rites except that they met before daybreak to sing to Christ and to God,[14] and to bind themselves by oath to a way of life that forbade murder, adultery, dishonesty, treachery, and all other crimes. (7) Trajan wrote back that men of this kind should not be sought out, but, when brought to court, they should be punished.[15] (8) Oh, how unavoidably ambiguous was that decision!

14. Some manuscripts read "to Christ as to God," perhaps emended to agree with the text of Pliny's letter, but see n. 88, below. For the expression "God and Christ," see *Spectacles* 25.

15. Pliny the Younger was governor (A.D. 111–13) of the Roman province of Bithynia-Pontus, which lay in northwestern Asia Minor (modern Turkey), bordering the Black Sea. When certain Christians were brought before Pliny, he imprisoned those who were Roman citizens, intending to send them to Rome for trial, but he had the others executed. Some, however, who were charged with being Christians recanted, and it was on the treatment of these that he sought Trajan's advice, since he had found them innocent of any crime and guilty only of "superstition." His letter is generally taken as evidence that Christians who would not renounce their faith were condemned for their profession of Christianity, that is, for the name alone. It is probable, however, that the suspicion of crime played a role in the proscription of the name—a suspicion Tertullian's *Apology* attempts to address, and which may be implied by Pliny's investigation of renegades. On the considerations that might well have justified

He says that they should not be sought—as though they were innocent; then he prescribes that they should be punished—as though they were guilty! Judgment, why do you thus ensnare yourself? If you condemn them, why not also search for them? If you do not search for them, why not also acquit them?

(10) Then, too, when you deal with us in this matter, you do not follow the procedure prescribed for judging criminals. To others who deny their guilt, you apply torture to force them to confess; to Christians alone, you apply torture to force them to deny. (13) A man proclaims: "I am a Christian."[16] He says what he is; you want to hear what he is not. You, who preside as judges to extract the truth, in our case alone take pains to hear a lie. "I am," says one, "what you ask if I am. Why do you torture me into lying? I confess, and you torture me!" Certainly, when others deny, you do not readily believe them; if we deny, you immediately believe us!

(14) Let this perversity of yours lead you to suspect that there is some secret underlying power that uses you as tools against the form and nature of exercising justice, and, in fact, against the very laws themselves.[17] Unless I am mistaken, the laws demand that evil-doers be brought to light, not concealed;

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in the minds of pagans the peremptory condemnation of the Christian name, see Robert L. Wilken, *The Christians as the Romans Saw Them* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1984), 11–29. See also Stephen Benko, "Pagan Criticism of Christianity During the First Two Centuries A.D.," in *Aufstieg und Niedergang der romischen Welt*, part II, vol. 23.2, ed. Hildegard Temporini and Wolfgang Haase (Berlin: Walter deGruyter, 1980), 1055–118; see esp. 1075–76, where the significance of Pliny's letter is discussed. For the same discussion in a more popular form, see Benko's *Pagan Rome and the Early Christians* (Bloomington, Ind.: Indiana University Press, 1984), 4–14. For Pliny's letter and Trajan's reply, see the appendix, below.

16. According to our literary sources, "I am a Christian" was the characteristic response Christians gave to their interrogators at their trials, no doubt because the charge against them was their confession of the name. See "The Acts of the Scillitan Martyrs" and "The Martyrdom of Polycarp," in Musurillo, *Acts*, 11 and 89; see also Tertullian, *The Crown* 1, below, and 1 Pet. 4:16. The literary sources, including Pliny's letter, attest as well the efforts magistrates made to encourage Christians to renounce the name; see "The Martyrdom of Saints Perpetua and Felicitas," in Musurillo, *Acts,* 114–15.

17. The "secret power" refers to the demons, whose role Tertullian will describe in chapters 22–24, below.

they prescribe that confessed criminals be condemned, not acquitted. (15) If torture is forestalled by confession, it will be unnecessary; sentence is then required. The guilty must be freed by, not freed from, paying the punishment that is his due. (16) Finally, no one makes an effort to acquit a confessed criminal. In the case of the Christian, you regard him as guilty of every crime, the enemy of the gods, rulers, laws, morals, and all nature. Yet you force him into a denial that you may acquit him. (17) You are making a sham of the laws. Whence comes this perversity of yours?

(18) Since, then, you treat us differently from other criminals in every respect, having in mind one object only, that we be cut off from that name, you can understand that there is no crime at all in our case; it is a question merely of a name.[18] This name a certain power of a rival agency persecutes, making this its first and foremost aim, that people may be unwilling to obtain certain knowledge about that of which they are certain they have no knowledge. (19) Hence it is that they believe stories about us that are not proved and they do not want any investigation, lest it be proved that the stories they prefer to have believed are not true. It follows that the name, an object of enmity to that rival agency, is condemned by its mere admission because of crimes presumed, not proved. (20) But if the term "Christian" involves in itself no element of guilt, it is extremely ridiculous that the charge is one of name only.

CHAPTER 3

(1) What of the fact that many, with eyes shut, stumble so blindly over their hatred of the name that, even when they speak favorably of someone, they insert some hateful remark about this name? "Caius Seius is a good man, except that he is a Christian." No one stops to think whether Caius is good because he is a Christian, or is a Christian because he is good! (2) People praise what they know and find fault with what they do not know. (3) Others censure as vagrant, good-for-nothing scoundrels those whom they knew in the past, before they acquired this name, and they censure them in the very act of

18. Tertullian's discussion of the name has parallels in both Justin, *Apology* I 4, and Athenagoras, *Plea* 2.1–4.

praising them. In the blindness of their hatred they stumble into approving the Christians. "That woman! How dissolute and frivolous she was! And that young man, how much more prodigal and debauched he used to be! They have become Christians."[19] Thus, the name that was responsible for their reformation is set down as a charge against them. (4) To the degree that one is reformed under the influence of the name, he gives offense. The Christians' goodness is outweighed by the hatred borne them.

(5) Well, then, if it is simply the name that is hated, what guilt can attach to names? What fault can be found with words except that something in the word sounds rough or unlucky or abusive or immodest? The term "Christian," on the other hand, as far as its etymology goes, is derived from "unction." Even when you mispronounce it "Chrestian"—for your knowledge of the word itself is uncertain—it is made up of "sweetness" or "kindness."[20] Hence, in harmless people even a harmless name is hated.

(6) But, I suppose, the religion is hated in the name of its founder. Is it anything new that some way of life gives to its followers the name of its teacher? Are not philosophers called Platonists, Epicureans, Pythagoreans after their founders? (7) No

19. The physician Galen, writing in the middle of the second century, provides a literary witness to Tertullian's record here, that some pagans noted the moral improvement in the lives of those who became Christians; see Wilken, *Christians as the Romans Saw Them,* 79–80. There also, however, appears to be pagan literary witness to the contrasting belief that Christians were morally dissolute; see n. 38, below, and Robert D. Sider, *The Gospel and its Proclamation,* Message of the Fathers of the Church, vol. 10 (Wilmington, Del.: Michael Glazier, 1983; distributed by the Liturgical Press, Collegeville, Minn.), 17–19. For the expression "they have become Christians" *(facti sunt Christiani),* see n. 11, above, and n. 79, below.

20. "Christian" is from the Latin *Christianus,* which is itself a formulation from the Greek *christos,* related to the Greek verb "to anoint." Through similarity of sound *christos* could easily be confused with a quite different Greek adjective, *chrestos,* "virtuous," "benevolent," "good." Though it is very likely that in popular parlance Christians were sometimes called "chrestians," the literary evidence sometimes cited from Suetonius, *Claudius* 25.4, and Tacitus, *Annals* 15.44, in support of Tertullian's claim is open to question; see Benko, "Pagan Criticism," *Aufstieg und Niedergang,* part II, vol. 23.2, 1056–63, or *Pagan Rome,*18–19; but cf. Wilken, *Christians as the Romans Saw Them,* 50 n. 2.

one takes offense at the profession of a name that has been handed down by a teacher together with his teaching. Of course, if anyone will prove that a school is bad and its founder likewise bad, he will prove also that the name is bad and deserves hatred because of the worthless character of the school and its founder. Consequently, before hating a name, it would have been fitting first to look for the character of the school in its founder or the character of the founder in his school. (8) But, in this case, investigation and knowledge of both are neglected. The name is seized upon; the name is assailed; although this religion and its founder are unknown, a word alone condemns Christians in advance because of the name they bear, not because they are convicted of anything.

[The law that forbids Christians to exist must be examined: unjust laws can and must be changed.]

CHAPTER 4

(1) Now that I have set down these remarks as a preface, as it were, to stigmatize the injustice of the public hatred against us, I shall take the stand to defend our innocence. Not only shall I refute the charges that are brought against us, but I shall even hurl them back upon those who make them, so that people may thereby know that among the Christians those crimes do not exist which they know exist among themselves; and that, at the same time, they may blush when they accuse those who—as they like to think—are their equals.[21]

(3) Inasmuch as, in the last resort, the authority of the law is hurled against truth in such a way that either there is nothing to be said after the law has been appealed to, or with you the necessity of obedience takes precedence to regard for the truth,[22] I shall therefore first discuss with you the question of the law, since you are its protectors. (4) In the first place, then, when you lay down the law and say: "Your existence is illegal!" and when you prescribe this rule without any further investigation,

21. I.e., their equals in vice.

22. Cf. Terence, *Andria* 68, "Obedience procures friends, truth brings hatred." The line is quoted by Cicero in *On Friendship* 24.89.

you make profession of violence and of an unjust, tyrannical domination, if you are saying that Christianity is illegal simply because that is your will, not because it really ought to be illegal. (5) Unquestionably that ought to be illegal which is evil, and from this very fact it is a foregone conclusion that what is good is legal. If I find that something is good that a law of yours has forbidden, is the law not powerless to keep me from doing that? If a law of yours has erred, it is, I presume, because it was conceived by human beings; it certainly did not fall from heaven.

(6) Is it any wonder to you that a man may have erred in making a law or that he recovered his senses and rejected it? (7) As your research daily throws more light upon the darkness of former days, do you not cut and hew all that old, overgrown forest of laws with the new axes of imperial rescripts and edicts? (9) The law used to be that those found guilty of bankruptcy might be cut in pieces by their creditors. Yet, by common consent, this cruel stipulation was later abrogated, and capital punishment was exchanged for a mark of disgrace.[23] (10) How many of your laws lie hidden that still need to be reformed—laws which are not recommended by length of years or the high position of him who framed them, but solely by their profession of justice! When they are recognized as being unjust, they deserve to be condemned, even when they themselves condemn. (13) No law has to render an account of its own justice solely to itself, but to those from whom it expects observance. Besides, a law is under suspicion if it refuses to submit to examination; it is worthless if it demands obedience without examination.

CHAPTER 5

(1) Let us consider to some extent the origin of laws of this sort.[24] (3) Consult your histories: you will find in them that

23. The "Twelve Tables," the earliest code of Roman law (451–50 B.C.) included legislation with severe penalties for debtors. Aulus Gellius, *Attic Nights* 20.1.19, 42–52, describes the law on bankruptcy mentioned here. See also Quintilian, *Education of an Orator (Institutio oratoria)* 3.6.84. In the chapter cited, Aulus Gellius represents Roman attitudes toward legal reform that are similar to those expressed here by Tertullian.

24. The search for the legal basis of the persecutions against Christians has been long and intense. Timothy Barnes found no evidence of an early imperial edict condemning Christians; he argued that Christians were condemned be-

Nero was the first to rage with the imperial sword against this religion, which was just at that particular time coming to life at Rome.[25] We actually glory that such a person took the lead in condemning us. For whoever knows him can understand that nothing except some magnificent good was ever condemned by Nero. (4) Domitian, too, somewhat of a Nero in cruelty, made some attempts. But—being also, to a certain degree, human—he soon put a halt to what he had initiated and even recalled those whom he had exiled. Such have always been our persecutors, unjust, wicked, depraved men whom you yourselves are accustomed to condemn.

(5) But of so many emperors from that time down to our own day who were wise in matters divine and human, show me one who persecuted the Christians! (6) On the contrary, we can point out our protector, if you will examine the letters of the most venerable emperor, Marcus Aurelius. In these letters he attests that the great drought in Germany was relieved by rain that fell in answer to the prayers of the Christians who happened to be in his army. Although he did not openly revoke the edict of persecution from these men, yet in another way he openly counteracted its effect, by threatening their persecutors with a sentence that was actually more horrible.[26] (7) What sort of laws, then, are those that are set in operation against us only by emperors who are wicked and devoid of justice, base and im-

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cause they were thought to threaten the moral foundation of Roman political and social life, and that the practice of condemning Christians had arisen early and had found an authoritative base in Trajan's Rescript to Pliny ("Legislation Against the Christians," *Journal of Roman Studies* 58 [1968]: 32–50). Paul Keresztes, on the other hand, believes that Christians were indeed condemned on the basis of an early imperial edict, and, very likely, subsequent supporting rescripts ("The Imperial Government and the Christian Church," *Aufstieg und Niedergang*, part II, vol. 23.2: 273–78). See also W. H. C. Frend, *Martyrdom and Persecution in the Early Church* (New York, N.Y.: New York University Press, 1967), 124–30. For Trajan's "rescript" (i.e., *Ep.* 10. 97), see the appendix.

25. Cf. Tacitus, *Annals* 15.44. Tacitus briefly describes the origin of the Christian "sect" and their terrible punishment when they were suspected of having set the great fire of Rome in A.D. 64. Some have inferred from Nero's action that an imperial edict making Christianity illegal was at that time issued by the emperor.

26. The accuser was to be burned alive.

pious, deceptive[27] and mentally deranged? These are the laws that Trajan nullified in part by forbidding that a search be made for Christians, laws which no Hadrian, no Vespasian, no Pius, no Verus ever enforced![28]

CHAPTER 6

(1) Now, I should like the most scrupulous guardians and avengers of the laws and institutions of our forefathers to answer whether they have been faithful to all of them, whether they have in no respect deviated from any of them, or caused any necessary and appropriate matters of discipline to be forgotten. (2) What has become of those laws that restrained extravagance and bribery, that forbade the spending of more than a hundred asses on a supper, or the serving of more than one hen—and

27. "Deceptive": *vani*, but the word can also mean "boastful," "vainglorious," possibly referring here to Nero's artistic pretensions and Domitian's claim to divinity.

28. In this survey of Roman rulers, Tertullian includes most of the emperors from Nero (A.D. 54–68) to Marcus Aurelius (161–80). The list is generally chronological, with some exceptions due evidently to literary design: Vespasian (69–79) and his son Titus (79–81) were followed by Domitian (81–96); after Nerva's brief rule (96–98) came Trajan (98–117), Hadrian (117–38), and Antoninus Pius (138–61). Lucius Varus, by adoption brother of Marcus Aurelius, shared the imperial rule with Marcus from 161 until his death in 169, though Tertullian here apparently means Marcus Aurelius Verus himself.

The interpretation that "good" emperors protected the Christians while the bad emperors persecuted them became an apologetic commonplace (cf. Lactantius, *On the Deaths of the Persecutors* 2–9). The evidence does not, however, support the interpretation: there were, in fact, some notable martyrdoms, including that of Justin Martyr, during the reign of the "good" Marcus Aurelius. Letters from Hadrian to Minucius Fundanus, the Proconsul of Asia, in 122–23 did, it is true, denounce informers and insisted that the charge of being a Christian had to be proved in court, but letters purporting to come from Antoninus Pius and Marcus Aurelius on behalf of the Christians are generally regarded as spurious; these letters became attached to Justin's *First Apology*, where they are found immediately after Hadrian's Rescript, and are translated by Joseph B. Falls in *The Writings of Justin Martyr*, FOTC, vol. 6 (New York, N.Y.: Christian Heritage, 1948), 108–11. Pagan literature (cf. Cassius Dio, *Roman History* 72.8) attests the storm that saved the Thundering legion in Germany in 172 or 174, an event that is also depicted on the column of Marcus Aurelius in the Piazza Colonna in Rome. The event provided a theme for pagan literature and was "christianized" by Apollinaris, an early Christian apologist and predecessor of Tertullian; see Grant, *Greek Apologists*, 83–85.

that an unfattened one?[29] (3) I observe that suppers now have to be called "centenarian" because of the 100,000 sesterces expended on them.[30] (4) As regards women, those customs of our ancestors that protected their modesty and sobriety have fallen into disregard. Why, no woman was acquainted with any gold except that on the one finger—the gold her spouse had given as a pledge in the engagement ring.[31](6) What has become of that conjugal happiness so fostered by high moral living that for nearly six hundred years after Rome was founded no home sued for a divorce? Look at women now. Every limb is weighed down with gold; yes, and now it is a divorce that is prayed for, as though that were the natural issue of marriage! (7) Even the decrees that your fathers had prudently passed respecting your very gods, you, their most dutiful sons, have abolished. The consuls, with full approval of the Senate, drove Father Bacchus and his mysteries not only from Rome but from all Italy.[32] (8) During the consulship of Piso and Gabinius,[33] Serapis, Isis, and Harpocrates with his dog-headed Anubis were expelled from the solemn assembly of the gods.[34] These gods *you* have restored,

29. Aulus Gellius names some of these sumptuary laws; see *Attic Nights* 2.24 and 20.1.23–24.

30. One sesterce was originally equal to two and a half asses, of which, Tertullian has just noted, not more than one hundred were, according to the law, to be spent on a dinner.

31. At betrothal the fiancé gave his prospective bride a ring as a pledge of the promise to be fulfilled. The fiancée wore it on the fourth finger of her left hand.

32. The reference is to the Bacchanalia (rites in honor of Bacchus), a term for the Dionysiac "revels" that came to Italy as early as the fifth century B.C.; as a result of the disorder they brought to Rome, the Senate repressed them in 186 B.C.; cf. Livy, *History of Rome* 39.8–19. Though these revels were evidently in some sense "mysteries," they are differentiated from the later Dionysiac mysteries that had, however, by the first century A.D. become popular in Italy.

33. In 58 B.C. Piso was father-in-law to Julius Caesar; a vivid, if rhetorical, portrait of both Piso and Gabinius has come down to us in Cicero's speech *In Defense of Publius Sestius* 9.

34. Serapis, Isis, and Harpocrates were Egyptian deities, generally worshiped together in the cult, which sometimes included Anubis. Serapis, introduced into Egypt ca. 300 B.C., was a god of the underworld and represented the hope of new life, as did Isis, a god of healing and restoration. Harpocrates (=Horus), child of Isis and Osiris (= Serapis), was a very popular divinity among the common people. Anubis was the god of embalming and guide of the dead to the underworld. The cult of these gods was spread widely over the Greco-Ro-

conferring upon them the utmost dignity.[35] (9) By your dress, your food, your manner of living, your attitude of mind, in fine, by your very speech, you have renounced your forefathers. With respect to the traditions of your fathers that you appear to be keeping most faithfully—I refer to your devotedness in worshiping the gods—I will show in its proper place[36] that these traditions are being despised, neglected, and destroyed by you in contradiction to the precedent set by your ancestors. (11) I will now reply to that infamous charge about our clandestine crimes, that I may clear my path for those that are more manifest.

[Tertullian now undertakes to answer the charges against the Christians. He turns first to those based on rumor: the charges are murder and incest, but he shows that the charges are improbable and evidence is utterly lacking. In fact, the pagans are accusing Christians of crimes the pagans themselves commit.]

CHAPTER 7

(1) We are spoken of as utter reprobates, and are accused of murdering babies in a holy rite[37] and then eating them, and of committing adulterous acts after the repast. (2) We are always spoken of in this way,[38] yet you take no pains to bring into the light the evidence for the charges that for so long a time have

man world. Apuleius, a second-century pagan from North Africa, witnesses to the profound devotion Isis, as a Saviour goddess, could inspire among pagans; see his *Metamorphoses,* Book 11. For Roman attitudes toward foreign religions and for legislation on the Bacchanalia and the Isis cults, see Frend, *Martyrdom and Persecution,* 77–86.

35. Cassius Dio, *Roman History* 47.15, records that a temple to Isis and Serapis was voted in 43 B.C.

36. Cf. chapters 13–15.

37. "In a holy rite": *sacramenti. Sacramentum* is an important word with several meanings in Tertullian's vocabulary. In chapter 2, above, it is translated "religious rites" ("he [Pliny] had learned nothing about their religious rites" [p. 11]); in *The Crown* 11, it is translated "oath of fidelity" (p. 129). Debate continues over the meaning of the word in early Christianity; see René Braun, *Deus Christianorum: Recherches sur le vocabulaire doctrinal de Tertullien,* 2d ed. (Paris: Études Augustiniennes, 1977), 435–43, and the article "Sacrament," in Everett Ferguson, ed., the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity,* 2d ed., 2 vols. (New York, N.Y.: Garland, 1997), with its extensive bibliography.

38. Such charges, coming from pagans, may have been common, but Chris-

been made against us. Now, either bring it into the light, if you believe the charges, or stop believing them, inasmuch as you have not brought the deeds to light! Because of your hypocrisy, the objection is made against you that the evil does not exist which you yourselves dare not bring to light.

(3)The origin of this religion dates from the time of Tiberius. Truth and hatred came into existence simultaneously.[39] As soon as the former appeared, the latter began its enmity. It has as many foes as there are outsiders. (4) Day by day we are besieged; day by day we are betrayed; oftentimes, in the very midst of our meetings and gatherings, we are surprised by an assault. (5) Who has ever come upon a baby wailing, as the accusation has it?[40] Who has ever kept for the judge's inspection the jaws of Cyclopes and Sirens,[41] bloodstained as he had found them? Who has ever found any traces of impurity upon [Christian] wives? Who has discovered such crimes, yet concealed them or been bribed to keep them secret? Whence the betrayal of our crimes? (6) Who could have been the traitors? Certainly not the accused themselves, since the obligation of pledged silence is binding upon all mysteries by their very nature.[42]

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tians also leveled them against other Christian groups perceived to be heterodox. A full account of the use of these charges by pagan and Christian alike is given in Clarke, *Octavius,* notes 116–22 to pages 64–65.

39. Cf. Terence, *Andria* 68: "truth brings hatred"; cf. n. 22, above. Tiberius was emperor from A.D. 17–37, at the time, therefore, of the origin of Christianity.

40. Some of the elements of Tertullian's response in chapters 7–9 to pagan suspicions have parallels in Athenagoras, *Plea* 31–36. Justin alludes to the pagan suspicion of incest and cannibalism, and offers a brief and somewhat indirect response in his first *Apology* 26–29.

41. Cyclopes and Sirens appear early in Greek literature as destroyers of human beings. See Homer, *Odyssey* 9.105–542 (Cyclopes, who are male figures) and 12.37–54, 165–200 (Sirens, female figures); the Cyclopes, savages who live without laws, devour men, while the Sirens entice travelers to come their way, and consequently cause them to perish in shipwrecks on the rocks nearby.

42. For the silence required of initiates into the mysteries, see Marvin W. Meyer, ed., *The Ancient Mysteries: A Sourcebook* (San Francisco, Calif.: Harper and Row, 1987), 4–5. Meyer finds the origin of the word "mystery" in the Greek *myein* "to close the eyes" (cf. "myopic"), and, by extension, "to close the lips." In his *Exhortation to the Greeks* 4, Clement of Alexandria introduces a long exposé of the pagan mysteries with an ironic reference to the initiates' obligation to silence and their necessary refusal to disclose what they have seen.

(7) If, then, Christians themselves are not the betrayers, it follows that outsiders are. Whence do outsiders get their knowledge, since even holy initiation rites always ban the uninitiated and are wary of witnesses? (8) The nature of rumor is well known to all. It was your own poet who said: "Rumor, an evil surpassing all evils in speed."[43] Why call rumor an evil? Because it flies? Because it testifies? Or because it generally lies? Even when it has a modicum of truth in it, rumor is not free from some taint of falsehood; it detracts from, adds to, or deviates from the truth; (9) and its life endures only so long as there is no proof. Having, as it were, fulfilled its office of reporting the news, it passes it on as a fact. From then on the story is considered a fact, and called a fact. (11) Does anyone except the unthinking believe rumor? (14) Rumor alone, then, is the witness you bring forth against us. What it has sometime or other spread abroad, and over such an interval of time has hardened into a matter of opinion, it has not yet been able to prove.

CHAPTER 8

Now, to appeal to the reliable witness of nature itself against those who assume that such accusations are credible: (1) look! we set up a reward for these crimes—they promise eternal life.[44] For the time being, believe it! On this point I have a question to ask: If you believed it, would you consider the acquisition of eternal life worth attaining with such a troubled conscience? (2) Come, bury your sword in this baby; or, if that is the other fellow's job, stand here beside this [bit of] humanity, dying before it has lived; wait for the young soul to take flight; receive the fresh blood; saturate your bread in it; partake freely! (3) Meanwhile, as you recline at table, note the place where your mother is, and your sister; note it carefully, so that, when the dogs cause darkness to fall, you may make no mistake![45] (4) Initiated and sealed in such mysteries as these, you live forever! I

43. Virgil, *Aeneid* 4.174.

44. Following the text of *Corpus Christianorum*, I take this sentence to introduce chapter 8 and to indicate that Tertullian wishes to appeal to nature (i.e., instinct) in making the argument that follows.

45. For the allusion to dogs, see next note.

wish you would tell me if eternity is worth such a price; if it isn't, these crimes should not be believed. Even if you believed them, I tell you that you would not want to commit them. Even if you wanted to, I tell you you couldn't. If you cannot do these things, you ought not to believe them of Christians. For a Christian, too, is a human being even as you are.

(6) "But," you say, "without realizing it, they are deceived and imposed upon." They were unaware that they should examine and investigate the matter with all vigilance. (7) Yet, I suppose, it is customary for those who wish to be initiated to approach first the father of the sacred rites to arrange what must be prepared. Then he says, "Now, you need a baby, still tender, one who will smile under your knife. You need bread, too, with which to gather up his juicy blood; besides that, candlesticks, lamps, some dogs, and bits of meat that will draw them on to overturn the lamps.[46] Most important of all, you must come with your mother and sister." (8) But, what if the latter are unwilling to come, or you do not have any? (9) What if all those preparations are made without the foreknowledge of those concerned? At any rate, after once experiencing it, they know of it and support and condone the procedure. "They are afraid of being punished if they make it known." Well, they would prefer to die outright rather than live with such crimes upon their consciences.

CHAPTER 9

(1) To refute these points at greater length, I will point out that you yourselves commit these very crimes—sometimes openly, sometimes secretly—and that, perhaps, is the reason why you have believed them also of us. (2) In Africa, babies used to be sacrificed publicly to Saturn (3) and even now this

46. The image is found in the *Octavius* of Minucius Felix (9.6) where the supposed criminal banquets are explained in more detail: "After . . . passion . . . has been fired by drunkenness, a dog which has been tied to a lamp stand is tempted by throwing a morsel beyond the length of the leash by which it is bound. It makes a dash, and jumps for the catch. Thus . . . the witnessing light has been overturned and extinguished . . ." (*Tertullian, Apologetical Works, and Minucius Felix, Octavius,* trans. Rudolph Arbesmann, Sister Emily Joseph Daly, and Edwin A. Quain, FOTC, vol. 10 [Washington, D.C.: The Catholic University of America Press, 1950], 337).

holy crime is continued in secret.[47] (5) Among the Gauls, older persons were sacrificed to Mercury.[48] In that city of the pious race of Aeneas, there is a certain Jupiter whom they bathe in human blood during the games held in his honor.[49] "But it is the blood of a beast-fighter," you say. At any rate, it is blood shed in murder.

(6) But, with regard to infanticide, how many, do you suppose, of those here present who stand panting for the blood of Christians want me to touch their consciences for putting their own offspring to death? (7) If there is some distinction in kind between one act of murder and another, it is certainly more cruel to kill by drowning or by exposure to cold, hunger, and the dogs. (8) But, with us, murder is forbidden once for all. We are not permitted to destroy even the fetus in the womb. To prevent the birth of a child is a quicker way to murder. It makes no difference whether one destroys a soul already born or interferes with its coming to birth. It is a human being and one who is to be a person, for the whole fruit is already present in the seed.[50]

47. Saturn was seen to be the equivalent of the Semitic Baal-Hammon. Like other Semitic peoples, the Carthaginians had practiced child-sacrifice, but it is doubtful that the practice of human sacrifice continued until Tertullian's day. For the arguments see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 15–18, 324.

48. The Celtic Teutates was identified with the Roman Mercury, god of commerce, and Mars, god of war. Ancient sources imply that human sacrifices were made to this god; cf. Lucan, *Civil War* 1.444–45, and Augustine, *City of God* 7.19, who cites Varro (first century B.C.) reporting human sacrifices in Gaul. Barnes claims that "human sacrifice in Gaul was suppressed very early" (*Tertullian,* 15–18).

49. The "city of . . . Aeneas" is Rome, which at an early period became the political center of Latium, i.e., of the Latin peoples. The cult of Jupiter Latiaris, that is, the Jupiter belonging to Latium, was observed at a festival of the Latin peoples on the Alban mount (Mount Cavo), on whose summit was a temple of Jupiter. At the festival his statue was bathed in the blood of a criminal who had been condemned to the beasts and killed in the amphitheater; cf. J.-P. Waltzing, *Tertullien, Apologetique: Commentaire analytique, grammatical et historique* (Paris: Société d'Édition "Les Belles Lettres," 1931), 72. See the treatise *Scorpiace* (7.6), where Tertullian says that Jupiter Latiaris is given human blood to taste.

50. Christians denounced abortion from a very early period; cf. the *Epistle of Barnabas* 19.5 (early second century) and *Didache* 2.2 (probably second century). See also Tertullian, *On the Soul* 37.2; 25.4–5 (FOTC, vol. 10, 266 and 238).

(9) As for bloody food and such tragic dishes: today, right here among you, to mark the devotees of Bellona, a thigh is slashed, the blood is taken in the hand and given them for their benefit.[51] Again, consider those who, at a show in the arena, take the fresh blood of wicked criminals as it runs down from their throats and carry it off to heal their epilepsy.[52] (11) And what about those who make a meal on the flesh of wild beasts taken from the arena—the boar that has licked the blood off him whom he has spattered with blood in the struggle; the bears, still stuffed with undigested human flesh. (12) You who eat these animals, how far removed are you from the banquets of the Christians? (13) Let your unnatural ways blush before the Christians. We do not even have the blood of animals at our meals; we refrain from eating the meat of any animals that have been strangled or that die of themselves, lest we be in any way contaminated with blood, even if it is hidden in the flesh.[53]

(16) Another point: Who are more expert at practicing incest than those whom Jupiter himself has instructed?[54] (17) Consider also how great chance there is for incestuous unions occasioned by mistaken identity. You expose your children to be taken up by some passerby. Sooner or later, the memory of the original family fades away. As soon as a mistake has occurred, the transmission of incest goes on. (18) Finally, wherever you are, at home, abroad, across the sea, your lust travels as your companion, and its outbursts everywhere can easily beget children for you anywhere at all. The result is that a brood thus scattered through illicit human intercourse may fall

51. Bellona, Roman goddess of war, was sometimes represented as the wife of Mars, the god of war. Her priests held wild processions, inflicting wounds on their arms and thighs, offering the blood from the wounds as a sacrifice and sipping it. The deep impression made by the ritual is suggested by the frequent allusions to it in Latin literature; cf. Virgil, *Aeneid* 8.703, and the *Historia Augusta,* Commodus" 9.5. See also Tibullus, *Poems* 1.6.45–50, Juvenal, *Satires* 4.123–24, and Lucan, *Civil War* 1.565–66.

52. Human blood was thought to have the power to cure epilepsy. Pliny, *Natural History* 28.2.4, describes the action of epileptics at a gladiatorial show.

53. An allusion to the decree of the Council of Jerusalem; cf. Acts 15:20, 29.

54. In Greek mythology Zeus, whom the Romans identified with Jupiter, was husband to his sister Hera, identified with the Roman Juno, and thus the divine exemplar of incest.

in with its own kindred and in blind ignorance fail to recognize it as begotten of incestuous blood.[55]

(19) As for us, an ever-watchful and steadfast chastity shields us from such an occurrence and, in so far as we refrain from adultery and every excess after marriage, we are safe, too, from the danger of incest. (20) If you would realize that these sins exist among yourselves, then you would perceive clearly that they do not exist among Christians. The same eyes would tell you the facts in both cases. But a two-fold blindness easily imposes itself, so that those who do not see what does exist seem to see what does not. I will point out that this is true in everything. Now I will speak of the more manifest crimes.

[The response to charges of "more manifest crimes." To respond to the first charge—"Christians do not worship the gods"—Tertullian directs attention to the nature of the gods of the pagans. Against the charge that Christians do not worship the pagan gods, he argues that the so-called gods do not exist, but are merely dead people who have been given certain honors thought to be appropriate to those who have served their fellow-citizens well. He goes on to show (chapters 13–15) that in virtually every facet of their lives pagans treat their gods with outrageous disrespect, and thus belie their claim to believe in the divinity of their gods. Artistically, the section establishes a lurid backdrop through a portrait of irrational and degraded behavior arising from pagan belief and worship. Against this backdrop the subsequent explication of the Christians' God will stand out sharply with luster and authority.]

CHAPTER 10

(1) "You do not worship the gods," you say, "and you do not offer sacrifice for the emperors." It follows that we do not offer sacrifices for others for the same reason that we do not do it even for ourselves—it follows immediately from our not worshiping the gods. Consequently, we are met with the charges of sacrilege and of treason. This is the chief accusation against

55. As, for example, Oedipus as represented in Sophocles' play. On the sin of exposing children, see Justin, *Apology* I 27 and 29.

us—in fact, it is the whole case—and it certainly deserves investigation.

(2) We ceased worshiping your gods from the time we discovered that they are non-existent. This, then, is what you ought to demand, that we prove that those gods are non-existent and for this reason should not be worshiped. Only then ought the Christians to be punished if the fact were established that those gods do exist. (3) "But for us," you say, "the gods do exist." We object and appeal from you to your conscience. Let your conscience pass judgment on us, let it condemn us, if it can deny that all those gods of yours have been mere human beings.[56] (4) Testimony is furnished to this very day by the cities in which they were born, and the regions in which they left traces of something they had done and in which it is pointed out that they were buried.

(6) It would be wearisome to call the roll of all the deities, but to sum up the whole situation: before the advent of Saturn there was no god among you. With him starts the roster of all your divinities. Now, whatever is established about their beginnings will apply also to their posterity. (7) As for Saturn, as far as literature tells us, no writer on antiquities has pronounced him other than a mere man. As far as arguments drawn from fact go, I find none more trustworthy than this: Saturn was welcomed by Janus right in Italy itself, where he finally took his abode after much traveling to and fro. (8) The mountain that he made his home was called the Saturnian. The city that he founded is called, even to the present day, Saturnia. The art of writing was first established there by him, and coins were struck with his image. Hence, he presides over the treasury.[57] (9) How-

56. Tertullian argues here from the doctrine of "euhemerism." Euhemerus, a Greek-speaker of the late third/early second century B.C., wrote a novel of travel that described a utopia wherein it was affirmed that the great gods had originally been kings, therefore men. About a century later, the Roman Ennius wrote a Latinized version of Euhemerus' work, thus introducing into Latin literature a theory that became popular among pagans and to which Christians frequently referred; cf. Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* 1.11, and Augustine, *City of God* 7.27.1–2. Athenagoras believed the idea was derived from Egyptian priests; cf. the *Plea* 28–30.

57. The story of Saturn's wanderings is briefly told in Minucius Felix, *Octavius* 21.4–6. Cast out of Olympus by Zeus, he came to the site of the future

ever, if Saturn was a man, he certainly was born of human parents. If his parents were unknown, it was easy for him to be called the child of those from whom all of us too may claim birth, that is, from heaven his father and earth his mother.[58] Moreover, those who make an unexpected appearance are said to have dropped from the sky. (10) Therefore, inasmuch as Saturn suddenly appeared everywhere, he happened to be called the "Heavenly One." (11) That is enough now about Saturn.

CHAPTER 11

(1) While you dare not deny that the gods were once human beings, you have made it your practice to affirm that after their death they became gods. Let us go back over the causes that have brought this about. (2) In the first place, you have to grant that there is some god more sublime, one who has, as it were, the proprietary rights to divinity, who has made gods out of human beings. The gods could not have assumed a divinity they did not possess unless the proprietary god had it in his own right. (4) So, if there is someone who could make gods, I come back to examine the reasons why anyone would make gods out of human beings. I find no other reason except that the great god desired ministers and assistants in his divine functions. But, in the first place, it would be beneath his dignity to need the services of anyone—least of all the dead. (5) Neither do I see what service is needed, for this whole fabric of the universe has been found undoubtedly in its very concept to have been once and for all arranged, equipped, ordered with the governing power of absolute reason. That which has perfected all things could not be imperfect: (6) nothing awaited Saturn. (7) Moreover, the gods are said to have discovered, not devised, those things necessary to sustain life. But, whatever is discovered existed before it could be discovered. (9) Therefore, if from the beginning the universe has stood devised and arranged with

Rome, built a fortified village called, in the tradition, Saturnia, and taught the local inhabitants the arts of civilization. In classical times the temple of Saturn in the Roman forum housed the state treasury.

58. For the notion, familiar in classical antiquity, of earth as universal mother, see Virgil, *Aeneid* 6.595.

fixed laws for exercising its functions, the argument for admitting human beings into the ranks of divinity on this ground is void, because the positions and powers that you have attributed to them were in existence from the beginning.

(10) But you reply that the conferring of divinity was a means of rewarding their services. On this point you grant, I suppose, that the god who makes gods possesses justice in a superior degree, since he has not recklessly nor undeservedly nor extravagantly bestowed such a great reward. (11) But see whether the services of these people are of a kind not to exalt them to heaven but to plunge them into the abyss of Tartarus, that prison of infernal punishment where (12) the dead are relegated—those who are shameless toward their parents, who commit incest with their sisters, who seduce married women, rape young girls and defile young boys, who commit sins of cruelty, murder, robbery, and fraud.[59] (13) Such disgraceful marks upon these people are an additional reason for our not believing that they afterwards became gods. For you yourselves sit in judgment to punish such persons—men of the very sort whom that god of yours has joined to himself to share in his majesty.

CHAPTER 12

(1) As for your gods, then, I see in them merely the names of certain people long dead. I hear their stories and recognize the sacred rituals arising from these myths. (2) As for their statues, I find no fault with them, except that the material used in them matches that in common pots and household utensils. The free hand of art transforms them and treats them thereby with utmost insult, adding sacrilege in the very act of transformation. Actually, for us who are beaten because of these very gods, it could be a particular source of comfort in our punishments that they themselves, in order to become gods, undergo

59. Pagans could find in Virgil a classic portrait of Tartarus as a place of infernal punishment; cf. *Aeneid* 6.548–627. Further, many of the sins listed here they would attach to Jupiter himself, as identified with the Greek Zeus, who according to mythology overthrew his father Cronos, married his sister Hera, seduced Leda (among others), raped the girl Danae, and abducted the boy Ganymede.

the same harsh treatment as ourselves.[60] (6) Obviously, your gods are insensible to these injuries and the demeaning insults associated with their manufacture, even as they are insensible to your homage. (7) Therefore, if we do not adore cold statues and images made in the likeness of their dead originals, statues with which the kites and mice and spiders are well acquainted, is it not praise rather than punishment that we deserve for recognizing and repudiating the error? Can it seem that we are injuring those who, we are certain, have absolutely no existence?

CHAPTER 13

(1) "But for us the gods do exist," you say. Then how is it that you are found to be wicked, sacrilegious, and irreligious toward your gods, neglect those whom you presume to exist, destroy those whom you fear, and make fun of those whom you champion? (2) Tell me if I am lying. In the first place, when some of you worship one set of gods, and others another set, you certainly offend the ones whom you fail to worship. (3) You scorn those whom you reject, yet you do not fear to offend them by rejecting them. (4) As for the household gods, whom you call the Lares, you treat them with a householder's power, pawning them, selling them, or changing them, sometimes making Saturn into a cooking pan or Minerva into a ladle.[61] (5) Likewise with the public gods: under state law you disgrace them, treating them as sources of income at auction. You make your way to the Capitol just as you do to the vegetable market; it is at the same voice of the auctioneer, beneath the same hammer, under the same entry of the quaestor, that the deity is auctioned and goes to the highest bidder.[62]

(8) It is fitting for you to proclaim divine honors for emper-

60. I.e., in the process of being manufactured the gods are subject, like the Christians, to beating and to fire. Apologetic literature often noted, sometimes in mockery, that idols were merely products manufactured by human beings; cf. Justin, *Apology* I 9, Athenagoras, *Plea* 17.3, Arnobius, *Against the Nations* 6.14, and Minucius Felix, *Octavius* 22.4–7. The mockery of idols as manufactured images has biblical precedent; see Isa. 44:12–17 and Jer. 10:1–15.

61. Saturn and Minerva are included in the term "Lares," since their statues were reserved in the lararium, a type of domestic chapel in which the tutelary deities (the Lares) of the house where placed.

62. The "quaestor" was a financial official. Tertullian describes the auction in somewhat fuller detail in his slightly earlier apologetic work, *To the Nations* I

ors after their death, since even in their lifetime you award such honors. (9) But when you worship Larentina, a public harlot;[63] when you set up Simon Magus with a statue and the inscription "Holy God";[64] when you make a god out of some favorite among the court pages[65]—even though your ancient gods are not more noble, at least these latter will deem it an insult on your part that you have granted this privilege to others that in days of old was conferred on them alone.

CHAPTER 14

(1) I would like to review your religious ceremonies, too. I say nothing about what you are like when you are sacrificing:

10.20–24. According to Waltzing, *Tertullien: Apologetique,* 99, Tertullian alludes somewhat indirectly to the collection of state revenues. The collection of these revenues was "auctioned" at the highest bid to commercial companies every five years. At the auction a quaestor would assist by noting the awards. These companies then charged a fee (a tax) to (among others) merchants setting up shop in the market (in the Campus Martius) and to people who sought access to the temple. The companies paid these revenues into the temple treasury, which was, in effect, part of the public treasury.

63. There were several versions in antiquity of the story of Larentina (Acca Larentia). She was known as a prostitute who, according to Livy, *History of Rome* 1.1–7, became Romulus' nurse, according to Aulus Gellius, *Attic Nights* 7.7.5–8, Romulus' benefactor. Having become very wealthy, she made Romulus (or the Roman people) her heir. Legend connected her with the festival on Dec. 23 of the Larentalia (Ovid, *Fasti* 3.55–57). Augustine, *City of God* 6.7, following the apologetic tradition, tells the story of Larentina with mockery.

64. Tertullian apparently confuses the Simon Magus of Acts 8:9–24 with Semo, the Hercules of the Sabine people (Ovid, *Fasti* 6.213–18). Justin in *Apology* I 26 says that the Roman senate set up a statue in the reign of Claudius (A.D. 42–54) to honor Simon Magus as a god. Though it is unlikely that the senate erected any such statue, Justin may, in fact, refer to an inscription (found in 1574) with a dedication to the god Semo Sanius. Grant, *Greek Apologists,* 47–49, discusses the inscription and its use in early Christian apologetic. See also the appendix in Ovid, *Fasti,* vol. 5, trans. James George Frazer, 2d ed., revised, revising trans. G. P. Gould, Loeb Classical Library, vol. 253 (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1989), 429–30.

65. A reference to Antinous, who was born about A.D. 110 and became a favorite of Hadrian (born A.D. 76). He was drowned (A.D. 130) while accompanying Hadrian on a trip up the Nile. Hadrian had him formally enrolled among the gods, and a cult was established for him in numerous cities; Pausanius, *Description of Greece* 8.9.7–8, mentions one of these. The deification of Antinous was a stock theme among the apologists; cf. Justin, *Apology* I 29, and Athenagoras, *Plea* 30.2.

anything that has been slain and is decaying and mangy you immolate. From rich and healthy animals you chop off any useless parts,[66] like the head and hoofs, which at home you would have set aside for the slaves or dogs!

(2) Turning to your literature, whereby you are formed to wisdom and to patterns of cultivated life, what utter absurdity do I find![67] On behalf of the Trojans and Greeks, the gods joined battle and fought it out among themselves like pairs of gladiators. Venus was wounded by the arrow of a mortal man because she wanted to rescue her son, Aeneas. (3) Jupiter weeps over the misfortune of Sarpedon, lusts with a disgraceful passion for his sister. (4) After this, what poet is to be found who is not a reviler of the gods? (5) There is even one well-known lyric poet—I mean Pindar—who sings of Aesculapius, who was punished for his avarice by a thunderbolt because in his practice of medicine he did injury to people's health. (6) If these tales are true, they ought not to have been recounted; if false, they should not have been invented by god-fearing people.

(7) I pass over in silence the philosophers, satisfied merely to mention Socrates, who, as an insult to the gods, used to swear by an oak, a goat, or a dog. (9) Diogenes, too, made some sportive remark or other in reference to Hercules, and the Roman Cynic Varro introduced three hundred Joves—or perhaps I should say Jupiters—minus their heads![68]

66. I.e., useless for a pagan dinner, and so offered to the gods in the sacrifice. For the same image more precisely drawn, see *To the Nations* I 10.35.

67. To mock the pagan gods as described in literature was a commonplace of Christian apologetic; cf., e.g., Athenagoras, *Plea* 21. For the allusions that follow here, see Homer, *Iliad* 5.311–40 (Venus); *Iliad* 16.459–61 (Sarpedon); *Iliad* 14. 292–351 (lusts for Hera); Pindar, *Pythian Odes* 3.47–60 (Aesculapius).

68. For popular opinion about the "strange gods" of Socrates, see Plato, *Apology* 24D–28A and Aristophanes, *The Clouds* 239–429. Diogenes (400–325 B.C.), founder of the sect of the Cynic philosophers, is said to have written a tragedy entitled *Heracles* (cf. Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers* 6.2.80), but for Diogenes' mockery of Hercules, see Lucian, *Dialogues of the Dead* 16. Varro (116–27 B.C.), made librarian in Rome by Julius Caesar in 47 B.C., was a prolific author and became, through his forty one books on *Antiquities,* a mine of information for the Christian apologists on the subject of Italian and Roman religion; see Augustine, *City of God* 6.3. "Minus their heads" is evidently a sarcastic comment on Varro's reduction of the various gods to one single divinity, called here Jove or (his alternative name) Jupiter. But the allu-

CHAPTER 15

(1) All the other lewd people of genius, too, revile the gods for your pleasure. Consider the plays: is it the mimic actors you laugh at in their jokes and antics, or your gods? The program offers: "Anubis, the Adulterer," "Diana Drubbed," and "Three Lean Herculeses—a Laughing-Stock." (2) The text of your pantomimes, too, represents all the vileness of your gods. Sol mourns his son, cast out of high heaven—it gives you a laugh; Cybele sighs passionately for her disdainful shepherd—it causes you no blush of shame. (3) What of the fact that the face of your god covers the disgraceful and infamous head of the actor? Is not the majesty of your gods insulted and their godhead defiled by your applause?[69] (4) Of course, you are more devout in the seats of the amphitheater where, over human blood and the filth resulting from the tortures inflicted, your gods do their dancing and provide plots and stories for the guilty—except

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sion is obscure. Tertullian may wish to suggest that so many names for a single god is like so many bodies without a head; or he may be referring to the so-called Stoic god who was represented as a ball (symbolizing the world) and so had neither head nor heart (for which see Seneca, *Apocolocyntosis* 8.1). For the different interpretations, see André Schneider, *Le premier livre Ad nationes de Tertullien: Introduction, texte, traduction, et commentaire,* Bibliotheca Helvetica Romana, vol. 14 (Neuchatel: Paul Attinger S.A.,1968), 235–36 (on *Ad nationes* I 10.43).

69. Mimes and pantomimes provided some of the most popular theatrical entertainment in late Roman times. The mimes, for which actors used dialogue but no masks, were coarse and often indecent, and female roles were played by women. In the pantomime a single actor wearing mask and costume represented in dance the narrative usually of mythological love stories, and was supported by instrumentalists and a chorus, whose songs helped to interpret the action (see *Spectacles,* n. 67). For Anubis see n. 34, above, and for a vivid narrative that reveals popular acknowledgment of his adulterous ways, see Josephus, *Antiquities of the Jews* 18.3.65–80; for Diana drubbed (Juno boxed the ears of Diana [i.e., Artemis] because she supported the Trojans) see Homer, *Iliad* 21.489–92; for jests about Hercules' gluttony, see Euripides, *Alcestis* 747–59; for Phaethon, Sol's son, who crashed to the earth in a vain attempt to drive his father's horses across the sky, see Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 2.150–234, 319–28. Cybele, jealously in love with Attis, caused him to castrate himself so that he could never marry (the story has variants); the tale was told at length by the Christian apologist Arnobius, *Against the Nations* 5.5–7, and was popular among the Romans—see, for example, Catullus, *Poems* 63, and Ovid, *Fasti* 4.223–44.

that the guilty, too, often assume the roles of your gods. (5) We once saw Attis castrated, and a man who was being burned alive played the role of Hercules. We watched Jupiter's brother, too, hammer in hand, dragging away the corpses of the gladiators.[70] (7) I should add that adulteries are arranged in the temples, that pandering is carried on between the altars, that in the very abodes of the priests, they satisfy their lustful desires. Perhaps your gods have more fault to find with you than with the Christians.

[Still responding to the first charge—"Christians do not worship the gods"—Tertullian directs attention to the God of the Christians. Having passed in review an array of pagan gods, showing them to be worthy of the contempt the pagans themselves bestow on them, he is now ready to describe in contrast the Christians' God. He first counters certain false ideas of the Christian God held by the pagans (chapter 16), then offers a brief but pregnant statement of the nature of the God the Christians worship (chapter 17).]

(8) What is it, then, that Christians worship if they do not worship such things as these? This, certainly, is within your power to understand: those who do not worship falsehood worship Truth; they no longer wander in an error wherein they have recognized their mistake, and so have given it up. Grasp this point first and derive from it the whole system of our religion,[71] after your false ideas about it have been first driven away!

70. It is possible that the first person plural used here reflects Tertullian's acknowledgment of his own role as spectator in the amphitheater before his conversion; cf. in chapter 18 (p. 38), "we laughed." Tertullian alludes here to the fact that tortured and bloodstained criminals ("the guilty") became part of a *mise en scène* in which actors performed, impersonating the gods. Similarly, the victims of the combats in the arena could be made to impersonate a god, representing some aspect of the myth associated with the god—for example, Hercules who had died, burned alive as a result of putting on a poisoned robe sent to him by his wife, Dianeira; for the story see Sophocles, *The Women of Trachis*. Jupiter's brother, Pluto, is generally more or less equated with the Greek Hades, god of the underworld. The cruel act played out in the allusion here may envision a version of the myth in which Pluto is escort of the dead to the underworld. In this scene, he holds the hammer, the characteristic attribute of Charon, ferryman of the dead, who used the hammer to finish off the wounded.

71. "Religion": *sacramenti*.

CHAPTER 16

(1) Like certain others, you have foolishly imagined that the head of an ass is our God. Cornelius Tacitus sowed the seed of such an idea as this. (2) In the fourth book of his *Histories,* he began the account of the Jewish War with the origin of this race. He states that the Jews, wasting away from thirst in the deserts of Arabia, availed themselves of wild asses to guide them to a spring. In gratitude for this, they deified the head of an animal of this kind.[72] (3) From this it was presumed, I suppose, that we, too, being closely related to the Jewish religion, are devoted to the worship of this same image. But that same Cornelius Tacitus relates in the same historical work that Gnaeus Pompey, after having captured Jerusalem, approached the temple to investigate the mysteries of the Jewish religion and found no statue there.[73]

(6) Even one who considers us superstitious worshipers of a cross turns out to be, along with us, a devotee of the cross. When some piece of wood is worshiped, the appearance makes no difference, provided the quality of the material be the same; the form makes no difference, if the wood is itself the body of some god. (7) For the beginning of your gods can be traced to things fashioned by sculptors on a cross.[74] (9) Others have an idea that the sun is our god. This suspicion started when it became known that we pray facing the East. (11) Likewise, we devote Sunday to joyousness, for a reason other than that we worship the sun.

(12) A novel representation of our god has quite recently been publicized in this city, started by a certain criminal hired to dodge wild beasts in the arena. He displayed a picture with this inscription: "*Onokoites,* the god of the Christians." The figure had the ears of an ass, one foot was cloven, and it was dressed in a toga and carrying a book. We laughed at both the caption and the cartoon.[75] (14) I mention these points lest it

72. Cf. Tacitus, *Histories* 5. (not 4, as Tertullian says) 3–4.

73. Cf. Tacitus, *Histories* 5.9.

74. Justin, *Apology* I 55 and 60, also notes, though in a different manner, that the cross is found in pagan life.

75. "Onokoites" appears to have been coined from two words which, put to-

might seem that we had purposely passed over any rumor and left it unrefuted. Turning now to the explanation of our religion, we shall clear up all these matters.

CHAPTER 17

(1) The object of our worship is the one God, who, out of nothing, simply for the glory of his majesty, fashioned this enormous universe with its whole supply of elements, bodies, and spirits, and did so simply by the Word with which he commanded, the Reason by which he arranged, the Power through which he was able to bring it all into being. (2) He is invisible, although he may be seen; beyond human grasp, though he is present to us through grace, beyond our ability to imagine, though human senses conceive of him. The force of his magnitude makes him known to human beings and yet unknown. And this is the principal transgression of those who are unwilling to recognize him of whom they cannot remain in ignorance.

[Tertullian looks for the evidence to support the Christian conception of God, first in general revelation (in the material world and in the witness of the soul), then in the special revelation given in the Hebrew Scriptures, whose prophecies have been unfailingly fulfilled and whose great antiquity gives them indubitable authenticity.]

(4) Do you wish us to prove his existence from his numerous, mighty works by which we are supported, sustained, delighted, and even startled? Do you wish us to prove him from the testimony of the soul itself? (5) The soul, though it be repressed by the prison house of the body, though it be circum-

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gether, mean "one who sleeps with (i.e., has sex with) an ass," but the meaning of this strange word has been widely disputed. For apparently the same story, see Tertullian *To the Nations* I 14. An old but interesting article, "Asinarii," in the *Dictionary of Christian Antiquities,* ed. William Smith and Samuel Cheetam (London: John Murray, 1875), 149, discusses the possible origin of this reproach and points to a "graffito" from ancient Rome that portrays on a cross a figure with an ass's head; cf. also the article, "Calumnies," op.cit., 261. The toga and book signify a teacher.

scribed by base institutions, weakened by lust and concupiscence, and enslaved to false gods, yet, when it revives, as from intoxication or sleep or some sickness, and enjoys health again, names "God" with this name alone because, properly speaking, he alone is true. "Good God!" "God Almighty!" and "God grant it!" are expressions used by the entire human race. (6) That he is a Judge, also, is testified by the phrases: "God sees" and "I commend it to God" and "God will reward me." O testimony of the soul, which is by natural instinct Christian! In fine, then, the soul, as it utters these phrases, looks not to the Capitol[76] but to heaven. It knows the abode of the living God; from him and from there it has come.[77]

CHAPTER 18

(1) But in order that we might more fully and more energetically approach God himself as well as his designs and desires, he has added the assistance of books, in case one wishes to search for God, to discover him, to believe in him, and to serve him. (2) From the beginning he sent into the world men who, because of their innocence and righteousness, were worthy to know God and to make him known to others. These men, filled with the Holy Spirit, he sent into the world that they might proclaim that there is but one God who made the universe and formed the human being from the earth; (3) that they might show forth also what signs of his sovereign power to judge he has manifested by means of rain and fire; what regulations he has prescribed for placing persons under obligation to himself; what recompense he has determined for those who are ignorant of his regulations, those who neglect them, and those who observe them, inasmuch as he is the one who, after the present life is ended, will direct his faithful followers to the reward of eternal life, but the wicked to everlasting and unending fire—

76. The Capitol was the seat of the chief of the Roman state gods.

77. Tertullian's appeal in this chapter to general revelation for our knowledge of God has its roots in the New Testament; cf. Acts 17:22–31 and Rom. 1:18–22. Tertullian devotes to the argument from the witness of the soul an entire treatise, *The Testimony of the Soul,* where, however, the dramatic setting requires that the soul should *not* be a Christian: cf. *Testimony of the Soul,* n. 9. The argument is briefly taken up by Minucius Felix, *Octavius* 18.11. See further *The Crown,* n. 27.

for all those who have died from the beginning of time will be revived, their bodies reformed; there will be a general review, and everyone will be examined according to his own merits.[78] (4) These are points at which we, too, laughed in times past. We are from your own ranks: Christians are made, not born![79]

(5) These preachers whom we mentioned are called prophets, because it is their function to foretell the future. Their words, as well as the miracles they performed to win faith in their divine mission, are preserved in the treasures of literature, and these are accessible. There is a story that the most learned of the Ptolemies, surnamed Philadelphus, well-versed in all literature, asked for books from the Jews, their own literature written in their own Hebrew tongue—books they alone possessed. (7) But, lest the knowledge of their books lie idle, the Hebrew was translated for Ptolemy by the Jews: seventy-two translators were assigned to him. (8) In this way he left these records completely translated into Greek.[80] (9) The Jews read and reread them openly. For that freedom they must pay a tax,[81] and generally they make use of it every Sabbath. He who

78. In this chapter Tertullian offers an abbreviated outline of Salvation-history as it appears in the Scriptures, which were written by "Spirit-filled men sent into the world." "Rain" and "fire" refer to such narratives as the Flood and the destruction of Sodom (Gen. 6–7 and 19), the "regulations" to the giving of the Law (cf. Ex. 20–24 and the book of Deuteronomy, which promises *passim* appropriate recompense), while the eschatological prophecies could be drawn from such passages as Ezek. 37:1–14 and Dan. 12:1–4.

79. "Christians are made, not born" *(fiunt non nascantur Christiani)* is one of Tertullian's best-known expressions; the Latin may also be rendered, "People are not born Christians, they become Christians." Cf. nn. 11 and 19, above. The antithesis implied here has a parallel in the Roman philosopher Seneca (ca. 2 B.C.–A.D. 65): "One is not born wise, but becomes wise" *(On Anger* 2.10.6). The phrase "become Christians" is also found elsewhere in Tertullian, e.g., *On Baptism* 18.5.

80. The story of the translation of the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek by seventy two (or seventy) Jews at the order of Ptolemy II (king from 282–46 B.C.) is told by Jewish writers (Philo, *Life of Moses* 2.5.25–44, and Josephus, *Jewish Antiquities* 12.2.11–118), and by Christian authors (cf., e.g., Justin in *Apology* I 31, where, however, the story is somewhat confused, and Clement of Alexandria, *Stromateis* 1.22). The translation came to be known as the Septuagint, that is, the translation of the Seventy (from the Latin *septuaginta* "seventy"; cf. Josephus, op.cit., 12.2.56–57 and 107).

81. After the capture of Jerusalem in A.D. 70, the emperor Vespasian re-

listens will find God; he who exerts himself to understand will also be led to believe.

CHAPTER 19

(1) Their great antiquity claims prime authority for these records. Among you, too, it is in accord with your superstitious ideas to make faith depend on times past.[82] (1) Moses was the first of the Prophets; he wove from the past the account of the foundation of the world and the formation of the human race and afterwards the mighty deluge; he prophesied events right up to his own day. Then, by means of the conditions of his own time, he showed forth an image of times to come. (2) Now, Moses is 1,000 years earlier than the Trojan War and, therefore, than the time of Saturn himself.[83] Other Prophets, too, more ancient than your literature have set forth many facts; even the

quired the Jews both of Palestine and of the Diaspora to pay to Rome the tax previously paid to the temple. Only those who did so had the legal right to assemble in synagogues. See E. Mary Smallwood, *The Jews under Roman Rule* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1976), 344–45.

82. For the remainder of chapter 19, I follow the text of the codex Fuldensis, one of two quite different versions of the chapter. This text, which some scholars have regarded as an earlier edition of the "vulgate" version, is considered to be less finished stylistically than the alternative version; when abbreviated as here, however, it can, I believe, reflect more vividly Tertullian's apologetic thinking than the more finished version. For the complex problems raised by the codex Fuldensis, see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 13–14 and 239–41.

83. It was a commonly held view in antiquity that the oldest cultures had the most authoritative access to the truth. The view was articulated by Hecataeus of Abdera (late fourth century B.C.) and adopted by Jewish apologetic—see, e.g., Josephus, *Contra Apionem, passim,* but especially 2.151–56. Hence, the argument from the antiquity of Moses became a commonplace of early Christian apologetic, and can be seen in Theophilus, *To Autolycus* 3.20–29, and Tatian, *Discourse to the Greeks* 31 and 36–41; for a lengthy comparative exposition of the chronology of the ancient world, see Clement of Alexandria, *Stromateis* 1.21. The apologists took their dates for events in the classical world from the grammarians (cf. the allusions in the chapters just cited from Tatian's *Discourse*). In fact, modern scholars who accept the historicity of Moses and the Trojan war usually place the former either in the thirteenth or the fifteenth century, the latter in the thirteenth also (or possibly the fourteenth). For the cultural basis of the apologists' argument, see Arthur Droge, *Homer or Moses: Early Christian Interpretations of the History of Culture* (Tubingen: J. C. B. Mohr, 1989), 11; for the apologists' dating of events, see Grant, *Greek Apologists,* 125–27.

last of the Prophets was either a little earlier or, at any rate, a contemporary of your wise men and lawmakers. (4) Zechariah lived in the reigns of Cyrus and Darius, at the time of Thales, first of the natural philosophers.[84]

I would continue to make my case in many further ways for the antiquity of the divine literature, if its trustworthiness had not found stronger support in the sheer force of its truth than in the records of antiquity. For, what will more powerfully defend the testimony of the Sacred Books than their daily fulfillment throughout the whole world, when the rise and fall of kingdoms, the fate of cities, the ruin of nations, the conditions of the times, correspond in all respects just as they were announced thousands of years ago?[85] Thus all these things that are still to occur have been verified for us because they were predicted along with events that, though they were still future when predicted, have in fact occurred.

CHAPTER 20
Omitted

[Tertullian has spoken of God's special revelation through the Hebrew Scriptures; he now proceeds to the new revelation brought by Christ, which invites an interesting statement of early Christology. In the course of chapter 21, he distinguishes the Jews, heirs to the Hebrew Scriptures, from the Christians, believers in the New Covenant.]

CHAPTER 21

(1) Since we have declared that this religion of ours depends upon very ancient Jewish records, perhaps on this ground there

84. The prophecies of Zechariah belong to the years 520–518 B.C. (cf. Zech. 1:1 and Hag. 1:1 and 2:1). Cyrus, founder of the Achaemonid Persian empire, ruled from 559–529 B.C.; Darius from 521–486 B.C. Thales (ca. 625–545 B.C.) was regarded by Aristotle as, among the Greeks, the founder of physical science.

85. The argument from the truth of prophecy played an important role in early Christian apologetic. It is one of Justin's most extensive arguments (*Apology* I 31–52). Like Tertullian here, Justin argues that the past fulfillment of prophecies is sufficient evidence that prophecies about what is still future will certainly be fulfilled (*Apology* I 52). Justin also argues that Moses was prior to pagan writers (*Apology* I 59).

should be further treatment of its status, as if, under the protecting name of a very well-known religion (and one that is, at any rate, lawful), it were concealing some claims of its own;[86] (2) because, aside from the question of age, we have nothing to do with the Jews—with regard either to the taboo on certain kinds of food, [or] the observance of certain holy days, [or] the bodily "seal,"[87] or the possession of a common name—matters upon which we certainly should agree were we subject to the same God. (3) But even the common people today know of Christ—albeit as some man, as the Jews thought him, a circumstance in virtue of which one may more readily think that we worship a mere man. Accordingly, it is necessary to speak briefly about Christ as God.[88]

(4) The Jews wholly enjoyed favor with God when both the outstanding justice and the faith of the original founders were evident. As a result, their race multiplied and their kingdom rose to exalted power. (5) But they were so filled with presumptuous confidence in their ancestors that they strayed from their teaching into the manners of the world—as the unhappy lot that today is theirs would indicate. Scattered, wandering about, deprived of land and sky of their own, they roam the earth without man or God as king.[89] (6) The holy voices that warned them of this fate all insisted always on the same points: that the day would come in the last cycles of time when God would select for himself worshipers from every race and people and place—worshipers much more faithful, to whom he would

86. For the legal position of Jews in the Roman empire, see Smallwood, *Jews under Roman Rule,* 134–36, 344–45, 472, 539. For the early identification of Christianity as a Jewish sect, see Frend, *Martyrdom and Persecution,* 81–82, 94–126.

87. I.e., circumcision.

88. For the expression "Christ as God," see n. 14, above.

89. Apparently a general allusion to the Jewish Diaspora, but probably with particular reference to the results of recent Jewish revolts. In the revolt of A.D. 66–70, the temple and much of Jerusalem was destroyed; after the later revolt of 132–35, a pagan city, Aelia Capitolina, was built on the site of the former Jerusalem, and Jews were forbidden to go near the place. Further, a revolt of Diaspora Jews in 115–17 resulted in the confiscation of Jewish property in Egypt, and Jews were banned from Cyprus. Cf. Smallwood, *Jews under Roman Rule,* 405, 413–15, 456–64.

transfer his favor in fuller measure because they were receptive of a fuller doctrine.

(7) Consequently, there came the one who God had foretold would come to renew and shed light upon that doctrine; namely, Christ, the Son of God. The Lord and Master of this grace and doctrine, the enlightener and guide of the human race, was proclaimed the Son of God, yet his birth was not such that he must blush at the name of son or the thought of paternal seed. (8) Not as the result of incestuous intercourse or the violation of another's wife has he a god for his Father—such are your deities. (9) But the Son of God has no mother in any sense that involves the violation of her purity; in fact, she who is regarded as his mother had not married. First, however, let me discuss his nature; then the manner of his birth will be understood.

(10) We have already said that God fashioned this whole world by his word, his reason, his power.[90] Even your own philosophers[91] agree that *logos,* that is, Word and Reason, seems to be the maker of the universe. This *logos* Zeno defines as the maker who formed everything according to a certain arrangement; the same *logos* (he says) is called Destiny, God, the Mind of Jupiter, and the inevitable Fate of all things. Cleanthes combines all these predicates into Spirit, which, according to him, permeates the universe.[92] (11) Moreover, to that Word, Reason, and Power by which, as we have said, God made everything, we, too, ascribe Spirit as the proper substance. For the Word in-

90. See chapter 17, above. For the exposition of Christ the divine Word as an apologetic motif, see Athenagoras, *Plea* 10 and 24, and Justin, *Apology* I 21–22, 32–51; the latter also shows how the divine Word was born of a virgin, lived, died, and rose again.

91. In particular the Stoics.

92. Zeno (335–263 B.C.) was founder of the Stoic school; Cleanthes (331–232 B.C.) was Zeno's pupil and successor as head of the Stoic school. In antiquity, Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers,* wrote the story of their lives with an account of their writings (7.1.1–5.176). Only fragments of the teachings of the Stoics remain, but their work is partially represented in some of Cicero's dialogues; cf., e.g., *On the Nature of the Gods* 1.14–15. See also Seneca, *Natural Questions* 2.45. In the Stoic view "logos," most frequently used in the sense of "reason," or "word," was active matter regarded as a rational force penetrating inert matter and thus engendering the world as we know it.

heres in the Spirit when it gives utterance,[93] Reason attends the Spirit when it arranges, Power is present to the Spirit when it accomplishes its work. This Word, as we have been taught, has been brought forth from God and, in being brought forth, has been generated, and is, therefore, called the Son of God and God on account of the unity of nature; for God, too, is Spirit. (12) When a ray is shot forth from the sun, a part is taken from the whole; but there will be sun in the ray because it is a sun ray; its substance is not separated, but extended. Thus, spirit proceeds from spirit and God from God just as light is kindled from light. The material source remains whole and unimpaired, although you derive from it numerous propagations that have its nature. (13) And so what has proceeded from God is God and the Son of God, and both are one; thus, the one being second to the other in terms of counting has effected number by gradation, not by essential condition, and he has not separated from but proceeded from the source. (14) This ray of God, then, as was ever foretold in the past, descended into a certain virgin and, formed as flesh in her womb, was born man mingled with God.[94] The flesh, provided with a soul, is nourished, matures, speaks, teaches, acts, and *is* Christ.

For the moment, accept this story—it resembles your own tales—while we show how Christ is proved and who they are who have supplied you with rival stories of the same kind that

93. Tertullian plays on the ambiguity of the Latin *spiritus*, "spirit," whose root meaning is "breath." For an analysis of the manner in which Stoic philosophy conditioned Tertullian's articulation of Trinitarian and Christological reflection, see Eric Osborn, *Tertullian, First Theologian of the West* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), 116–43.

94. "Mingled": *mixtus*. Tertullian was later to reject this word as inadequate to express the human-divine relationship in Christ, and preferred to speak of the divine and human relationship in Christ as *coniunctus* "united"; see *Against Praxeas* 27.8 and 27.11. For an exposition of this passage in the *Apology* and a discussion of its apologetic aims, see Ernest Evans, *Tertullian's Treatise Against Praxeas* (London: SPCK, 1948), 50–63. In general, Tertullian's incipient Trinitarian thought in the *Apology* finds amplification in the treatise *Against Praxeas*: for the image of the sun and its ray, and the concept of a single essence subject to number, see especially *Against Praxeas* 8. For the degree to which Tertullian anticipates the Christological formulations of a later time, see Evans, op. cit., 316–19.

aim at the destruction of such truth. (15) The Jews, too, knew that Christ would come; in fact, they were the ones to whom the Prophets spoke. Even now they are expecting his coming, and there is no stronger bone of contention between them and us than their refusal to believe that he has already come. (17) Since they considered him merely a man, it followed that they came to esteem him as a wonder-worker because of his power. For, with a word he drove evil spirits from persons, gave sight again to the blind, cleansed lepers, healed paralytics, and finally, by a word, restored the dead to life; he reduced to obedience the very elements of nature, calming storms, walking upon the water, manifesting that he was the Word of God. In other words, he is that original, first-born *Logos,* endowed with power and reason and sustained by spirit, the same who, by a mere word, still creates and did create all things. (18) As for his teaching, whereby the teachers and elders of the Jews were refuted, they were so embittered, particularly because large numbers turned aside to follow him, that they finally brought Jesus before Pontius Pilate, and with violent demands forced Pilate to hand him over to them to be crucified. He himself had foretold that they would do just this; that might be of slight account, had not the Prophets also foretold it long before. (19) Yet, fastened to the cross—the death appointed for him—he manifested many signs that distinguished his death. For he anticipated the duty of the executioner and with a word, of his own accord, he breathed forth his spirit.[95] At the same moment, although the sun was in the midst of her course, the daylight disappeared. You have this disappearance of the sun all over the world related in your own archives.[96]

(20) Then he was taken down from the cross and laid in a sepulcher. The Jews carefully surrounded the place with a large

95. Cf. John 19:28–30.

96. Tertullian may allude imprecisely to presumed official records of an extraordinary eclipse, but the reference may also be to an early version of the spurious "Acts of Pilate" that came to be incorporated into the apocryphal *Gospel of Nicodemus.* A letter of Pilate to Claudius (whose name was substituted very early for that of Tiberius) is part of the literature; cf. Wilhelm Schneemelcher, ed., *New Testament Apocrypha,* vol. 1, *Gospels and Related Writings,* rev. ed., trans., ed. R. McL. Wilson (Cambridge: James Clarke and Co., 1991), 501–36; for the letter to Claudius, see p. 527 and n. 1, and p. 536.

band of armed guards lest his disciples steal away his body and thereby trick them for all their apprehension. (21) But, lo! on the third day the earth suddenly quaked and the massive stone was rolled back. The guards were scattered in fear and, although none of his disciples appeared on the scene, there was nothing to be found in the sepulcher except the winding sheets. (22) In spite of all this, since it was to the interest of the elders to spread a false story and reclaim from their faith in Christ the tribute-paying, service-rendering people, they spread the report that the body had been stolen by the disciples. For Christ did not show himself in public. (23) However, he passed forty days with some of his disciples in Galilee, a region of Judaea, teaching them what they were to teach. Then, when they had been ordained for the office of preaching throughout the world, a cloud enveloped him and he was taken up into heaven. (24) All these facts about Christ were reported to Tiberius, the reigning emperor, by Pilate who was by now himself a Christian in heart.[97] And the Caesars, too, would have believed in Christ, had Caesars not been necessary for the world, or if the Caesars could have been at the same time Christians.

(26) But we are going to show you that those very demons whom you adore are fit witnesses to Christ.[98] (27) For the present, you have a coherent outline of the history of our founding; we have explained here the origin of our religion and of our name in connection with its founder. (31) Examine, therefore, whether the divinity of Christ is true. If it is, and if its recognition remakes persons for good, it follows that you must renounce the false.

97. Cf. the previous note. Tertullian had earlier referred to the report to Tiberius (*Apology* 5.4, omitted in the selections offered here), who received it sympathetically. The "christianization" of Pilate, which serves here as a gesture of rapprochement between Church and empire, reflects a tradition that culminated in the veneration of Pilate as saint in Syria and Egypt; cf. Johannes Quasten, *Patrology,* vol. 1 (Westminster, Md.: Newman Press, 1951), 118. For an interesting older study on the implications of the sentiment expressed in this paragraph on Christianity and the Caesars, see Charles Norris Cochrane, *Christianity and Classical Culture: A Study of Thought and Action from Augustus to Augustine,* (1944; reprinted, with text revised and corrected, London: Oxford University Press, 1968), 213–16.

98. See chapter 23, below.

[Tertullian proceeds to describe what pagan idols really are. They are the residences of the demons, who deceive whomever they can in order to induce their victims to believe in idols, since these same demons are nourished by the fumes and blood from the sacrifices offered to idols. This account of the demonic suggests why people have been blind to both general and special revelation.]

CHAPTER 22

(1) And so we say that there exist certain spiritual natures. The term is not new; the philosophers know of evil spirits, like Socrates himself awaiting the will of his "daimon."[99] (2) All the poets know of them; even the unlettered man of the street pronounces the name of Satan—and does so as a result of the soul's instinctive knowledge.[100] Again, Plato did not deny the existence of angels.[101] As witnesses to the names of both demons and angels, the magicians are at hand. (3) As for the details of how some of the angels were corrupted[102] of their own

99. Tertullian's "demonology" elaborates precedents that can be found in apologetic literature; cf. Justin *Apology* I 9,14, 21, 56–58, and Athenagoras, *Plea* 24–27. The explication of demonology became an important part of later apologetic literature; see, e.g., Augustine, *City of God* 9.5–22. Sr. Daly translated *daimones* variously as "evil spirits," "devils," and "demons." I have rendered the word consistently as "demons," retaining "daimon" only in reference to Socrates' famous daimon. For Socrates' daimon see Plato, *Apology* 31C–D and 40A–C, in which passages, however, Plato speaks, more precisely, of Socrates' "*daimonion*," which he describes as a divine, oracular sign. For "demons" in Christian literature, see the article "Demons" in *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity*. For the "daimones" in classical literature, see James Hastings, ed., *Encyclopedia of Religion and Ethics*, vol. 4 (Edinburgh: T&T Clark ,1911), 593–94. For the witness of a contemporary of Tertullian, see the little treatise by Apuleius, *On the God of Socrates* 6–17 (available in Jean Beaujeu, ed., *Apulée: Opuscules philosophiques et fragments* [Paris: Société d'Édition "Les Belles Lettres," 1973], 26–37). In this work by Apuleius, "demons" appear as beings composed of "air," intermediary between the gods and human beings, conveying the requests of the latter to the gods, and bringing the aid of the gods in the heavens to people on the earth; as messengers of the gods they are able to indicate the future.

100. On this claim see *Testimony of the Soul* 3 and n. 16.

101. See Plato, *Symposium* 202E–203A, where the daimon is defined in a good sense as the "go-between" of gods and human beings.

102. "Corrupted": *corruptis*. Cf. the terms Tertullian uses elsewhere in these selections to express the effects of the Fall: *Apology* 46; *Testimony of the Soul* 3; *Spectacles* 2 (cf. n. 13).

accord and then constituted the source of the even more corrupt race of demons, a race condemned by God together with the originators of the race and their leader Satan, the account is found in Sacred Scripture.[103]

(4) For the present, it will be sufficient to explain their mode of action. Their business is the subversion[104] of mankind; thus spiritual wickedness was from the very beginning bent upon man's destruction. The demons, therefore, inflict upon men's bodies diseases and other bitter misfortunes, and upon the soul sudden and extraordinary outbursts, using violence. (5) They have their own subtle, spiritual properties for assailing each part of human nature. (6) It is with some invisible and mysterious power of infection that the breath of demons and fallen angels induces the corruption of the mind by foul passions, by dread derangements of the mind, or by savage lusts accompanied by manifold delusions. Of these delusions, the greatest is that whereby those gods are foisted upon the seduced and ensnared minds of human beings so that they may procure for themselves a proper diet of fumes and blood offered to their statues and images, (7) and so that they might be enabled to turn people aside, by tricks of deception, from contemplation of the true God. I will explain how these illusions are set in operation.

(8) Every spirit is winged. Both angels and demons have this property. Therefore, they are everywhere in a moment. For them, the whole world is but a single place; what happens and where it happened they can know and tell with the same ease. (9) They even have borrowed the counsels of God that the Prophets of old proclaimed. In this way and from these sources they derive information and strive to rival the divine power of God, while they try to steal his power to foretell. (10) From dwelling in the air and being close to the stars and having com-

103. Cf. Gen. 6:2, where the Septuagint reads, "angels of God," 2 Pet. 2:4, and Rev. 12:7–9. "Sacred Scripture" here renders *litteras sanctas*, "sacred literature." Tertullian also uses such words as *instrumentum*, and *scriptura* to designate the bible. His terms for Scripture are analyzed in Braun, *Deus Christianorum*, 454–73.

104. "Subversion": *eversio;* in the next clause "spiritual wickedness" translates *malitia spiritalis*.

munication with the clouds,[105] they know well of the proceedings going on in the skies, so that they can even promise the rain—which they already feel falling. These[106] are the very ones who set themselves up as gods, doing things that make people believe in gods.[107]

[Recalling the literary device of the trial, Tertullian invites the plaintiff to summon the demons as witnesses, who, he affirms, will not only confess who they are but also that Christians worship the one and only God.]

CHAPTER 23

(4) But, that is enough on this point; there now follows a demonstration of the fact itself. Let there be produced right here before your tribunals someone who, it is well known, is beset by a demon. If any Christian bids the spirit to speak, the same will confess that he is a demon, just as truly as elsewhere he will falsely proclaim himself a god. (5) In a similar way, let there be brought forward one of those who are thought to be under the influence of a god, who conceive the divine power from the fumes that they inhale at the altars, and who prophesy by gasping for breath.[108] (6) Take Caelestis or Aesculapius,[109] if they do not confess that they are demons—not daring to lie to

105. An interpretation, evidently, of Eph. 6:12, where "the spiritual forces of evil" (cf. preceding note) are said to be "in the heavenly places" (NRSV); cf. *Flight in Time of Persecution*, n. 38.

106. I place here at the end of chapter 22 this sentence from chapter 23.2; the remainder of chapter 23.1–3 is omitted.

107. For a scriptural foundation for the view that the "gods" are in reality "demons," see Ps. 96:5, where the Septuagint (95:5) reads, "All the gods of the nations are demons"; cf. 1 Cor. 10:20–21.

108. A reference apparently to those who delivered oracles under the inspiration of the god, such as the priestess of Delphi. The description here may evoke Virgil's portrait of the Sybil in *Aeneid* 6.77–102, where there is, however, no attempt to rationalize the divine inspiration by appealing to the effect of fumes.

109. Caelestis, a Roman epithet ("the heavenly one") for the Carthaginian goddess, Tanit. Aesculapius was a Greek god of healing, but the Aesculapius worshiped with Caelestis at Carthage was in reality the Semitic god Eshmoun under a Greek name; cf. *To the Martyrs*, n. 24.

a Christian—then right here and now shed the blood of that bold Christian! (7) What is more revealing than such a performance? What more trustworthy than such a demonstration?

(12) Here, some might say: "And who is this Christ with his nonsense?" (13) Whatever you laugh at, let the demons laugh at, too, along with you; let them deny that Christ is to judge every soul that has been from the beginning of time after its body has been restored to it; let them deny that they are unclean spirits, who feed on blood and smoke and fetid, burning heaps of animal flesh; let them reject the charge that for their wickedness they have been condemned in advance to the same day of judgment, with all their devotees and their works.[110]

(15) Yet, this whole mastery and power of ours over them derives its effectiveness from the mere mention of the name of Christ and the reminder of those punishments that they expect will come upon them from God through Christ, his Arbiter. Fearing Christ in God and God in Christ, they are subject to the servants of God and of Christ. (16) Thus, at a touch, a breath from us, they quit the bodies of individuals—though against their will. (17) Believe them when they tell the truth about themselves, you who believe them when they lie!

CHAPTER 24

(1) This whole confession of theirs, whereby they deny that they are gods and declare that there is no other god but the One whose subjects we are, is quite sufficient to repel the charge of treason to the Roman religion. For if there is no religion, since you have no gods for certain, then it is certain we are not guilty of violating religion. (2) On the contrary, your charge will act as a boomerang upon yourselves. In worshiping falsehood you not only neglect—or, I should say, do violence to—the true religion of the true God, you actually commit the crime of positive irreligion.

[Tertullian offers proof that the pagan gods did not give the Romans their empire. Since from the pagan point of view treason is implied in the Christians' refusal to worship the gods who are al-

110. Cf. Matt. 8:29 and 2 Pet. 2:4.

leged to prosper and protect the State, Tertullian demonstrates that the rise and fall of empires is in the hands, not of the pagan gods, but of the God of the Christians.]

CHAPTERS 25–26

(1) It seems to me that I certainly have given sufficient proof of the difference between false and true divinity, now that I have pointed out how the proof depends not merely on discussion and argument, but also on the spoken testimony of those very ones whom you believe to be gods; so that there is no necessity of adding anything further to this topic. (2) However, since we made particular mention of the name of Rome, I will not avoid the issue that is provoked by those who say that the Romans, as a result of their scrupulous religious observance, have become masters of the world; and that so truly are they gods that those peoples surpass all others in prosperity who surpass all others in devotion to their deity.[111]

(12) But, how senseless it is to attribute the dignity of the Roman name to their scrupulous religious observances!—for it was after the institution of imperial, or, call it, still kingly power, that religion made advances. Although it was Numa who begot the superstitious punctiliousness, nevertheless, divine service with statues and temples was not established among the Romans at that time. (13) Religious services were shabby, the rituals were unpretentious; the god himself had nowhere put in his appearance; statues had not deluged the city. Consequently, the Romans' religious attitude did not precede their greatness, and, therefore, it was not for the fact that they were religious that they are great.[112]

111. For this claim as stated by a Roman, see Cicero, *On the Nature of the Gods* 2.3.7–8; 3.2.5–6, and *Concerning the Responses of the Soothsayers* 9.19. The claim continued to be made into late antiquity: Augustine devoted Book IV of the *City of God* to refuting it—in terms not unlike those of Tertullian here.

112. The simplicity of the old Roman religion was a common theme in the literary sources. Varro, for example, according to Augustine, *City of God* 4.31, said that the Romans worshiped the gods for one hundred and seventy years without images; Cicero, *On the Nature of the Gods* 3.17.43, indicates that the "poor little pots of Numa" (the legendary founder of the Roman religion) were a subject of popular oratory; cf. also Tibullus, *Poems* 1.10.15–20, and Juvenal, *Satires* 6.1–4, 342–45.

(14) On the contrary, how could their greatness be attributed to their religious attitude, since their greatness resulted from their indifference to religion? For, unless I am mistaken, every kingdom or empire is acquired by wars and extended by victories. Yet, wars and victories generally consist in the capture and destruction of cities. This business is not without its violence to the gods; there is indiscriminate destruction of city walls and temples, slaughter of citizens and priests without distinction, pillaging of treasures sacred and profane alike. (15) The sacrileges of the Romans are as numerous as their trophies; their triumphs over the gods as many as those over nations. (17) Certainly, the assumption cannot harmonize with truth that those people seem to have attained greatness on the merits of their religious service who have grown by giving offense to religion.

(1) Watch out, then, lest the one who dispenses kingdoms be the one to whom belong both the world that is ruled and human beings themselves who rule it; lest he who existed before all time and who has made the world a unified system of times has ordained changes in the ruling powers during certain periods in the course of time; lest he under whom the human race once lived before there were cities at all be the one who raises cities and destroys them.

[Summary comments regarding the first of the charges of "more manifest crimes."]

CHAPTERS 27–28

(1) Enough has been said to refute the charge of offending divinity, since it cannot seem that we are offending that which we have shown does not exist. Therefore, when called upon to sacrifice, we take a firm stand against it. (2) Some think it madness that, when we could offer sacrifice here and now, and then go away unpunished, preserving the same attitude of mind as before, we prefer to be obstinate rather than safe;[113] (3) but we

113. Pliny, *Ep.* 10.96.3, reported his view that whether guilty or innocent of other crimes, the obstinacy of Christians should be punished; cf. chapter 2, above, and for Pliny's letter, see the appendix.

realize the origin of such suggestions, who it is that prompts all this—that spirit endowed with the nature of demons and angels, who wars against us, using as its battleground your minds, which have been attuned to him by his secret insinuations.

(1) Moreover, the injustice of forcing persons of free will to offer sacrifice against their will is readily apparent, for, under all other circumstances, a willing mind is required for discharging one's religious obligations. (2) Now, it is by the same spirits, assuredly, that you have been taught to force us to offer sacrifice for the well-being of the emperor.

[The response to charges of "more manifest crimes": the second charge—treason. Pagans charge Christians with treason on two grounds. They complain, first, that Christians do not give the emperor due honor. Tertullian responds that the Christians do not offer useless sacrifice to the emperor, but, rather, effective prayers for him.]

CHAPTERS 28–29

(3) We have come, then, to the second charge alleged against us, that of offending a more august majesty. You pay your obeisance to Caesar with greater fear and craftier timidity than to Olympian Jupiter himself. And rightly so, if you but knew it! For what living man—whoever he may be—is not more powerful than any of your dead ones?

(1) First, then, let it be established whether those to whom sacrifice is offered can grant health to the emperor or to any man at all. (2) Certainly, they should first protect their own statues, images, and temples, which, I believe, the emperors' soldiers have to keep safe with guards. Moreover, those very materials for them come, I think, from the emperors' mines, and entire temples depend upon the nod of a Caesar. (3) If the gods are so completely in Caesar's power, and belong to him so completely, how can they have Caesar's welfare in their power? (4) So, we are committing a crime against the emperors because we do not subordinate emperors to their property, and we do not make a joke of our duty regarding their health, for we do not think it rests within hands that are soldered on with lead! (5) But then you are the irreligious ones who seek health

where it is not, who ask it from those who have no power to give it, and who neglect the one in whose power it lies. And, in addition to all this, you assail those who know how to ask for it, and who can obtain it, too, since they know how to ask!

CHAPTER 30

(1) For, in our case, we pray for the welfare of the emperors to the eternal God, the true God, the living God, whom even the emperors themselves prefer to have propitious to them before all other gods.[114] They know who has given them power; they know who has given them life; they feel that he is the only God in whose power alone they are; against him they cannot avail, through him they know they do avail. From him comes the emperor, from whom came the man also, before he became the emperor; from him comes the emperor's power, from whom as well came the breath of life. (4) Looking up to him, we Christians constantly beseech him on behalf of all emperors. We ask for them long life, undisturbed power, security at home, brave armies, a faithful Senate, an upright people, a peaceful world, and everything for which a man or a Caesar prays.

CHAPTERS 31–33

(1) Well, now, we have been flattering the emperor and have lied about the prayers we said just to escape rough treatment! Indeed, if you think that we have no interest in the emperor's welfare, consider the words of God, our literature.[115] We ourselves do not keep it concealed; in fact, many a chance hands it over to outsiders. (2) Learn from this literature that it has been enjoined upon us to pray to God even for our enemies, and to beg for blessings for our persecutors.[116] Now, who are any greater enemies and persecutors of Christians than those on whose account we are charged with the crime of treason? (3) But it is clearly and expressly said: "Pray for kings, for princes

114. For an example of such a prayer for rulers and governors, see the letter of Clement of Rome, *To the Corinthians* 61.

115. "The words of God, our literature": *Dei voces, nostras litteras;* cf. chapter 21, second paragraph, where the Latin *sanctae voces* is rendered by "holy voices," referring to the oracles of the prophets. For Tertullian's terminology of Scripture, see n. 103, above.

116. Cf. Matt. 5:43–45; Rom. 12:14.

and for rulers, that all may be peaceful for you!"[117] For, when the empire is shaken, inasmuch as the rest of its members are also shaken, we, too, are naturally involved in some part of the disaster.

(1) There is also another, even greater, obligation for us to pray for the emperors; yes, even for the continuance of the empire in general and for Roman interests. We realize that a tremendous catastrophe that threatens the whole world, and the very end of the world, with its threat of dreadful afflictions, are arrested for a time by the continued existence of the Roman Empire.[118] This event we have no desire to experience, and, in praying that it may be deferred, we favor the continuance of Rome.

(2) Then, too, we take an oath not by the "*genii* of the Caesars,"[119] but by their prosperity. We respect in the emperors the decision of God, since he has placed them over the people.[120] We know that in them is that which God has willed, and so we wish that what God has willed be safe and sound, and we consider this an important oath.

(1) We are under obligation to look up to the emperor as one whom our Lord has chosen. So, I might well say: "Caesar belongs more to us, since he has been appointed by our God." (2) And so, as he is mine, I do more for his welfare, not only because I pray for it to him who can really grant it, but also because, as I set the dignity of Caesar below that of God, I com-

117. Cf. 1 Tim. 2:2.

118. It is clear from his treatise *On the Resurrection of the Dead* 24.18 that Tertullian understood the Roman empire to be the "restraining force" of 2 Thess. 2:7 that would prevent the appearance of the Antichrist. So also later apologists such as Augustine, *City of God* 20.19. In his treatise *To Scapula* 2.6 Tertullian claims that the Roman empire will endure as long as the world stands; similarly Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* 7.25.7–8.

119. The "*genius*" was thought to be the divine or spiritual nature in a person or place. When an oath was taken an appeal might be made to the *genius* of the person addressed, and on festal occasions it was customary to propitiate the *genius:* for the former see, e.g., Horace, *Epistles* 1.7.94, and Suetonius, *Caligula* 27.5; for the latter see, e.g., Horace, *Epistles* 2.1.144, *Odes* 3.17.14, and Virgil, *Aeneid* 7.136. In "The Acts of the Scillitan Martyrs" (Musurillo *Acts*, 87) the proconsul asks the Christian Speratus to "swear by the genius of the emperor." For the origin of this oath, see Grant, *Augustus to Constantine*, 86.

120. Cf. Rom. 13:1–7.

mend him the more to God to whom alone I subordinate him. However, I do subordinate him to God; I do not make him God's equal. (3) If he is a man, it is to his interest as a man to yield precedence to God. Let him consider it enough to be called emperor.

CHAPTER 34
Omitted

[Tertullian continues to address the charge of treason, turning now to the second complaint of the pagans, that Christians endanger the security of the state. To this Tertullian responds that Christians do not participate in national celebrations, but they will never be found to plot treachery. Indeed, the demonstration of Christian loyalty urges the legitimization of the Christian society.]

CHAPTERS 35–36

(1) So, this is why Christians are public enemies, because they do not devote meaningless, false, and wanton honors to the emperors. (2) There is no question about it: it is a splendid ceremony to bring out in public the braziers and banquet couches, to dine in the streets, to make the city smell like a tavern, to chase around in bands giving oneself over to crimes, effrontery, and the seductive pleasures of lust. Does the public express its delight with public degradation? Shall immoral licentiousness be considered loyalty? excessive indulgence, religious respect? (4) Oh, how right then is our condemnation! Why do we perform our ceremonies and express our joys for the Caesars in a way that is chaste, sober, and decent? Why, on a festive day, do we not overshadow our door posts with laurel branches and infringe upon the daylight with lamps?[121] It is an honorable practice, indeed, when a public festival demands

121. In the Roman world occasions of public and private rejoicing were celebrated by decorating the doors with laurel; cf. Juvenal, *Satires* 6.79 (a marriage); 9.85 (a birth); 12. 91–92—where morning lamps are also mentioned—(a safe return from a voyage). See especially Tertullian's treatise *On Idolatry* 15. Tertullian alludes here to such public festivities as marked the anniversary of an emperor's birth, his accession to power, and the annual celebrations at the beginning of the year with prayers for the emperor's safety.

that you deck out your home with the appearance of a new brothel!

(5) Now, on this question of religious worship rendered to a less august majesty—the second charge of sacrilege, inasmuch as we do not celebrate with you the festivals of the emperors—I would like to point out your loyalty and sincerity. (6) It is the Romans themselves that I arraign: does that Roman tongue spare any emperor of its own? (7) If our breasts were transparent, whose heart would not appear engraved with the scene of one new Caesar after another presiding over the distribution of the dole?[122]

(8) "But, that's the rabble," you say. Perhaps it is the rabble; still, they are Romans, and none is more clamorous in their demands for punishment of the Christians than the rabble. Yes, of course, the other classes of society are conscientiously loyal, as their position of authority requires. There is never a hostile whisper from the Senate, the knights, the camp, or the palace itself. (9) Whence then come men like Cassius and Niger and Albinus?[123] Whence those others who have conspired against the emperors? From the ranks of the Romans, unless I am mistaken—that is, from among non-Christians. (10) And all of them, right until the very outbreak of their disloyalty, offered sacrifices for the well-being of the emperor and swore by his *genius*.

(1) If such is the case, and those who once were called Romans are now found to be enemies, why is it that we who are considered enemies are refused the name of Romans?[124] (2)

122. A donative (a money gift donated by the emperor) was customary at the accession of a new emperor; hence here the supposed popular wish for ever-changing emperors.

123. By recalling these names Tertullian shows that traitors have come not only from "the rabble" but from the upper classes as well. Avidius Cassius, one-time consul and governor under Marcus Aurelius, had himself saluted as emperor; his revolt collapsed and he was murdered (A.D. 175). After the death of Commodus (A.D. 192), Pescennius Niger, who had been senator, consul, and governor, and Clodius Albinus, from the Roman nobility, attempted to seize power, thus becoming rivals of Septimius Severus. The latter defeated them both, Niger in 194 and Albinus in 197, the year in which Tertullian wrote the *Apology*. See *To the Martyrs* 6 and n. 26.

124. The argument presupposes the conventional Roman view that those who, by their actions, became public enemies, *ipso facto* ceased to be Roman cit-

Furthermore, the loyalty, the reverence, the fidelity due the emperors consists in that moral behavior that God demands be shown to all. (3) In no good that we perform do we show preference for certain persons. (4) We are the same toward the emperors as we are toward our neighbors. For, to desire evil, to do evil, to speak evil, to think evil of anyone—all are equally forbidden to us. Whatever is forbidden with regard to anyone is, perhaps even to a greater degree, forbidden with regard to that one who, through God, is so great a personage.

CHAPTER 37

(4) If we wanted to act as open enemies, would we lack the strength of numbers and troops? We are but of yesterday, yet we have filled every place among you—cities, islands, fortified strongholds, towns, your gathering places, the military camp itself, registration units, town councils, the palace, the senate, the forum; we have left nothing to you but the temples of your gods.[125] (5) For what war would we not have been fit and ready, even though unequally matched in military strength, we who are so ready to be slain, were it not that, according to our rule of life, it is more lawful for us to be killed than to kill?

(6) Even unarmed and without any uprising, merely as malcontents, simply through an invidious withdrawal, we could have fought against you. For, if such a multitude of people as we are had broken loose from you and had gone into some remote corner of the earth, the loss of so many citizens, of whatever kind they might be, would certainly have made your power

izens. Tertullian wrote the *Apology* (197) just before the Emperor Caracalla made all free men and women in the empire Roman citizens (212), but Tertullian's use of the word "Roman" here suggests that people were already using the term "Roman" in a loose and non-technical sense to designate the masses who were culturally Romans, if not technically Roman citizens. It is clear from Pliny's letters that even in his time one did not cease to be a Roman citizen by becoming a Christian, since among the Christians indicted those who were Roman citizens received special treatment: Pliny sent Roman citizens to Rome for trial, but executed the others; cf. n. 15, above. A. N. Sherwin White discusses Tertullian's use of the words "Roman" and "citizen" in *The Roman Citizenship*, 2d ed. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1973), 433–37.

125. On Tertullian's exaggeration of the numerical strength of Christians, see chapter 1 n. 12, above. "Registration units" renders *tribus*, "tribes," a political grouping to which, traditionally, each Roman citizen had been assigned.

blush for shame; in fact, it would even have punished you by this very desertion. You would have had to look around for people to rule; there would have been more enemies than citizens left to you. (8) For, now, the enemies whom you have are fewer because of the number of Christians. These you have preferred to call the enemies of the human race.[126]

(9) But who would snatch you away from those secret enemies that are constantly destroying your spiritual and bodily health—I mean, the demons, which we ward off from you without any reward and without pay? (10) Instead of thinking of any compensation for so great a protection, you have preferred to consider as enemies a class of people who are actually indispensable to you.[127] To tell the truth, we are enemies, not of the human race, but of human error.

CHAPTER 38

(1) Accordingly, this religion[128] ought not to be included among those societies that cannot legally exist—which would be a somewhat milder judgment.[129] Its members commit no

126. Cf. Tacitus, *Annals* 15.44.5, a passage that is generally understood to mean that the Christians, charged with setting fire to Rome, were condemned not so much on the grounds of the alleged incendiarism, but "because of their hatred of the human race."

127. In this and the contextual chapters, Tertullian responds to a well attested pagan perception that Christians fail to fulfill their civic duties. For the criticisms of Celsus, in this respect a representative pagan, see Wilken, *Christians as the Romans Saw Them*, 117–19.

128. "religion": *sectam*, used often of a school or sect, while the word "societies" that soon follows renders *factiones*. In this chapter Tertullian uses language carefully chosen to present the Christian Church in terms analogous to those used of pagan societies, thus inviting pagans to view the Church from the perspective of their own presuppositions; cf. Wilken, *Christians as the Romans Saw Them,* 44–47.

129. The reading of this sentence is uncertain; Sr. Daly had understood, "Accordingly, ought not this religion to be regarded with somewhat milder judgment among those societies which cannot legally exist?" Clubs and societies *(sodalitates, collegia)* were a familiar feature of Roman life. Laws against *collegia* had been enacted during the last years of the Republic (64–44 B.C.) to curb the political activity to which they often lent themselves. Augustus (A.D. 7) required that every society be sanctioned by the senate or the emperor, though general permission was given for burial clubs. A century later Trajan specifically disallowed firemen's clubs in Asia Minor (Pliny, *Ep.* 10.33–34), and this had

such crimes as are regularly feared from illegal associations. (2) For, unless I am mistaken, the motive for prohibiting associations rests on the prudent care for public order, lest the state be split into parties, a situation which would easily disturb voting assemblies, council meetings, the Senate, mass meetings, and even public entertainments by the clash of rival interests, since by now men have even begun to make a business of their violence, offering it for sale at a price. (3) But for us there is no need of banding together. Nothing is more unfamiliar to us than politics. There is only one state for all that we acknowledge—the universe.

(4) Likewise, we renounce your public shows just as we do their origins, which we know were begotten of superstition, while we are completely aloof from those matters with which they are concerned. Our tongues, our eyes, our ears have nothing to do with the madness of the circus, the shamelessness of the theater, the brutality of the arena, the vanity[130] of the gymnasium. (5) How, then, do we offend you? If we prefer different pleasures, that is our loss—if loss there be—not yours.

[Tertullian offers a portrait of the Christian society: it is a model of creative community, not an assembly of conspirators.]

CHAPTER 39

(1) Now I myself will explain the practices of the Christian society,[131] that is, after having refuted the charges that they are evil, I myself will also point out that they are good. We constitute a body as a result of our common religious convictions, the unity of our way of life, and the bond of a common hope. (2)

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been taken as a ban on the gathering of Christians (*Ep.* 10.96.7, for which see the appendix).

130. "Vanity": *vanitate;* Tertullian probably intends to evoke images of "useless frivolity" and/or "vainglory"—both meanings can be conveyed by the Latin; cf. n. 27, above. In this sentence Tertullian alludes to forms of entertainment he will consider in his treatise on *Spectacles*, included below.

131. "Christian society": *Christianae factionis;* cf. n. 128, above. With the portrait of the Christian community here, compare Justin, *Apology* I 67; cf. also the brief but impressive account of the character of the early Christian community in the *Epistle to Diognetus* 5 (second century).

We come together for meeting and assembly in order that we might, like an army in battle formation, besiege God with prayers. Such violence is pleasing to God.[132] We pray, also, for the emperors, for their ministers and those in power, for a stable world, for universal peace, and for the delay of the coming end of the world. (3) We assemble for the consideration of the Holy Scriptures, to see if the circumstances of the present times demand that we look ahead or reflect. We nourish our faith with holy conversation, we uplift our hope, we strengthen our trust, intensifying our discipline at the same time by the inculcation of moral precepts. (4) At the same occasion, there are words of encouragement, of correction, and holy censure. For judgment also is passed with great weight,[133] as among people who are certain of the presence of God; and it is a deeply affecting foretaste of the future judgment, if anyone has so sinned that he is dismissed from sharing in common prayer, assembly, and all holy intercourse.[134] (5) Certain approved elders preside, men who have obtained this honor not by money, but by the evidence of good character. For nothing that pertains to God is to be had for money.

Even if there is some kind of treasury, it is not accumulated from a high initiation fee as if religion were something bought and paid for.[135] Each one deposits a small amount on a certain day of the month or whenever one wishes, and only on condition that one is willing and able to do so. No one is forced; each makes his contribution voluntarily.[136] (6) The money therefrom is spent for the support and burial of the poor, for children who are without their parents and means of subsistence, for household servants who have become old and cannot work, likewise, for shipwrecked sailors; and if any are in the mines, on islands,

132. For the image of violence, see Matt. 11:12; Luke 16:16.

133. I.e., "with great gravity," or possibly, "with great authority."

134. The allusion here to the procedure of penance in the early Church is greatly elaborated in Tertullian's treatise *On Penitence*, for which see William P. LeSaint, *Treatises on Penance: On Penitence and on Purity*, Ancient Christian Writers, vol. 28 (Westminster, Md.: Newman Press, 1959). See esp. *On Penitence* 9 (LeSaint, 31–32).

135. Epigraphical evidence shows that "initiation fees" (dues) were collected by pagan societies; see Wilken, *Christians as the Romans Saw Them,* 36–40.

136. Cf. 2 Cor. 9:7.

or in prisons—provided they are there because they belong to God's sect—these become entitled to loving and protective care for their confession.[137] (7) The practice of such a special love brands us in the eyes of some. "See," they say, "how they love one another."

(8) Over the fact that we call ourselves brothers, people fall into a rage. But we are your brothers, too, according to the law of nature, our common mother. (9) And yet with how much more right are they called brothers and considered such who have acknowledged one father, God, who have drunk one spirit of holiness,[138] who in fear and wonder have come forth from the one womb of their common ignorance to the one light of truth! (11) So we who have become mingled[139] in mind and soul have no hesitation about sharing what we have. Everything is in common among us—except our wives.[140]

(14) Why wonder, then, if such dear friends take their meals together? You attack our modest repasts—apart from saying that they are disgraced by crimes—as being extravagant. (15) However, anyone sees the bit of straw in another's eye more easily than a mote in his own.[141] Others indulge in extravagant banquets: for the Dionysiac revels, for the mysteries of Attica, a battery of cooks is drafted; at the smoke of a feast of Serapis, the firemen will be summoned.[142] But only about the repast of the

137. Those who confessed their faith before a tribunal were sometimes banished, or sent to the mines, or imprisoned to await execution. The Church generally undertook to relieve their condition; see *To the Martyrs* 1, where Tertullian acknowledges the Church's contribution to the physical needs of the prisoners, contrasting it with his contribution to their "spiritual needs."

138. Cf. 1 Cor. 12:13.

139. "Mingled": *misceri*. The word can be used of sexual intercourse, as in *Apology* 9.16 (omitted in this selection). The word is also used in chapter 21, "man mingled with God" (n. 94, above).

140. Perhaps an allusion to Plato's model state, where wives were to be held in common; see *Republic* 5.457B–D.

141. Cf. Matt. 7:3.

142. The "mysteries" were generally characterized by initiation rites required for admission. The most famous mysteries of the Greeks were the Eleusinian mysteries (mysteries of Attica), brought under state control sometime before 600 B.C., and the Dionysiac mysteries which developed somewhat later, though Bacchic revels as portrayed in Euripides' *Bacchae* belong to an early period. For a vivid contemporary account of the "Dionysiac revels" and the

Christians is any objection brought forth. (16) By its very name our repast indicates its purpose. It is called by a name that to the Greeks means "love."[143] Whatever it costs, it is gain to incur expense in the name of piety, since by this refreshment we comfort the needy. (17) If the motive of our repast is honorable, then on the basis of that motive appraise the entire procedure of our discipline. No one sits down to table without first partaking of a prayer to God. The diners eat as much as those who are hungry take; they drink as much as temperate people need. (18) They satisfy themselves as persons who remember that they must worship God even throughout the night; they converse as people who know that the Lord is listening. After this, the hands are washed and lamps are lit, and each one, according to his ability, is invited to stand forth and sing to God something taken from the Holy Scriptures or of his own making. Prayer puts an end to the meal. (19) From here they depart, not to unite in bands for murder, or to run around in gangs, or to indulge in lewdness, but to observe the same regard for modesty and chastity as people do who have partaken not only of a repast but of a rule of life.

(20) Such is the gathering of Christians. There is no question about it—it deserves to be called illegal, provided it is like those that are illegal; it deserves to be condemned, if any complaint is lodged against it on the same ground that complaints are made about other secret societies. (21) But for whose destruction have we ever held a meeting? We are the same when assembled as when separate; we are collectively the same as we are individually, doing no one any injury, causing no one any harm. When people who are upright and good assemble, when the pious and virtuous gather together, the meeting should be called not a secret society but a senate.

"mysteries of Attica," see Clement of Alexandria, *Exhortation to the Greeks* 2. For Serapis see n. 34, above. On the mysteries see n. 42, above; and see Walter Burkert, *Ancient Mystery Cults* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1987).

143. "Love": *dilectio;* Tertullian refers to the Greek word *agape*, which, however, he avoids here. *Dilectio* is a word appearing in later Latin, coined from the verb *diligo*, which means "to esteem highly," "to be very attentive towards," "to love." Cf. *To the Martyrs*, n. 14.

[It is not the Christians but the pagans who bring destruction upon the state.]

CHAPTERS 40–41

(1) On the other hand, those people deserve the name of a secret society who band together in hatred of good and virtuous folk, who cry out for the blood of the innocent, on the idle plea that they consider that the Christians are the cause of every public calamity and every misfortune of the people. (2) If the Tiber rises as high as the city walls, if the Nile does not rise to the fields, if the weather will not change, if there is an earthquake, a famine, a plague—straightway the cry is heard: "Toss the Christians to the lion!" So many of them for just one beast? (3) I ask you, before the reign of Tiberius, that is, before the coming of Christ, what great misfortunes befell the world and its cities? (4) Plato relates that a land larger than Asia or Africa was washed away by the Atlantic Ocean.[144] (5) In those days the great flood poured its waters over the whole world, (7) a rain of fire burnt up the regions of Sodom and Gomorrah,[145] and fire from its own neighboring volcano overwhelmed Pompeii.[146] No one at Rome had yet come to adore the true God when Hannibal, near Cannae, measured his slaughter by bushels of Roman rings. All your gods used to be worshiped by everyone when the Senones seized the Capitol.[147]

(10) At all times the human race has deserved ill at God's hands—in the first place, because, although it knew him in part, it did not seek and find him, but invented other gods; in the second place, because it became hardened in all vices and crimes. (11) But, if it had sought him, recognized, and worshiped him, it would have experienced his mercy rather than his wrath.[148] (12) So the race now must experience the anger of

144. A reference to the fabled island of Atlantis, which was engulfed by the ocean; cf. Plato, *Timaeus* 24E–25.

145. Cf. Gen. 7:11–24 (flood) and Gen. 19:24 (Sodom and Gomorrah).

146. A reference to the well known destruction of Pompeii from the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in A.D. 79.

147. Hannibal virtually annihilated an army that numbered, according to tradition, 80,000 men at Cannae in 216 B.C. The Senones led the Gallic band that captured Rome, though it failed to take the capitol, in 390 B.C.

148. Cf. Rom. 1:18–2:11 and Acts 17:24–29.

this same God just as it did also in times past, before the name of Christian was even mentioned. Why do people not realize that the misfortunes come from him whose blessings they have failed to recognize? (1) You are the ones, then, who cause trouble in human affairs; you are always the ones who bring down public calamities—you, who scorn God and adore statues.

CHAPTER 42

(1) But on still another charge of misconduct are we arraigned: they say that we are worthless in business. How can they say that? Are we not people who live right with you, people who follow the same way of life, the same manner of dressing, using the same provisions and the same necessities of life? We are not Brahmans or Indian ascetics who dwell in forests, withdrawn from life. (2) We bear in mind that we owe thanks to the Lord our God who created us; we disdain no fruit of his works; obviously, we do restrain ourselves from an immoderate or excessive use of them. So it is not without a forum, not without a meat market, not without baths, shops, factories, inns, market days, and the rest of your business enterprises that we live with you—in this world. (3) We are sailors along with yourselves; we serve in the army;[149] we engage in farming and trading; in addition, we share with you our arts; we place the products of our labor at your service. How we can appear worthless for your business, when we live with you and depend on you, I do not know.

(8) "At all events," you say, "the income of the temples is daily melting away. How few there are who still cast in a contribution!"[150] Of course; for we cannot afford to give aid both to human beings and to those gods of yours, when both are begging. In the meanwhile, our mercy spends more from street to street than your religion does from temple to temple. (9) But the rest

149. For the extent to which Christians served in the army at this time, see Louis J. Swift, *The Early Fathers on War and Military Service*, Message of the Fathers of the Church, vol. 19 (Wilmington, Del.: Michael Glazier, 1983), 68–69 (distributed by the Liturgical Press, Collegeville, Minn.); see, also, Tertullian, *The Crown* 12 and n. 55.

150. For temple revenues see n. 62, above. Visitors might also leave a small piece of money in the sanctuary.

of the taxes will acknowledge a debt of gratitude to the Christians who pay their dues with the same good faith that keeps us from defrauding another.

CHAPTER 43
Omitted

CHAPTER 44

(2) We now call your judicial acts to witness, you who preside each day to pass judgment on prisoners. So many guilty persons are examined by you with various charges against them: the man arraigned there as a murderer, a pickpocket, a profaner of temples, a seducer or robber of those in the baths—which one of them is charged also as a Christian? (3) It is with people from your own midst that the jail is always bulging, the mines are always humming,[151] the wild beasts are always fattened. No one there is a Christian—unless he is *merely* that; if he is something else, too, then he is no longer a Christian.[152]

[Summary affirmation of Christian innocence.]

CHAPTER 45

(1) We, then, are the only ones who are innocent! What wonder if this must necessarily be the case? For it really must be. We have been taught our innocence by God; we understand it perfectly, as something revealed by a perfect teacher; we guard it faithfully, as something entrusted to us by a judge who is not to be despised. (2) On the other hand, it is human opinion that has handed over to you your idea of innocence; it is likewise human authority that has enjoined it; therefore, you are not possessed of a moral system that is either complete or so inspires fear as to produce true innocence. (3) Which is more complete, to say: "Thou shalt not kill," or to teach: "Be not even angry"?[153] Which is more perfect, to forbid adultery, or to guard against even a single glance of concupiscence?[154] (7) We alone

151. Condemned criminals were sometimes sent to work in the mines; cf. n. 137, above.

152. Cf. Minucius Felix, *Octavius* 35.6.

153. Cf. Matt. 5:21–22; Col. 3:8; Tit. 1:7.

154. Cf. Matt. 5:28.

who are examined under the eyes of an all-seeing God, we who foresee an eternal punishment from him, deservedly achieve innocence because of the fullness of our wisdom and because of the greatness of the torments that are eternal; we are in fear of him whom he, too, will have to fear—I mean, the very one who sits to pass judgment on us, the fearful; in a word, we fear God, not the proconsul.[155]

[Concluding considerations: Christianity is more than a philosophy, for philosophy, though it has borrowed from Scripture, has nevertheless failed to find the full truth.]

CHAPTER 46

(1) We have, I believe, held our ground against all the crimes imputed to our charge that demand the blood of Christians. We have pointed out our whole position and the means by which we can prove that it is just as we have indicated, namely, by the evidence and antiquity of the Sacred Scriptures and by the testimony of the spiritual powers. Who will dare to refute us by the same form with which we have established our proof: by means of truth? (2) But while the truth which is ours becomes manifest to each and all, meanwhile, disbelief, though it be convinced of the goodness of this religion, does not consider our doings as divinely inspired at all, but merely as a sort of philosophy. "The philosophers," it says, "teach the same virtues, and they, too, profess morality, justice, patience, moderation, and chastity."[156] (3) If, then, we are compared to them on the basis of our teaching, why are we not, accordingly, treated the same as they regarding the free and unmolested practice of our teaching?

(6) Now the more the truth fans the flames of hatred, the more offense does the one give who reliably proclaims it. But the one who feigns and falsifies it for the most part wins favor among the persecutors of truth precisely because he does so.

155. On the place of fear in Tertullian's ethical scheme, see *Spectacles*, n. 10.

156. Galen, for example, compared the high moral standards of Christians with those of philosophers; cf. Wilken, *Christians as the Romans Saw Them*, 79–80 (cf. also n. 19, above).

(7) Philosophers, with mockery and contempt, out of hostility feign the truth[157] and, in feigning it corrupt it, eager only for glory; Christians both strive for the truth out of necessity and maintain it unspoiled,[158] concerned for their salvation.

[Tertullian now proceeds (chapters 46.8–47.10) to a comparison of Christians and philosophers: while he contrasts the moral failures of individual philosophers with the moral achievement of the typical Christian, he admits a certain similarity in philosophical conceptualization, but shows that philosophers have borrowed their thoughts from the Old Testament, which antedates them, as well as from the New; and in borrowing from the truth they have corrupted it.]

CHAPTER 47

(11) Everything against truth has been constructed from truth itself. The spirits of error effect this rivalry. By them has this kind of falsification of our life-giving doctrine been instigated; by them, too, have certain tales been started that, by virtue of their resemblance to the truth, would weaken faith in the latter, or rather, would win faith over for themselves, so that anyone may consider that Christians must not be believed because poets and philosophers must not be—or he may think that poets and philosophers should be believed all the more because they are not Christians.[159] (12) Hence, we are ridiculed when we proclaim that God will hold a final judgment. Yet, in like manner the poets and philosophers establish a tribunal in the underworld. And if we threaten hell we are laughed to scorn for it. Yet, Pyriphlegethon is also called a river among the dead. (13) If we mention paradise, the Elysian Fields have already won belief.[160] (14) Whence, I ask you, comes such close

157. "Out of hostility feign the truth" is the preferred reading, but there is some support for the reading adopted by Sr. Daly, "in mimicry feign the truth."

158. On the language here, see n. 102, above.

159. Cf. Justin, *Apology* I 54.

160. See Virgil's powerful description of Pyriphlegethon, the fiery river that surrounds Tartarus (*Aeneid* 6.550–51); see also his description of the harsh tribunal of Rhadamanthus (*Aeneid* 6.566–69), and of the Elysian Fields, the home of the blest (*Aeneid* 6.637–78).

resemblance with the philosophers and poets? From no place else but from our mysteries.[161] If from our mysteries as their primary source, then our mysteries are more reliable and more worthy of belief than the copies of them which also find belief.

CHAPTERS 48–49
Omitted

[In bringing his *Apology* to a conclusion, Tertullian has broached the doctrine of the Final Judgment. He goes on to defend the Christian doctrine of the resurrection of the dead that must precede the Final Judgment. Here, too, he recognizes the distorted adaptations of the philosophers (e.g., in the theory of the transmigration of souls), and he explains and justifies the specifically Christian view, noting that the God who created the world from nothing can restore the individual person in the Resurrection. This will lead to the great and final Assize, when the worshipers of God will be rewarded by being eternally with God and the profane will be punished with perpetual fire. Such beliefs, encouraging people to lead good lives, do not deserve condemnation. Having observed that no threat of condemnation can induce Christians to fall away from God, but that through condemnation Christians attain the object of their choice, Tertullian concludes the *Apology* with a final rhetorical flourish (chapter 50).]

CHAPTER 50

(1) "Why, then," you say, "do you complain because we persecute you, if you desire to suffer, since you ought to love those through whom you suffer what you desire?" Certainly, we are willing to suffer, but in the way that a soldier endures war. No one actually has a liking for suffering, since that inevitably involves anxiety and danger. (2) However, a man fights a battle with all his strength and, though he complained about there being a battle, he finds delight in conquering in battle, because he is attaining glory and reward. There is a battle for us, be-

161. "Our mysteries": *nostris sacramentis*, as also in the next sentence. In the context here, the connotation of "doctrines," as Sr. Daly translated, may be present; cf. Braun, *Deus Christianorum*, 440.

cause we are called to trial in court so that we may fight there for the truth while our life hangs in the balance. And the victory is to hold fast to that for which we have fought.[162] This victory has attached to it the glory of pleasing God and the reward of eternal life. (3) We have won the victory when we are killed; we escape at last when we are led forth. So you may call us "faggot fellows" and "half-axle men," because we are bound to a half-axle post and burned in a circle of faggots. This is the garb of our victory; this is our robe embroidered with palms; in such a chariot do we celebrate our triumph.[163]

[Concluding remarks]

(12) Carry on, good magistrates; you will become much better in the eyes of the people if you sacrifice the Christians for them. Crucify us—torture us—condemn us—destroy us! Your injustice is the proof of our innocence. (13) Yet, your tortures accomplish nothing, though each is more refined than the last; rather, they are an enticement to our sect.[164] We become more numerous every time we are hewn down by you: the blood of Christians is seed.[165] (15) For, who is not stirred by the contemplation of it to inquire what is really beneath the surface? And who, when he has inquired, does not approach us? Who, when he has approached, does not desire to suffer so that he may procure the full grace of God, that he may purchase from him full pardon by paying with his own blood? (16) For, by this

162. Cf. Minucius Felix, *Octavius* 37.1.

163. A Roman general, victorious in a distinguished battle, often celebrated a triumph when he returned to Rome. In the triumph he was dressed in a special robe and carried in a four-horse chariot through the Forum to the temple of Jupiter on the Capitol. Cf. *The Crown*, n. 61.

164. "Sect": *sectae;* the word is often used of a school or sect; cf. n. 128, above.

165. The expression is sometimes paraphrased as "The blood of martyrs is the seed of the Church." Here "we are hewn down" renders the Latin *metimur,* literally, "we are harvested," thus suggesting that the "harvest" of martyred Christians provides the seed for the growth of the Church. In apologetic literature, persecution was seen as a stimulus to the growth of Christianity; cf. Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* 5.13.10.

means, all sins are forgiven.[166] That is why we give thanks immediately for your sentences of condemnation.[167] Such is the difference between things divine and human: when we are condemned by you, we are acquitted by God.

166. Early Christians believed that martyrdom itself effected the forgiveness of all sins.

167. Probably a reference to the martyr's words, "Thanks be to God," on hearing the sentence of condemnation. Cf. n. 13, above.

2

TESTIMONY OF THE SOUL

Introduction

This little treatise—one of Tertullian's shortest[1]—may in several respects be considered a companion piece to the *Apology,* which it appears to have followed within a year. In this treatise, as in the *Apology,* it is the image of the trial that provides the framework within which the argument proceeds. An ill-defined paganism that ridicules and hates Christian beliefs has put Christian faith on trial. In the course of the proceedings, Christian faith asks to cross-examine a witness from paganism itself—the soul not yet purified by the waters of baptism. During the procedure the unconverted soul confesses that it recognizes basic Christian beliefs as true; by implication it has acknowledged pagan religion as false. Plaintiff suddenly becomes defendant: because the unconverted soul acknowledges the truth of Christian faith, it stands guilty of living the lie of paganism, and at God's Assize on the Judgment Day it will stand condemned.[2]

1. In the Latin text of *Corpus Christianorum,* the treatise has only 270 lines; *To the Martyrs,* Tertullian's shortest treatise (included below), has, in the same text, 180 lines.

2. Tertullian shows little interest in clarifying the *mise en scène* implied in this treatise. The only explicit feature establishing the image of a case in court is the witness. It is not impossible, therefore, to imagine the *personae* in different roles: Christianity as the plaintiff, paganism as the defendant that condemns itself by its own witness. But the last sentence of chapter 1 and the first of chapter 2 sug-

While it appears that this treatise, like the *Apology,* is positioned as a defense of Christianity, it becomes in fact an exhortation to the pagans to adopt the faith of Christians, a faith that is shown to be at its source their own. Indeed, the brevity of the treatise, the limitation of its scope to a single issue—the validity of basic Christian doctrines—and especially the literary device of cross-examining a witness from the ranks of the opposing side, all help to foster a stronger sense of exhortation here than in the *Apology.* In effect, Tertullian has attempted to build a bridge between Christian belief and the pagan intellectual heritage as expressed in its assumptions, which in itself constitutes an invitation to pagans to believe. And yet, after the carrot, the stick: like the *Apology* the treatise concludes with the threat of punishment upon pagans who, still unconverted, will face the great Judge on the Last Day. Thus fear, too, has its role to play in Tertullian's evangelical exhortation.

As Tertullian himself acknowledges, he was not the first Christian to endeavor to speak to pagans on their own terms. Others, however, had sought to find in the literary tradition of paganism the kernels of truth pagans shared with Christians, in the hope that the recognition of a common truth articulated in the pagan tradition would facilitate pagan conversion. But Tertullian seeks to go beyond the literary tradition to find a source of truth on which indeed the tradition may draw, but which is more authoritative than the latter could ever be. This source is the "common ideas" shared instinctively by all human beings, even those left untouched by learning and so unacquainted with the literary tradition.

The notion of *communes sensus,* "the common ideas," was essentially Stoic in origin and assumed that all persons are born with a soul that derives ultimately from the divine. Because of its divine origin, the soul enters one's life with an awareness of divine truth.[3] This doctrine needed little adaptation for evan-

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gest that it is the Christian faith that defends itself from the spiteful slanders of pagans, whom Christian doctrines offend, and it would be characteristic of Tertullian's irony to have the witness called from the plaintiff's ranks only to find in the course of cross-examination that it has become a defendant.

3. For the Stoic origin of the doctrine of the "common ideas" and for the variety of expressions used by Tertullian to indicate this Stoic concept, see *Quin-*

gelical purposes. The Christian could affirm that though sin has distorted the original integrity of the soul, and though a pagan education has obscured the soul's vision,[4] there are moments in life when the soul is led to acknowledge the divine truth with which it entered the world.

Tertullian makes in this treatise a rather large claim, for he ascribes to the common ideas some of the central Christian doctrines: that God is one; that God's mercy and beneficence have their counterpart in the exact judgment exercised by God; that the demonic exists as the source of evil in our world; that souls exist after death; and that there will be a future resurrection.

Tertullian had already applied the concept of the common ideas to his exposition in the *Apology*.[5] But the concept was, apparently, integral on a broader scale to his understanding of the relation between general and special revelation, and he repeatedly appeals to it in other works: *On the Flesh of Christ* 12.5, (where he refers to our present treatise); *On the Resurrection of the Dead* 3.2; *Against Marcion* 1.10.2; *On the Soul* 2.5 and 41.3; *The Crown* 6; and he refers to it in his letter *To Scapula* 2.1. It was a concept that required some account of the effect of "original sin" on the soul, an account Tertullian gives in *On the Soul* 41: though the soul has lost its original integrity, it has not lost the ability to recall the knowledge brought with it into life from its divine origin. Thus the soul can be regarded both as "naturally Christian," as in the *Apology,* and also as not Christian, as in *The Testimony of the Soul:* Christian insofar as it enjoys the grace of general revelation, not Christian insofar as it lives without the grace of special revelation.

Just as in the *Apology* Tertullian seems to have had his ear tuned to the interests of Christians, so it is likely that in *The Testimony of the Soul* he was aware of the confirmation of faith Christian readers might receive from his treatise. The fictive judicial victory would please Christian readers, and the ground of their

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ti Septimi Florentis Tertulliani De anima, ed. by J. H. Waszink (Amsterdam: J. M. Meulenhoff, 1947), 99 and 454–55.

4. Tertullian discusses somewhat negatively the philosophers' use of the common ideas in *On the Soul* 2.5.

5. Cf. *Apology* 17 (pp. 36–37, above).

faith would be clarified by the explication of the complementary roles of natural and revealed knowledge in their salvation. Thus the treatise would appear to have provided a particularly effective bridge between Christian and pagan, through the language of the pagans both confirming the faith of Christians and convincing pagans of the verity of the Christian faith they despised.

The Text

CHAPTER 1

Great love for research and an even greater memory are required of a student who would gather proofs for the truth of Christianity from the most accepted works of the philosophers, poets, and any other teachers of secular learning and wisdom. Indeed, some of our brethren have composed small treatises of this kind.[6] Unfortunately, however, the stubbornness of people in disbelieving has denied credence even to their own teachers, who otherwise are widely approved and read. Then the poets are fools when they depict the gods as fabulous characters; then the philosophers are harsh when they knock at the gates of truth. Therefore, we will no longer have anything to do with the literature and instruction of a perverted felicity, which is believed rather when it is false than when it is true. Let the pagans see for themselves whether some of their authors have made a pronouncement concerning the one and only God.

I call to our aid new testimony, even better known than all literature, more discussed than all doctrine, more familiar to the masses than any publication. Stand forth, then, O soul.[7] I do not call upon you who are formed in the schools, practiced in the libraries, nourished in the Attic academies and porti-

6. Clement of Alexandria's *Protrepticus* (i.e., *Exhortation to the Greeks)* is perhaps the best early example of the attempt made to offer pagans an access to Christian truth through insights familiar to them and articulated for them by their own writers. For Clement's discussion of the witness found in the writings of pagan philosophers and poets to the truths of Christianity, see his *Exhortation* 6–7. The model for this type of exhortation may be found in embryonic form in Paul's address to the Athenians in Acts 17:22–31.

7. The expression implies that the soul is to stand forth publicly as a witness in the presence of the jurors.

coes.[8] I address you who are simple, unskilled, unpolished and uneducated. I shall demand from you an answer concerning those things that you bring with you into human life, which you have learned to perceive, either from yourself or through your author—whoever he may be. You are not a Christian, as far as I know, for, as a rule, the soul is not born Christian; it becomes Christian.[9] Nevertheless, the Christians are now pleading for testimony from you, who are not one of us,[10] against your own fellows, who hate us and laugh at our doctrines—the very doctrines you yourself now stand guilty of believing in.

CHAPTER 2

People are offended when we proclaim that there is but one God, called by this name alone, from whom all things come and to whom the universe is subject. But if this is your knowledge give us your testimony. For we hear you—openly, and with a complete freedom that is not allowed to us—use in private and in public such expressions as, "God willing" and "May God grant this." By these expressions you indicate that some being does exist, and you confess that all power belongs to him for whose will you have regard.

Furthermore, the nature of the God whom we proclaim is not hidden from you. "God is good" and "God does good" are expressions of yours. And, plainly, you add, "But the human being is evil." By this contrary proposition, you indirectly and figuratively accuse mankind of being evil, for the very reason that it has departed from God who is good. Moreover, with regard to the fact that among us Christians every blessing—which comes from God who is all goodness and kindness—recalls the principle article of our religion and our conduct (namely, the sovereignty of God), you say just as easily as a Christian must, "May

8. Plato's school in Athens was known as the Academy; the Stoics took their name from their practice of lecturing in the "Painted Porch" (from the Greek *stoa,* "porch"), a public hall in Athens.

9. Cf. *Apology,* nn. 11, 19, and 79, and *Spectacles,* n. 78; but for the soul as instinctively Christian, see *Apology* 17 and n. 77.

10. The soul is *extranea*—"not one of us" (i.e., the Christians)—because it is the unconverted, hence pagan, soul that is asked to witness on behalf of the Christians.

God bless you."[11] But when you turn the blessing of God into a curse, then by this very word you confess in the same manner as we that all power over us belongs to him.

There are those who do not deny that God exists, but plainly do not regard him as the searcher, arbiter and judge of our actions. They separate him from the cares of observation and the annoyances of chastisement, him to whom they do not attribute even wrath.[12] For, they say, if God becomes angry, he is subject to corruption and passion. Whence, therefore, comes the natural fear of the soul toward God, if God is incapable of wrath?[13] What is feared, if not anger? Whence does anger arise, if not because of punishment? Whence punishment, if not as a result of power? And whose is the highest power, if not that of God alone? Hence, O soul, because of your knowledge it is possible for you to proclaim in private and in public: "God sees all" and "God will judge between us." Indeed this happens often in your very temples. Whence does this come to pass since you are not a Christian?[14] O testimony of truth, which in the very midst of the demons makes you a witness for the Christians!

CHAPTER 3

Indeed, some follower of Chrysippus ridicules us when we assert that demons exist—just as if we did not prove their exis-

11. I have followed here the interpretation of Carlo Tibiletti, ed. and trans., *Tertulliano: La testimonianza dell'anima* (Florence: Nardine Editore, 1984), 43; the meaning of Arbesmann's translation (FOTC, vol. 10, 134) is uncertain. However, Tibiletti's translation is paraphrastic; more literally the passage may be rendered: "Moreover, since, among us, in the presence of the God of goodness and kindness, blessing is in every case the most sacred symbol of our way of life and conduct, you say just as easily as a Christian must, 'May God bless you.'" In this passage the phrase "most sacred symbol" translates *summum sacramentum,* which Tibiletti understands in the sense of "principle article . . . (namely the sovereignty of God)"; for the various meanings of *sacramentum,* cf. *Apology,* n. 37.

12. A reference to the Epicureans, who taught that the gods lived in a world whose happiness was unbroken by any cares or concerns for our human world. See Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers* 10.76–77 (citing Epicurus' "Letter to Herodotus") and 10.139 (citing from Epicurus' "Sovran Maxims"); see also Lucretius, *On the Nature of Things* 2.646–51.

13. On the place of "fear" in Tertullian's thought, see *Spectacles* 1 and n. 10.

14. Cf. n. 9, above.

tence, we who alone drive them out of bodies.[15] Your curses answer that they exist and are filled with horror. You call a person a demon who, because of either his uncleanness or wickedness or insolence or whatever stain we attribute to the demons, is repulsive to the point of an unavoidable hatred. Finally, in every instance of annoyance and in every expression of contempt and detestation, you utter the word "Satan."[16] This is the one whom we call the angel of wickedness, the artificer of every error, the adulterator of the whole world. You, then, perceive who has destroyed you,[17] and know him in your hatred of him.

CHAPTER 4

We affirm that you continue to exist after the extinction of life and to await the day of judgment; and that, according to your deserts, you will be delivered either to torture or to bliss, both eternal; and that, in order to be capable of it, your former substance must necessarily return to you.[18] This is the Christian teaching, yet, because of its name, it is considered a mere delusion and a presumption. But we do not blush at our presumption if you share it. For, to begin with, when you mention someone who has died, you call him "poor fellow," not, of course,

15. Chrysippus of Soli (280–207 B.C.) was a pupil of Cleanthes, head of the Stoic school in succession to Zeno, its founder. Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers* 7.151, says, however, that the Stoics did, in fact, believe that *daemones* exist and are in sympathy with human beings. Tertullian may refer here to the derision the philosophers directed at the Christians' claim to exorcise demons (cf. Tibiletti, *La testimonianza,* 74).

16. The word *Satanas* is not attested in classical literature. Tertullian apparently ascribes to pagans the use of a biblical word to indicate that, when a pagan imprecates a curse, the Satan known to Christians is in fact invoked, even though not specifically under that name. In *Apology* 22 Tertullian anticipates the comment here: ". . . even the unlettered man of the street [makes frequent use of a curse, for in the same tone of execration he] pronounces the name of Satan, [the leader of the wicked race]—and does so as the result of the soul's instinctive knowledge" (cf. p. 46, above, where the text placed here in brackets is omitted).

17. "Who has destroyed you": *perditorem.* For Tertullian's doctrine of the primal Fall and its effect upon the soul, see the reference to *On the Soul* 41 in the introduction (p. 73). See also *Spectacles,* nn. 13 and 19.

18. Cf. *To the Martyrs,* n. 21, for references to Tertullian's treatise *On the Resurrection of the Dead,* where Tertullian shows that the flesh must arise to share with the soul in its rewards or punishments.

because he is snatched away from the good of life, but because he has already been delivered to punishment and judgment. Do you call one poor who does not feel anything? If you are incapable of suffering after death, if no power of feeling remains, why do you fear death at all? But, when you do fear, you know that it is an evil. Moreover, you would not know that it is an evil and be afraid of it, if you did not know that there exists something after death that makes it an evil, so that you are afraid of it.[19] But, perhaps you feel more sure about the capability of feeling after death than you do about the future resurrection, a doctrine of ours which is branded as a reckless supposition. Yet, this also is proclaimed by the soul. For, if someone inquires about a person who has died some time ago, thinking that he is still alive, the following answer readily comes to our lips: "He has already departed." He is, then, supposed to return.

CHAPTER 5

These testimonies of the soul are as true as they are simple, as simple as they are common, as common as they are universal, as universal as they are natural, as natural as they are divine.[20] I do not think that they can seem worthless and unimportant to anyone, if one should deliberate upon the majesty of nature from which the authority of the soul derives. As much as you will give to the teacher, so much you will award to the pupil: nature is the teacher; the soul is the pupil. Whatever either the one has taught or the other has learned has come from God, that is, the teacher of the teacher. What the soul can divine with regard to its chief teacher, you are able to judge from that which is within you. Is it really something strange if it knows him by whom it was

19. Tertullian's discussion on the fear of death echoes discussions commonly found in classical literature; cf., e.g., Plato, *Phaedo* (esp. 67A–72A), and Cicero, *Tusculan Disputations* 1.

20. The language in this paragraph and the next reflects Tertullian's effort to seek common ground with his pagan audience. Educated readers would be familiar with the Stoic doctrine of the "common ideas" and would appreciate his view that these "ideas" were "inborn," coming from the divine spark implanted in every soul. They precede pagan literature, but insofar as the latter explicates the ideas, it too becomes a trustworthy witness to them; see the introduction (pp. 72–73) to this treatise. The concept of the "common ideas" was applied to the apologetic endeavor by later writers as well; see Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* 2.1.7.

bestowed? Even deceived by its adversary, it remembers its author, his goodness and law, its own end, and its adversary. Is it so extraordinary, then, if, being a gift of God, it proclaims the same things that God has given to his own people to know?

But he who does not consider such outbursts of the soul as the doctrine of nature and the silent deposit of a congenital and inborn knowledge will rather say that the practice of speaking in this fashion has been strengthened by the opinions of published books that have been widely spread among the common people. At all events, the soul was prior to letters; speech, prior to books. Are we to believe, therefore, that before literature and its dissemination people lived without making utterances of this sort? And whence, I ask, did it happen that letters came to know and disseminate for the use of speech things that no mind had ever conceived, or tongue had ever expressed, or ear had ever heard? Now Divine Scripture is much older than secular letters;[21] if then, the soul has appropriated these utterances from letters, one must believe it has taken them from ours, not yours. For earlier works are more fitted for the instruction of the soul than later ones. Even if we should grant that the soul has been instructed from your writings, the tradition would reach back to the principal source—our writings.

CHAPTER 6

Therefore, trust your own books. As to our Scriptures, trust them all the more because they are divine. As to the judgment of the soul itself, trust nature in like manner. If you distrust your own literature, neither God nor nature is capable of lying. In order to trust nature as well as God, trust the soul. Among all the nations human nature is one and the same; there is one soul, though many tongues; one spirit, though many sounds. Each people has its own language, but the subject matter of every language is common to all. God and the goodness of God are everywhere, and everywhere is the testimony. Every soul justly proclaims those things that we are not allowed even to hint at. Deservedly, then, every soul is a defendant as well as a witness of the truth, and it will stand before the forecourts of God on the day of judgment without anything to say.

21. Cf. *Apology* 19.

3

SPECTACLES

Introduction

The ruins of ancient cities offer an impressive witness to the passion that the citizens of Rome and the empire felt for four kinds of entertainment: races in the circus; stage plays, mimes, pantomimes, and farces in the theater; athletic and other contests in the stadium; and gladiatorial combats and beast fights in the amphitheater. In the heart of modern Rome a vast ellipse marks the place of the ancient circus; only a few remains of the theater of Pompey in the Campus Martius have been found, but the shell of the theater of Marcellus is one of the most striking sights in the eternal city.[1] Just outside the ancient Roman Forum towers the great Colosseum, the immense amphitheater built by the Flavian emperors and dedicated in A.D. 80, while the modern Piazza Navona retains the contours of Domitian's stadium. In Tertullian's Carthage, too, archeology has revealed the once magnificent centers of popular entertainment—the amphitheater at Carthage, regarded as a marvel even in the Middle Ages, was capable of seating perhaps 35,000 spectators. Lesser provincial cities also clamored for shows. Indeed, remains from buildings that provided the space for shows are to

1. Cf. J. P. V. D. Balsdon, *Life and Leisure in Ancient Rome* (New York, N.Y.: McGraw-Hill, 1969), 255.

be found in virtually every city of any significance in North Africa, and their size suggests their importance: Thysdrus (modern El-Djem, some 250 kilometers south of Carthage) undertook to build in the early third century an amphitheater almost the size of that in Carthage. The importance to the populace of these shows may also be judged by the increasing time devoted to them. In Rome by the middle of the fourth century A.D., "one hundred and seventy-seven days of the year were the occasion of some regular games or other."[2] Obviously, then, spectacles played a central role in the life of pagan communities.[3]

Though Tertullian cannot have been the first to condemn the shows,[4] he is the first from whom we have a reasoned exposition of the case against the shows through an argument that finds in the shows the *locus* for a radical distinction between Christian and pagan. Addressing his treatise not only to the faithful, but also to catechumens preparing for baptism,[5] he focuses upon baptism as the primary event that distinguishes Christians from pagans, and he draws out the implications of baptism for the Christian who must make an evaluation of the popular entertainment of the pagan world. The issue was not merely academic. In spite of the bold claim in chapter 24 that Christians are marked primarily by their absence from the spec-

2. Balsdon, *Life and Leisure,* 248.

3. All the kinds of entertainment described here are included in the Latin term *spectacula,* a word that, like its English derivative, connotes in the singular a " show." To speak strictly, theatrical performances and chariot racing were *ludi,* "games"—the Latin word suggests "play"—while the gladiatorial and wild beast fights were *munera,* a word that originally implied a service to the dead. The contests in the stadium were *agones,* a transliteration of a Greek word meaning "contest."

4. Irenaeus, a Greek-speaker and the bishop of the Church in Lyons (second century), reveals his disapproval of "spectacles" by noting that it is at "spectacles" that heretics are to be found (*Against Heresies* 1.6.3); cf. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, eds., *The Ante-Nicene Fathers,* vol. I, *The Apostolic Fathers with Justin Martyr and Irenaeus,* American reprint, A. Cleveland Coxe, revised ed. (Grand Rapids, Mich.: William B. Eerdmans, 1989), 324.

5. Some scholars have conjectured from the pastoral role Tertullian seems to assume here that he was a priest; see Marie Turcan, ed., *Tertullien: Les spectacles,* Sources chrétiennes, vol. 332 (Paris: Les Éditions du Cerf, 1986), 43. Perhaps; but he appears to include himself among the laity in the much later treatise *Exhortation to Chastity* 7.3.

tacles, in practice some, perhaps many, Christians continued to enjoy the pleasures of pagan society. This we can infer from the mere existence of the present treatise, likewise from Tertullian's record (in the second chapter) of the debate among Christians on the matter, and, finally, from his account of the unpleasant circumstances of the Christian woman who attended the theater (chapter 26).

If we can agree with a recent editor that *Spectacles* followed shortly after the *Apology,*[6] we can see already developed in the latter work the fundamental lines of argument that would be applied in *Spectacles.* There (*Apology* 38), as here, Tertullian denounces the games on the grounds both of the superstitious idolatry and the immorality associated with them, but the argument is much more elaborate in *Spectacles.* Here he undertakes to show that at the spectacles one simply cannot extricate oneself from the idolatry that pervades their every aspect. Later, in *The Crown,* the argument will be extended to show that idolatry was a formidable objection to the Christian's participation in many activities, and we find the argument again in the treatise *On Idolatry.* In the shows everything was, beyond cure, tied to idolatrous practices, and the Christian could, by his or her presence there, only affirm the idolatry.

This argument is supported by fundamentally four considerations. There is, first, what we may call an ontological fact—in baptism Christians receive the Holy Spirit, thus becoming a new being; Christians must therefore endeavor to maintain that being in its integral condition. The Spirit received in baptism is tender and gentle and cannot sustain the raucous, not to say raw, passions aroused by spectacles. Second, Tertullian extends his argument to the interpretation of scriptural injunctions, as indeed queries from Christians invited him to do: if not directly, then by implication, Scripture does address the issue of Christian attendance at pagan games. Third, Tertullian observes the destructive character of the shows. He speaks of the uncontrollable passion in the circus leading to irrational affec-

6. Both Barnes, *Tertullian,* 54–55 and 325, and Marie Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 43, date the treatise to 197. Turcan places the treatise just after the *Apology;* Barnes originally thought it preceded (pp. 54–55), but in his Postscript of 1985 he prefers to place it after the *Apology* (p. 325).

tion and hatred, of the moral degradation of the theater, of the physical destructiveness of both theater and stadium, and of the terrible cruelty of the arena. Finally, Tertullian invites his readers to consider the implications of a sacramental view of life: in baptism our bodies acquire a new relationship—our hands, our lips, our voices are given to the praise of God; can these same instruments be used in the service of the demonic?

One will not leave unobserved the significance of the concluding chapters where Tertullian suggests that the re-orientation of experience in baptism leads the Christian to a wholly new concept of "pleasure" in which the tension of competitive strife is replaced by the peace of reconciliation, moral degradation by a pure conscience and a contented life, the thrill of spectacles by the drama of demons cast out and cures effected, and delight in pagan lyrics and literature by the joy found in the music of the Church and the narratives of the Holy Scriptures.[7]

The Text

CHAPTER 1

Learn, you servants of God who are just now entering upon his service, and you who have already affirmed and professed him,[8] recall what principle of faith, what reason inherent in truth, what rule in our way of life forbid the pleasures of the spectacles. Some may perhaps be allured by the opinions of pagans[9] who commonly use the following arguments against us in

7. We may note here that long after the Constantinian revolution and during the growing dominance of Christianity in the later empire the shows continued to be a contentious issue, an issue which often had as its central focus the relation between paganism and Christianity; see R. A. Markus, *The End of Ancient Christianity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), 107–23, 168–74.

8. Tertullian addresses those who are about to be baptized as well as those who have been baptized; the former he invites to "learn" as catechumens, the latter to "recall" what they once had learned as catechumens.

9. "Pagans": *ethnici*. Tertullian characteristically uses the Latin *ethnicus* in this treatise to refer to the pagans. The word is used in the Latin Vulgate translation in Matt. 6:7 and 18:17, where the Greek is rendered "heathen" (AV) or "Gentile" (NRSV). On the use of the word "pagan," see Robin Lane Fox, *Pagans and Christians* (New York, N.Y.: Alfred A. Knopf, 1987), 30–46. Fox stresses the cul-

this matter: such comforting and merely external pleasures of the eyes and ears are not opposed to religion, which is found in one's mind and conscience; nor is taking delight in such enjoyment in its proper time and place a sin as long as the fear of God[10] and God's honor remain unimpaired. (4) But this is precisely what we intend to prove: that these things are not compatible with true religion and true obedience to the true God.

CHAPTER 2

(1) Moreover, there is no one of our adversaries who will not offer this excuse, too: that all things have been created by God and handed over to mankind—just as we proclaim—and that they are undoubtedly good, as coming from a good Creator; and among them we must count all the various components that make up the spectacles, the horse, for instance, and the lion, the strength of body and the sweetness of voice.[11] Accordingly, they say that a thing that exists by God's creation cannot be considered either foreign or opposed to God.

(4) Now, no one denies—because everyone knows what nature of its own accord tells us—that God is the creator of the universe, and that this universe is good and has been made over to man by its creator.[12] (5) But because pagans have no real knowledge of God—knowing him only by natural law and not by right of friendship—it is inevitable that they prove ignorant

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tic associations appropriate to the word. For an interesting analysis of the language Tertullian uses to designate non-Christians, see I. L. S. Balfour, "Tertullian's Description of the Heathen," in Elizabeth A. Livingstone, ed., *Studia Patristica,* vol. 17, no. 2 (Oxford: Pergmon Press, 1992), 785–89.

10. For Tertullian fear of God (which does not exclude the love for God) serves as a fundamental presupposition and motivating force of the Christian life; cf. *Testimony of the Soul* 2, where fear of God appears as a natural instinct, hence a universal attribute of the religious life. For the theme in the New Testament, see, e.g., Rom. 3:18; 2 Cor. 7:1; Heb. 4:1; 1 Pet. 1:17 and 2:17; Rev. 14:7. The theme becomes a leit-motif in the study of Claude Rambaux, *Tertullien face aux morales des trois premiers siècles* (Paris: Société d'Édition "Les Belles Lettres," 1979).

11. Horse, lion, strength of body, and voice represent, respectively, circus, amphitheater, stadium and theater, the four kinds of shows Tertullian will discuss in this treatise.

12. On the natural knowledge of God as Creator, see *Apology* 17 and *Testimony of the Soul* 2.

of his commands regarding the use of his creation. Likewise, must they be unaware of the rival power that by its hostile actions seeks to falsify[13] the uses of divine creation. For, with such defective knowledge of God, one cannot know either his will or his adversary. (6) We must, then, consider not only by whom all things were created, but also by whom they were perverted.

(7) Why, every form of evil-doing—misdeeds which also pagans forbid and punish as indubitably such—comes from things created by God. (8) You see murder committed by iron dagger, poison, or magic incantation: but iron, poisonous herbs, angels[14] are all equally creatures of God. Yet, did the creator design those creatures of his for the destruction of humanity? Certainly not. He forbids man-slaying by the one summary commandment: "Thou shalt not kill."[15] (10) Man himself, the perpetrator of every kind of villainy, is not only the work of God, but also his likeness[16]—yet, both in body and spirit it has fallen away from his Creator. For we did not receive the eyes for gratifying carnal appetite, the tongue for speaking evil, the ears for listening to slander;[17] nor was the spirit implanted in the body that it might become a workshop for contriving acts of treachery and fraud and injustice. (11) For if God, who demands innocence of us, hates all wickedness, even if it be only in thought, then it is certain beyond all doubt that it was never his intention in creation that whatever he created should lead to acts he condemns, even if those acts are done through the medium of his handiwork. The whole reason for condemnation is, rather, the misuse of God's creation by God's creatures.[18]

13. "Falsify": *adulterandis;* just below, "were perverted" renders *conversa.* For the "rival power," i.e., Satan and his demons, and for the vitiation of God's creation, see *Apology* 22–23 and 46, and *Testimony of the Soul* 3.

14. For Tertullian Satan's minions included both demons and angels; see *Apology* 22 and nn. 99–107, and the article "angels" in the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity.* Tertullian also witnesses here to the belief, widespread in antiquity, that magical imprecations were able to effect death.

15. Cf. Ex. 20:13 and Matt. 5:21.

16. Cf. Gen. 1:26–27.

17. Tertullian implicitly acknowledges here the view expressed in *The Crown* 5 that human organs have certain natural uses—to circumvent which is in some measure a perversion.

18. The argument appears in a slightly different form in *The Apparel of Women* I 8.3–6; cf. also *The Crown* 8 and 10.

(12) We, therefore, in coming to know the Lord, have also looked upon his rival, and in learning the creator, we have likewise detected the adulterator;[19] we ought, then, to feel neither surprise nor doubt. For man himself, God's handiwork and image, the lord of the whole universe, was cast down in the very beginning from his state of innocence by the power of that angel, both rival to God and adulterator; at the same time, he turned against the creator not only man, but with man the entire material world, man's possession, which had been created like man for perfect wholeness. He was angry that God had given the world to the human race and not to him, and so he intended to make mankind guilty before God in possessing the world, and to establish his own power in it.[20]

CHAPTER 3

(1) Armed with this knowledge against the opinion of pagans, let us now turn to the same excuses put forward by people in our own ranks. For there are some brethren who, being either too naive or over-particular in their faith, demand a testimony from the Scriptures[21] when faced with giving up the spectacles, and declare the matter an open question, because such a renunciation is not specifically enjoined upon the servants of God. (2) Now, to be sure, nowhere do we find that, just as it is it laid down with precision "Thou shalt not kill," "Thou shalt not worship an idol,"[22] so clearly is it declared: "Thou shalt not go to the circus," "Thou shalt not go to the theater," "Thou shalt not watch a contest or show of gladiators." (3) But we do find that to this special case there can be applied that first verse of David, where he says: "Happy is the man who has not gone to the gathering of the ungodly, nor stood in the ways of sinners, nor sat in the chair of pestilence."[23] (4) For, even though

19. "Adulterator": *interpolatorem*—one who falsifies, recasts, making a thing fall short of its original perfection, that is, its original integrity. Thus, in the next sentence, "state of innocence" and "perfect wholeness" each renders—appropriately—forms of the Latin *integritas;* cf. *Apology* 22 and n. 102.

20. For the devil's envy see Wisdom 2:24.

21. "Scriptures": here simply *scripturis,* unqualified; cf. "divine Scriptures," *scriptura divina,* just below, and *Apology,* n. 103.

22. See Ex. 20:13 and 4–5.

23. Ps. 1:1.

David seems to have foretold that well-known just man,[24] because he took no part in the gathering and meeting of the Jews deliberating on the killing of the Lord, divine Scripture admits always a broader interpretation wherever a passage, after its actual sense has been exhausted,[25] serves to strengthen discipline. So, in this case, too, the verse of David is not inapplicable to the prohibition of spectacles. (5) For if then he called a mere handful of Jews "a gathering of the ungodly," how much more such a vast crowd of pagans? Are pagans less ungodly, less sinners, less the enemies of Christ than the Jews were then?

CHAPTER 4

(1) I shall now appeal to the prime and principal authority of our "seal"[26] itself. When we step into the water and profess the Christian faith in the terms prescribed by its law,[27] we bear

24. The "just man" refers to Joseph of Arimathea; cf. Luke 23: 50–51. "Foretold" renders *praedicasse,* translated by Arbesmann as "praised"; Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 105, prefers "proclaimed," a word that might suggest both praise and prophecy.

25. "Actual sense" apparently means "literal sense," but Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 108–9, prefers to understand, "Scripture broadly extends its multiple meanings to all cases where the interpretation which the present circumstance demands makes it a bulwark for conduct." In any case, it seems that Tertullian understands that this passage can be interpreted in two ways: (1) allegorically, as a prophetic forecast of events in the life of Christ; insofar as this was the sense intended by the author—assumed to be David—it could be regarded as the actual or literal sense; (2) as a moral exhortation (the moral sense), a reading that later came to be known as "tropological." These two ways of reading Scripture are already evident in Justin Martyr *Apology* I 40. Tertullian offers guidelines for the interpretation of Scripture in his treatise *On the Resurrection of the Dead* 18–21, where he attempts to impose "controls" on the allegorization of Scripture.

26. The "seal" (*signaculum)* here means the sacrament of baptism. From later sources we know that the candidate for baptism renounced publicly, before the whole Christian congregation, "the Devil and his pomp and his angels," i.e., paganism, its worship, and lax morality; the candidate then proceeded to the baptistry for baptism by immersion. See nn. 27 and 28, below.

27. "Its law" is the law of faith, which Tertullian describes elsewhere as the "rule (*regula)* of faith," a statement of belief more or less equivalent to the Apostle's Creed (see *On the Veiling of Virgins* 1.3–4). In baptism the candidate was immersed three times in the water, each time, in response to a question, declaring his faith in, respectively, God, Christ, and the Holy Spirit (cf. *The Crown,* n.

public witness that we have renounced the Devil and his pomp and his angels.[28] (2) What, however, shall we call the chief and foremost manifestation by which the Devil and his pomp and his angels are recognized, if not idolatry? From this source comes every unclean and evil spirit. (3) So, if it shall be proved true that the entire apparatus of the spectacles originates from idolatry, we will have reached a decision in advance that our profession of faith in baptism refers also to the spectacles, since spectacles belong to the Devil and his pomp and his angels because of the idolatry involved.

(4) We shall, therefore, set forth the origins of the various spectacles, explaining in what nurseries they grew up; next in order, the titles of some of them, that is, the names by which they are called; then their equipment and the superstitions observed in them; thereafter the places and the presiding spirits to whom they are dedicated; and, finally, the arts employed in them and the authors to whom they are ascribed. If, among these, we find anything that is not related to an idol, we shall declare it to be free from the stain of idolatry and, as a result, to have no connection with our renunciation.

[In chapters 5–12 Tertullian follows the program he has just announced, citing the evidence from four types of spectacles or "games" *(ludi):* races in the circus *(ludi circenses)*, exhibitions in the theater *(ludi scaenici)*, athletic and musical contests *(agones)*, and gladiatorial displays in the amphitheater *(munera)*. From the extensive evidence he offers, the few excerpts given here are merely representative.[29]]

13). It is not, however, certain that in the time of Tertullian the candidate responded to the triple interrogation with the respective parts of a declaratory creed (like the Apostle's Creed). For the relation of baptism to creed, see J. N. D. Kelly, *Early Christian Creeds,* 3d ed. (London: Longman, 1972), 30–49.

28. Apparently a ritual formula, to which reference is made again in *The Crown* 3 and 13; see *The Crown* nn. 14 and 71. "Pomp" referred to idolatry in all its aspects and manifestations. Cf. *On Idolatry* 18.8. For a fundamental study of the expression, see J. H. Waszink, *"Pompa Diaboli," Vigiliae Christianae* 1 (1947): 13–47.

29. For an informative and interesting account of Roman spectacles, see Balsdon, *Life and Leisure,* 244–339. Balsdon touches upon various issues Tertullian addresses in the selections offered here.

CHAPTER 5

(1) Concerning the origins of the spectacles, authors give the following report. The Lydians migrated from Asia and settled in Etruria, where they introduced the spectacles in the name of religion. From that place the Romans invited the performers, borrowing also the name, so that the "performers" [*ludii*] were so called from the "Lydians" [*Lydii*].[30] (4) But it is, after all, not the name that matters; the real issue is idolatry. In fact, since the games generally went under the name of Liberalia, they clearly proclaimed the honor of Father Liber. They were first held in honor of Liber by the country folk because of the blessing they say he bestowed upon them by making known to them the delicious taste of wine.[31] (8) On a later date, Romulus instituted games in honor of Jupiter Feretrius at the Tarpeian Rock, which were called Tarpeian and Capitoline Games.[32] After him, Numa Pompilius initiated games in honor of Mars and Robigo—for they invented also a goddess of *robigo*

30. Tertullian expresses the (probably incorrect) view of Herodotus, *History* 1.94, that the Etruscans were Lydians from Asia Minor (Sardis was their later capital), who emigrated to Italy, and were the inventors of the games common to themselves and the Greeks. According to Livy, *History of Rome* 7.2, Etruscan actors came to Rome in 364 B.C. It is not true, however, that the Latin word for "games," *ludi,* is derived from *Lydii,* "Lydians." For the connotation of *ludi,* "games," see the introduction to this treatise, n. 3, above.

31. Liber was an old Italic deity, originally a fertility god, who came to be regarded as a god of wine. In time he became associated with Dionysus, the Greek god of wine. Tertullian recalls an early period, before the time of Romulus, when the only games were the Liberalia, so that *ludi* and *liberalia* were in effect synonymous.

32. The "capitol," the lofty citadel of Rome, was originally called the Tarpeian hill. According to Livy, *History of Rome* 1.10.5–6, Romulus, legendary founder of Rome (ca. 750 B.C.), dedicated a temple on the capitol to Jupiter Feretrius, that is, the Jupiter who subdues enemies, in order to celebrate his victory in the war that followed the "rape of the Sabine women" by the Romans; nothing is said by Livy here, however, of establishing Tarpeian games. But Livy also indicates (5.50.4) that the Capitoline games were established to honor Jupiter for the preservation of his temple on the Capitol during the Gallic invasion (390 B.C.). The Capitoline games may have replaced older Tarpeian games, but it is possible that "Tarpeian and Capitoline" is tautologous and together refer to the "Capitoline" games; the expression "Tarpeian games" appears nowhere else.

[mildew].[33] This will suffice to prove the guilty origin of the games in idolatry.

CHAPTER 6

(1) The titles by which the games still go today betray the nature of their origin. In these titles there is clearly expressed for what idol and for what superstition the games of either kind[34] were designed. (2) For instance, the games of the Great Mother and Apollo, and also those of Ceres, Neptune, Jupiter Latiaris, and Flora are general festivals;[35] the remaining trace their superstitious origin back to birthdays and commemorative celebrations of the emperors,[36] to happy political events, and to municipal feasts. (3) Among them are also the funeral games, established by bequests to render honor to the memory of private persons.[37] But in the question of idolatry, it makes no difference to us under what name or title they are exhibited, as long as the matter concerns the same spirits that we renounce.

33. Numa Pompilius (ca. 700 B.C.) was the legendary second king of Rome. He was said to have done much to develop religion among the Romans. Mars is the god of war; Robigo the god who protected against rust. There are relatively few indications that the two deities were associated.

34. I.e., games in honor of the gods and games in honor of the dead, as described immediately below.

35. In Latin the names (i.e., the titles) of these games are adjectival, e.g., Megalensian, Apollinarian, etc. Their titles therefore clearly reveal an idolatrous origin: Megalensian, from the Greek *megale* for "great mother" (Cybele), hence the games in her honor, the games in honor of Apollo, etc. The list includes four of the six great public games: those in honor of the Great Mother, Apollo, Ceres and Flora; the two it omits—the Roman games and the People's games—have titles lacking the names of gods. Hence for these Tertullian substitutes the games in honor of Jupiter Latiaris (the Jupiter of the Latin peoples; cf. *Apology* 9 and n. 49, above) and of Neptune. These annual games were in each case celebrated on holidays.

36. "Emperors": *regum,* more frequently "kings" or "rulers," which may include emperors, but Tertullian may rather have in mind here the period of the early Roman rulers.

37. Livy, *History of Rome* 23.30.15, describes funeral games lasting for three days during which twenty-two pairs of gladiators fought. They were given in 216 B.C. in honor of Marcus Aemilius Lepidus, who had served as consul. The first gladiatorial combats in Rome were apparently given in 264 B.C. as a gift of sons in honor of their father; cf. n. 58, below.

CHAPTER 7

(2) The equipment, also, of both kinds of games must be the same because of the common guilt of idolatry which founded them. Somewhat greater pomp, however, is displayed in the spectacles in the circus, to which the term [*pompa*] is properly applied. The *pompa*—"procession"[38]—which comes first, proves in itself to whom it belongs, with the long line of idols, the unbroken train of images, the chariots and coaches and cars, the portable thrones and garlands, and the attributes of the gods.[39] (3) Moreover, how many sacred rites are observed, how many sacrifices offered at the beginning, in the course, and at the end of the procession, how many religious corporations, furthermore, how many priesthoods, how many bodies of magistrates are called upon to march in it—all of this is known to the inhabitants of Rome, that city where all the demons have gathered and taken up their abode. (4) And if in the provinces less care is given to management of the games because of less ample funds, all the spectacles in the circus everywhere must be considered as belonging to the model from which they are copied.[40] The pomp of the circus, whatever its nature, offends God. Even if there be carried but a few idols in procession, it takes only one to have idolatry.

CHAPTER 8

(1) In accordance with my plan, I shall deal next with the places. The circus is consecrated to the Sun. The temple of the

38. *Pompa* is a Latinization of the Greek word *pompe,* meaning "a solemn procession."

39. The imagery here alludes to some of the chief elements in a procession that preceded the games in the Circus, and that started from the Capitol, passed through the Forum, and concluded in the Circus. The "idols" were statues of the gods and of divinized emperors, "images" were statues, busts, or wax portraits of the dead, the "chariots" perhaps carried the magistrate who presided at the games (identified with Jupiter by his dress), "coaches" carried the "attributes" (i.e., the paraphernalia) of the gods, "cars" conveyed the images of people who had received divine honors, while statues of some deities (e.g., Cybele) apparently made their way on portable "thrones." A procession to the games is described in Dionysius of Halicarnassus, *Roman Antiquities* 7.72. See also Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 146–51.

40. I.e., the Roman model.

Sun stands in the middle of it, and his image shines forth from the pediment of the temple.[41] How many evidences of idol worship do you recognize in the decoration of the place? (3) Every ornament of the circus is a temple by itself. The eggs are regarded as sacred to Castor and Pollux; the dolphins spout water in honor of Neptune.[42] (5) The huge obelisk has been set up[43] in honor of the Sun. The gathering of the demons was cold and limp without their Great Mother, so she presides there over the ditch.[44] (7) You, Christian, have nothing to do with a place that so many diabolic spirits have made their own.

(8) But, you say, what will happen if I enter the circus at some other time? Shall I be then, too, in danger of contamination? There is no law laid down with regard to places as such. For not only these places where people gather for the spectacles but also the temples may be entered by the servant of God without peril to our rule of life, provided that one does so for an urgent and honest reason that has no connection with the business and function proper to the place. (9) Moreover, there is no place—whether streets or marketplace or baths or taverns or even our own homes—that is completely free of idols: Satan

41. The Circus was, in fact, a circle with a central axis (the *spina*) around which charioteers drove their horses. It thus served as a symbol of the sun making its way around the world. The "temple" in the center of the *spina* may have been an obelisk surmounted by a sphere or a flame.

42. Castor and Pollux were twins who, according to one form of the story, were born from an egg laid by their mother, Leda. After their death they were recognized as deities. As Castor had excelled in horsemanship, the two together became the patrons of horsemanship. To complete a race chariots circled the *spina* seven times. Each lap completed was marked by lowering at one end of the *spina* one of seven egg-shaped balls from a platform, and at the other end by lowering or turning a dolphin (sacred to Neptune). Spectators could thus determine at any point how far the race had progressed.

43. "Set up": *prostituta*—the word is probably intended to have sexual connotations. Augustus brought this obelisk from Egypt to Rome in 10 B.C. It is found today in the Piazza del Popolo.

44. In this sentence "was cold and limp" renders *frigebat*—again a sexual connotation may be intended. The Great Mother, Cybele, was originally a Phrygian goddess, brought to Rome in 204/205 B.C., at a time of crisis during the wars with Hannibal. She is represented on some monuments as seated on a lion in the *spina* near the central obelisk. The *spina* came to be known as the "ditch." For Cybele's love for Attis, see *Apology* n. 69.

and his angels have filled the whole world. (10) Yet, it is not by our being in the world that we fall away from God, but by taking part in some sins of the world.[45]

CHAPTER 9

(1) Next let us consider the arts displayed in the circus games. In times past, equestrian skill was simply a matter of riding on horseback. But when this skill was pressed into the service of the games, it was changed from a gift of God into an instrument of the demons. (2) Accordingly, this kind of exhibition is regarded as sacred to Castor and Pollux, to whom horses were allotted by Mercury.[46] (3) Moreover, concerning the chariot, the four-horse team was consecrated to the Sun; the two-horse team, to the Moon:[47] "Erichthonius first dared to yoke four steeds to the car."[48] This Erichthonius is a demon-monster, or, rather, the Devil himself, not a mere snake.[49] (4)

45. Cf. John 17:15; 1 Cor. 5:9–10. In *On Idolatry* Tertullian explores in much more detail the problem addressed here, and attempts to draw a fine line between activities permitted and those not permitted: a goldsmith may make objects for a home but not for a temple; one may go to the schools to learn but not to teach; one may accept social engagements provided one is not invited specifically as an attendant at or a participant in a sacrifice. See *On Idolatry* 8, 10, 11, 16.

46. Castor and Pollux were celebrated as outstanding horsemen (see n. 42, above). Their horses drank from the pool of Juturna in the Roman Forum (a place still shown to visitors) after they had made a miraculous appearance at the battle of Lake Regillus (496 B.C.) and had brought the news of the victory to Rome. A fragment from the Greek poet Stesichorus (ca. 575 B.C.) attests the support in the literary tradition for the claim made here that they received their horses from Hermes (equated with the Roman Mercury) and Hera (Juno) for the funeral games of Pelius.

47. In both literary texts and sculpted monuments, the sun is generally portrayed as riding in a four-horse chariot, the moon in a two-horse chariot. See, for example, Virgil, *Aeneid* 6.535 (four-horse chariot); *Aeneid* 5.721 and 7.26 (two-horse chariot).

48. The words are cited from Virgil, *Georgics* 3.113–14.

49. Erichthonius was a legendary king of Athens who was supposed to have instituted the Panathenaea in Athens, a festival which came to include horse races. The fire-god, Hephaestus, attempted to violate the goddess Athena; in his struggle with her, he spilled his semen on her thigh, which she wiped off and threw on the earth. From this Erichthonius was born in semi-serpentine form; the legend might thus evoke for Christians the image of the serpent-tempter of Gen. 3. To Erichthonius was generally attributed the invention of the four-horse chariot.

And if, at Rome, Romulus was the first to display a four-horse chariot, he, too, has been enrolled among the idols himself.[50] (5) The chariots having been produced by such inventors, it was only fitting that they clad their drivers in the colors of idolatry. For some have dedicated the red to Mars, others the white to the Zephyrs, the green to Mother Earth or Spring, the blue to Sky and Sea or Autumn. (6) The condemnation of idolatry certainly applies also to the idolatry that is impiously offered to the elements of the world.[51]

CHAPTER 10

(1) Let us pass on to the exhibitions on the stage. (2) The pageantry is the same as that in the circus, inasmuch as a procession is held to the theater from the temples and altars, with that whole wretched business of incense and blood, to the tune of flutes and trumpets, under the direction of the two most polluted masters of ceremonies at funerals and sacrifices: the undertaker and soothsayer.[52]

(3) Now we will turn to the performances on the stage. The theater is, strictly speaking, a shrine of Venus. It was in that ca-

50. Tertullian dates the appearance of the four-horse chariot in Rome to the time when Romulus organized games for the festival called the Consualia, on which occasion the Sabine women were carried off. Romulus, legendary founder of Rome, was, according to one version of his life, apotheosized and came to be identified with the old Sabine god, Quirinus.

51. "The elements of the world"—the phrase is perhaps intended to recall, e.g., Gal. 4:3 and Col. 2:8, 20. Four parties, named after colors—the Whites, Reds, Greens, and Blues—claimed the often passionate loyalties of those who watched the races. The charioteers were dressed in the color of their respective parties. Tertullian sees in the colors a cosmological symbolism, which, in his representation, may conflate the four elements of nature (fire, air, earth and water) with the seasons and the terrestrial and heavenly bodies.

52. This description confirms what little we know about the procession to the theater. It was much less impressive than that to the circus, and probably consisted of some of the actors and musicians involved in the performances, along with priests, soothsayers (*haruspices,* i.e., men who declared the future or the divine will by looking at the entrails of sacrificial animals), and undertakers (men who organized funeral processions), as well as animal victims for sacrifice, since sacrifice preceded the performance. By noting undertakers (men daily in association with death) and soothsayers (men who looked into the cadavers of wild beasts), Tertullian adds two details that turn the procession to the theater into a cortege of death; see Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 182–83.

pacity, after all, that this type of structure gained influence in the world. (4) For the censors foresaw the great danger arising from the theater's lasciviousness. (5) So, when Pompey the Great had erected that citadel of all vile practices, he built on top of it a shrine of Venus and termed it not a theater, but a temple of Venus, "under which," he said, "we have put tiers of seats for viewing the shows."[53] (6) Venus and Liber [Bacchus], however, are close companions. The two demons have banded together in a sworn confederacy of drunkenness and lust. (7) Therefore, the temple of Venus is also the house of Liber. For stage performances were instituted by Liber. (8) And the arts of the stage are under the patronage of Liber and Venus. Those features that are peculiar to, and characteristic of, the stage, that wantonness in gesture and posture, they dedicate to Venus and Liber, deities both dissolute: the former by her sex, the latter by effeminate dress.[54] (12) As far as the arts are concerned, we ought to have gone further back and taken exception to all further arguments, on the ground that the demons, from the very beginning looking out for themselves, contrived, along with the other foul practices of idolatry, also those of the shows in order to turn the human race from the Lord and bind it to their glorification, and gave inspiration to people of genius in these particular arts. You will hate, O Christian, the things whose authors you cannot help but hate.

Let us now begin the treatment of the contests [*agones*].[55]

53. Pompey completed his theater during his second consulship (55 B.C.). Tacitus reports the disapproval of Pompey's contemporaries and the continuing criticism a century later of the moral laxity encouraged by the theater (*Annals* 14.20.3–5). According to Aulus Gellius, *Attic Nights* 10.1.7, Tiro, Cicero's freedman, acknowledged that Pompey had built a temple, the steps of which formed a theater, that is, the steps to the temple would provide the seats for the theater (see Balsdon, *Life and Leisure,* 254 and plate 1c). The Romans had long had wooden theaters that could be dismantled or moved, and the objection to Pompey's theater seems to have been that it was a permanent stone structure.

54. Tertullian here assumes the identification of the Roman Liber with the Greek Dionysus, from dances in honor of whom Greek theater is thought to have originated. In place of "effeminate dress" some scholars understand "swaying gait," referring to the god's drunkenness rather than his effeminacy.

55. Among the *agones,* athletic contests were predominant, but there were also contests in poetry and music.

CHAPTER 11

(1) Their origin is akin to that of the games. They, too, are instituted either as sacred or as funereal and are performed to honor either the gods of the Gentiles or the dead. (2) What wonder is it, then, if the whole paraphernalia of these contests is tainted with idolatry—with unholy crowns, priestly superintendents, assistants from the sacred colleges, and last, but not least, with the blood of bulls?[56] (3) To add a supplementary remark concerning the place: as you may expect from a place where the arts of the Muses, of Minerva, of Apollo, and even of Mars meet in common, with contest and sound of trumpet they endeavor to equal the circus in the stadium, which is no doubt a temple. (4) The gymnastic arts also had their origin in the teachings of the Castors and Herculeses and Mercuries.[57]

CHAPTER 12

(1) It still remains to examine the most prominent and most popular spectacle of all. It is called *munus* ["an obligatory service"] from being an *officium* ["a duty"]. For the ancients thought they were performing a duty to the dead by this sort of spectacle. (2) For in time long past, in accordance with the belief that the souls of the dead are propitiated by human blood, they used to purchase captives or slaves of inferior condition and to sacrifice them at funerals.[58] (3) Afterwards, the persons thus pro-

56. Priests presided at the contests. The Greek *agones* included a sacrifice offered to the hero or divinity in whose honor the contests were given (there is less evidence for sacrifice at the Roman games). Priests and presiding officials may have worn crowns, but crowns were also given to the winner, who was identified with the hero or divinity. Cf. *The Crown* 13, and for some description of the contests, see Suetonius, *Domitian* 4.4.

57. Minerva (= Athena) was thought to have invented wind instruments, Apollo the lyre; Mars was the god of battles. Hercules, legendary founder of the Olympic games, was thought to have entrusted the presidency of the games to the twins, Castor and Pollux, who, admired for their skill and valor in fight, represented the athletic ideal of the Greeks. Due to his dexterity, Mercury was celebrated as the patron of gymnastic skills.

58. Cf., e.g., the sacrifice of Trojan captives at the tomb of Achilles, Homer, *Iliad* 23.166–77. From the classical literary tradition see, e.g., Euripides, *Hecuba* 218–28, 518–80, which is a telling adaptation of the myth of the sacrifice of Polyxena at the tomb of Achilles. For the thirst of the dead for blood, see *Odyssey* 11. 23–99 and 138–54. According to Valerius Maximus, *Memorable Deeds*

cured were trained in the use of arms, and exposed to death at the tombs on the day appointed for sacrifices in honor of the dead. (4) Gradually the refinement of pagans progressed in the same proportion as their cruelty, and they were not satisfied unless human bodies were torn to pieces also by wild beasts.[59] What was then a sacrifice offered for the appeasement of the dead was no doubt considered a rite in honor of the dead. This sort of thing is, therefore, idolatry, because idolatry is a service rendered to dead persons. (5) It is, furthermore, in the images of the dead that the demons have their abode.[60]

To come to the consideration of the titles: though this type of exhibition has become an act in honor of the living—I mean those entering upon quaestorships, magistracies, flaminates, and priesthoods—still, since the dignity of the name cannot escape the charge of idolatry, whatever is carried out in the name of this dignity shares necessarily in the taint of its origin.[61] (6) In the same way we must interpret the paraphernalia that are considered as belonging to the ceremonies of these very offices. For the purple robes, the fasces, the fillets, and crowns, and the pottage dinners given on the eve of exhibitions do not lack the pomp of the Devil and the invitation of demons.[62] (7) What

and Sayings 2.4.7, the first gladiatorial combat in Rome was given (in 264 B.C.) by the sons of Brutus Pera to honor the ashes of their father. Tertullian's description of the origin of the gladiatorial shows is essentially confirmed by Balsdon, *Life and Leisure,* 248–49.

59. Animal baiting, though not strictly a *munus,* came to be attached to the gladiatorial combats. Though some people faced the animals well armed and well trained and with little risk of death, others had to fight virtually stripped, while criminals were sometimes thrown to the beasts, almost naked and with both hands tied behind their backs. A vivid account is found in "The Martyrdom of Saints Perpetua and Felicitas," in Musurillo, *Acts,* 127–31.

60. I.e., demons inhabit the idols, which are images of dead people. The theory is explained in *Apology* 11, 12, 22.

61. After 105 B.C. it fell to the magistrates to offer these shows, in doing which they could win honor for themselves. Under the empire, during the first century A.D., when the magistracies were tightly controlled by the emperor, the games contributed especially to the honor of the donor. Families also continued to offer gladiatorial combats in honor of their dead. The shows might be given either in the name (under the title) of the dead whom they honored, or of the donor; see Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 210–11.

62. The purple robes and the fasces were the attributes of magistrates, the fillets and crowns of priests. On the eve of the show a meal was offered to those

shall I say about the place? For the amphitheater is consecrated to names more numerous and more dreadful than the Capitol, temple of all demons as it is. And to say a final word about the arts concerned, we know that Mars and Diana are the patrons of both types of games.[63]

CHAPTERS 13–14
Omitted

CHAPTER 15

(1) So much, then, for the main charge: idolatry. Now let us also point out that the other characteristics of the things going on at the spectacles are all opposed to God. (2) God has given us the command both to deal with the Holy Spirit in tranquility, gentleness, quiet, and peace, inasmuch as it is tender and sensitive, and also not to vex it by frenzy, bitterness of feeling, anger, and grief. (3) How, then, can the Holy Spirit have anything to do with spectacles? There is no spectacle without violent agitation of the spirit.[64] For even if a person enjoys spectacles modestly and soberly, one cannot go to them without the mind being roused and the spirit being stirred by some unspoken agitation. (6) No one ever approaches a pleasure such as this without passion; no one experiences this passion without its damaging effects.

CHAPTER 16

(1) Since, then, frenzy is forbidden us, we are debarred from every type of spectacle, including the circus, where frenzy rules

about to die (see the account of the meal in "The Martyrdom of Saints Perpetua and Felicitas," in Musurillo, *Acts,*125). It is unclear whether by the phrase "invitation of demons" Tertullian means that the demons are invited or that they invite.

63. Mars was patron of the gladiatorial combats; Diana, goddess of the hunt, was patron of animal baiting.

64. On the gentle and peace-loving character of the Spirit, see Eph. 4:30–31; Gal. 5:16–25. This characterization is found repeatedly in Tertullian's work, e.g., *To the Martyrs* 1; see also *On Patience* 15.4–6 and *On Baptism* 8.3–4. The delicacy and tenderness of the Spirit was a theme already expressed (early second century) in Hermas, *The Shepherd* (Mandates 5.2–3). Here and in the next sentence "spirit" renders the Latin *spiritus,* which suggests the close relationship envisioned between the Holy Spirit and the Christian's spirit.

supreme. Look at the populace, frenzied even as it comes to the show, wildly excited over its wagers. (2) They await the signal with bated breath; one outcry voices the common madness: (3) "He has thrown it!" they shout; everyone tells everybody else what all of them have seen just that moment.[65] (4) From such beginnings the affair progresses to outbursts of fury and passion and discord and to everything forbidden to the priests of peace. Next come curses, insults without any justified reason for the hatred, and rounds of applause without the reward of affection. (6) God who forbids us to hate does not permit us to curse even with cause.[66]

CHAPTER 17

(1) In like manner we are commanded to steer clear of every kind of impurity. By this command we are precluded also from the theater, (2) whose greatest charm is produced by its filth—which the actor of the Atellan farces conveys by gestures, the mimic actor exhibits by womanish apparel, the pantomime experiences in his own body from boyhood in order to become an artist. (3) Even the very prostitutes are brought upon the stage and exhibited in public before the eyes of persons of every age and rank; their address, their price, their record are publicly announced.[67]

65. The races were preceded by betting. The gates, or starting places for the chariots, were determined by lot (shaking the urn). The praetor, a senior magistrate, presided and dropped a cloth from his balcony to signal the beginning of a race.

66. Cf. Luke 6:27–28; Rom. 12:14.

67. The Atellan farces offered the viewer coarse, indecent scenes from everyday life with stock figures such as the glutton; as the actors wore masks, gesture was important in conveying nuances. The mimes, played without actors' masks, represented licentious themes. (Some editors prefer to read the clause "the mimic actor exhibits by womanish apparel" as "the mime exhibits through women," thus adding the objection that women go on stage.) The pantomime was performed by a single actor playing many roles, and with gestures only (the text was sung by an accompanist). One needed extensive training from boyhood to achieve the suppleness of body required to perform all parts, including those represented by women. At the festival of the goddess Flora, courtesans were brought on stage as actors for a day, performing in the nude. The licentiousness of the festivals of Flora is attested by Ovid, *Fasti* 5.347–68. Cf. *Apology,* n. 69. For further description of the mime, pantomime, and Atellan farce, see Balsdon, *Life and Leisure,* 274–79.

(6) You have, therefore, the theater prohibited in the prohibition of uncleanness.

Again, if we reject the learning of the world's literature as convicted of foolishness before God,[68] we have a sufficiently clear rule also concerning those types of spectacles that, in the world's literature, are classified as belonging to the comic or tragic stage. (7) Now, if tragedies and comedies are bloody and wanton, impious and prodigal inventors of outrage and lust, the recounting of what is atrocious or base is no better; what is objectionable in deed is not acceptable in word.

CHAPTER 18

(1) As for what is done in the stadium, you cannot deny that it is unfit for you to see—punches and kicks and blows and every disfiguration of the human face, that is, of God's image.[69] (2) Never can you approve the foolish racing and throwing feats and the more foolish jumping contests; never can you be pleased with either harmful or foolish[70] exhibitions of strength nor with the cultivation of an unnatural body, outdoing the craftsmanship of God. (3) Also, the art of wrestling belongs to the Devil's trade: it was the Devil who first crushed the human race. The very movements of the wrestler have a snakelike quality.[71] Crowns are of no use to you; why do you seek pleasure from crowns?[72]

CHAPTER 19

(1) Are we now to wait for a scriptural repudiation of the amphitheater, also? If we can claim that cruelty, impiety, and brutality are permitted us, let us by all means go to the amphitheater. (2) "But it is a good thing when the guilty are punished." Who will deny this but the guilty? Yet it is not becoming for the

68. Cf. 1 Cor. 3:19. "World's literature": *saecularis litteraturae.*

69. Cf. Gen. 1:27. Tertullian apparently refers to the "pankration," which combined both wrestling and extremely brutal boxing.

70. "Foolish . . . more foolish . . . foolish" represents the Latin *vanos . . . vaniores . . . vanae,* probably in the sense of having no usefulness to either spectator or athlete (cf. 1 Tim. 4:7–8), or of seeking vain-glory by the athlete. For the idea, see *Apology* 38 and n. 130.

71. An allusion to Gen. 3:1–20.

72. I.e., the crowns given to the winner in the contest; cf. *The Crown* 13.

guiltless to take pleasure in the punishment of another. (3) And who is my voucher that it is the guilty always who are condemned to the beasts, or whatever punishment, and that it is never inflicted on innocence.[73] (4) Certain it is that innocent men are sold as gladiators to serve as victims of public pleasure.[74] (5) This reply I have addressed to pagans.[75] Heaven forbid that a Christian should need any further instruction about the detestableness of this kind of spectacle.

CHAPTER 20

(1) How foolish, then, is the reasoning of those who, obviously as a subterfuge to avoid the loss of pleasure, plead as their excuse that no regulation concerning such an abstinence is laid down in Scripture in precise terms. (2) Only recently I heard a novel defense offered by one of these devotees of the games. "The sun," he said, "indeed, even God himself, looks on from heaven and is not defiled." (4) My good fellow, you are putting the defendant on the same footing as the judge: the defendant who is a defendant because he is seen, and the judge who, because he sees, is judge. (5) Do we, perhaps, give free play to lewdness outside the gates of the theater just because God has eyes also outside the covered seats and the tiers and the stage? We are wrong: nowhere and never is there any exemption from what God condemns. (6) It is the freedom from the change of opinion that constitutes the fullness of truth. What is intrinsically good or evil cannot be anything else.

CHAPTERS 21–22

(1) All things, we maintain, are firmly defined by the truth of God. The pagans, who do not possess the fullness of truth, since their teacher of truth is not God, form their judgment of

73. For animal-baiting in the case of criminals, see n. 59, above.

74. Slaves and prisoners of war were sometimes sold to serve as gladiators.

75. The reply is directed to the argument immediately above in defense of the amphitheater that the guilty should be punished; see chapters 1 and 2, where pagan arguments contribute to a dialogue among Christians. It is likely that Tertullian would have expected some pagans to read his book though it was specifically addressed to catechumens and Christians. If so, his book would be a contribution to dialogue with pagans. A mixed audience has been suggested also for the *Apology;* cf. *Apology,* n. 8.

good and evil in accordance with their own opinion and inclination, making what is good in one place evil in another, and what is evil in one place good in another. (2) Thus it happens that the man who protects the ears of his maiden daughter from every foul word will take her himself to the theater to hear such words and see the gestures that accompany them, and (3) one who shudders at the sight of the body of a man who died in accordance with nature's law will in the amphitheater look down with tolerant eyes upon bodies mangled and smeared with their own blood. (1) Such are the inconsistencies of people who confuse and confound the nature of good and evil through their fickleness of feeling and instability in judgment.

CHAPTER 23
Omitted

CHAPTER 24

(2) If we have shown that all these things have been instituted for the Devil's sake and furnished from the Devil's stores (for everything that is not God's or that displeases God is the Devil's), then this represents the pomp of the Devil that we renounce in the "seal" of faith.[76] (3) No share, however, ought we to have in what we renounce—whether in deed or word, whether in look or in thought.[77] Let the pagans tell us whether it be permitted for Christians to attend a spectacle. Why, for them this is the principal sign that one has become a Christian,[78] that he renounces the spectacles. (4) A person, therefore, who removes the mark by which one is recognized, openly denies one's faith. What hope is there left for such a one? No one deserts to the camp of the enemy without first throwing away his weapons, renouncing his oath of allegiance[79] to his leader, and without pledging himself to die with the enemy.

76. On the seal of faith and the pomp of the devil, see nn. 26, 27, 28, above.

77. "In look or in thought" follows the text and translation of Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 283.

78. "That one has become a Christian": for the expression see *Apology,* nn. 11, 19, 79, and *Testimony of the Soul,* n. 9.

79. "Oath of allegiance": *sacramentum.* Soldiers swore an oath of allegiance, called *sacramentum,* to their military commander (for the military *sacramentum,* see *The Crown,* n. 47). Hence, this oath becomes a metaphor of the Christian's

CHAPTER 25

(1) Will the person, seated where there is nothing of God, at that moment think of God? One will have peace in the soul, I suppose, as one cheers for the charioteer; will learn purity while gazing with fascination at the mimic actors. (3) While the tragic actor is ranting, our good friend will probably recall the outcries of some prophet! Amid the strains of the effeminate flute-player,[80] he will no doubt meditate on a psalm! (5) What sort of behavior is it to go from the assembly of God to the assembly[81] of the Devil? Those hands which you have lifted up to God, to tire them out afterwards applauding an actor? To cheer a gladiator with the same lips with which you have said "Amen" over the Most Holy? To call out "for ever and ever" to anyone else but to God and Christ?[82]

CHAPTER 26

(1) Why, then, should such people not also be susceptible to demoniac possession? For we have the case of that woman—the Lord is witness—who went to the theater and returned home having a demon. (2) So, when in the course of exorcism the unclean spirit was hard pressed with the accusation that he had dared to seize a woman who believed, he answered boldly, "I was fully justified in doing so, for I found her in my own domain." (3) It is well known, too, that to another woman, during the night following the very day on which she had listened to a tragic actor, a shroud was shown in a dream, and a rebuke called out to her, mentioning the tragic actor by name; nor was that woman still alive after five days.[83]

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baptism; cf. *Apology,* nn. 37, 71, 161, *Testimony of the Soul,* n. 11, and *To the Martyrs,* n. 17.

80. The reading here is uncertain, and the reference may be to the 'effeminate pantomimist'; cf. n. 67, above.

81. "Assembly" here twice renders the Latin *ecclesia,* which in some other contexts has the sense of "church," thus sharpening the contrast in Christian ears between the two assemblies.

82. It was the custom in the early Church to raise the hands in prayer and to say "amen" upon receiving the bread and wine at the Eucharist. There is evidence that winners in the contests were greeted with the cry "forever and forever."

83. Tertullian was quick to appeal to such evidence; see *Apology* 23 and *On Idolatry* 15.7–8.

CHAPTERS 27–28

(1) We ought to hate those gatherings and meetings of pagans, seeing that there the name of God is blasphemed. (3) Do you doubt that at the very moment when you are raging wildly in the assembly of the Devil[84] all the angels look forth from heaven and note down every individual who has uttered blasphemy, who has listened to it, who has lent tongue, who has lent ears to the service of the Devil against God? (4) I grant you that you have there some things that are sweet, pleasant, harmless, and even honorable. It is into spicy and sweet dishes that poison is instilled. So, too, the Devil pours into the deadly draught he prepares the most agreeable and most welcome gifts of God. (5) Everything, then, you find there, whether valorous or honorable or sonorous or melodious or tender, take it for drippings of honey from a poisoned cake.

(1) Let the Devil's own guests stuff themselves with sweets of that sort. Our banquet, our marriage feast, has not yet come.[85] (3) You are too dainty, O Christian, if you desire pleasure also in this world; nay, more, you are a fool altogether if you deem this pleasure. For what other prayer have we but that of the Apostle—"to leave the world and find our place with the Lord"?[86] Our pleasure is where our prayer is.

CHAPTERS 29–30

(1) And finally, if you think that you are to pass this span of life in delights, why are you so ungrateful as not to be satisfied with so many and so exquisite pleasures given you by God, and not to recognize them? For what is more delightful than reconciliation with God? (2) What greater pleasure is there than true liberty, a pure conscience, a contented life, freedom from fear of death? (3) To trample under foot the gods of pagans, to drive out demons, to effect cures, to seek revelations, to live to God[87]—these are the pleasures, these are the spectacles of the

84. "Assembly": *ecclesia;* cf. n. 81, above. I follow the reading of Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 298. The text of *Corpus Christianorum* reads, "when the Devil is raging in his assembly."

85. Cf. Rev. 19:9 and Matt. 22:1–10; Luke 14:16–24.

86. Phil. 1:23.

87. For the expression "live to God," see Rom. 6:10–11. By "revelations" Ter-

Christians, holy, everlasting, and free of charge.[88] (4) If the literary accomplishments of the stage delight you, we have sufficient literature of our own, enough verses and maxims, also enough songs and melodies;[89] and ours are not fables, but truths, not artful devices, but plain realities. (5) Do you want contests in boxing and wrestling? Here they are: impurity overthrown by chastity, faithlessness slain by faith, cruelty crushed by mercy, impudence put in the shade by modesty. Such are the contests among us, and in these we win our crowns.

(1) Moreover, what a spectacle is already at hand—the second coming of the Lord, now exalted, now triumphant! What exultation will that be of the angels, what glory of the saints as they rise again! What a kingdom, the kingdom of the just thereafter! What a city, the new Jerusalem! (2) But there are yet other spectacles to come—that day of the Last Judgment, when the hoary age of the world and all its generations will be consumed in one fire.[90] (3) What a panorama of spectacle on that day!

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tullian intends those that individual Christians receive on behalf of the community, as it realizes in a practical way the saying of Christ that "When the spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth" (John 16:13). Tertullian records examples of such revelations in *On the Soul* 9.4 and *On the Veiling of Virgins* 17.3. For Tertullian the conviction that undiscovered truth could be discerned under the guidance of the Spirit (whom Tertullian will call the "Paraclete," adopting a Johannine expression [cf. John 14:16 and 15:26; 1 John 2:1]), already apparent in this early work, became ever more pressing as he advanced in his literary career, and it became a dominant feature of his later Montanist period; on Tertullian's relation to Montanism, see *Flight in Time of Persecution,* n. 5. On the importance of revelations in the Montanist community, see the article on "Montanism" in the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity.*

88. Though some have seen an allusion here to a supposed charge for admission to the shows, it is perhaps preferable to suppose that Tertullian wishes to emphasize God's gracious gift. Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 311, believes that admission to shows was generally free, but Balsdon, *Life and Leisure,* 333, finds evidence that admission was sometimes charged.

89. On "songs and melodies" see Col. 3:16; also *Apology* 39. *Apology* 2.6 (where Tertullian refers to Pliny's account of Christians who "met before daybreak to sing") indicates that liturgical singing was practiced among Christians a century before Tertullian. In general the "literature" referred to here would seem to be essentially Scripture, hymns based on it, or perhaps paraphrases of it. See Turcan, *Les spectacles,* 314–15, and the article on "music" in the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity.*

90. It is evident that Tertullian adopted the eschatological views of the millenarians: the second coming of Christ entailed the resurrection of the just who

Which sight shall excite my wonder, my laughter—as I see so many and so mighty kings groaning in the depths of darkness? Wise philosophers blushing before their followers as they burn together? Poets, too, trembling before the judgment seat of Christ whom they did not expect to meet? (5) Then will the tragic actors be worth hearing, more vocal in their own catastrophe; then the comic actors will be worth watching, much lither of limb in the fire; then the charioteer will be worth seeing, red all over on his fiery wheel; then the athletes will be worth observing, not in their gymnasiums, but thrown about by fire. (7) Such scenes as these are in a measure already ours by faith in the vision of our spirit. But what are those things which "eye has not seen nor ear heard and which have not entered into the heart of man"?[91] Things of greater delight, I believe, than circus, both kinds of theater,[92] and any stadium.

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would reign with Christ for a thousand years over an earthly kingdom centered in Jerusalem (cf. Rev. 20–21). After a thousand years all would rise to be judged at the Last Judgment, the unjust to be condemned to eternal punishment. There is no direct evidence that Montanists were millenarian, but Montanists are known to have some views very much like those that characterize millenarianism; cf. the article on "chiliasm" in the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity*.

91. 1 Cor. 2:9.

92. I.e., the theater and the amphitheater.

4

TO THE MARTYRS

Introduction

For several reasons this little treatise deserves a place in a collection that attempts to elucidate the Christian response to a pagan world. First, the treatise introduces us, if a little obliquely, to some of the circumstances concomitant with the confession of the Name before the pagans. If we may judge from the account of the martyrdom of Perpetua and her companions, written shortly after this treatise,[1] Christians found themselves in prison not as a punishment for their confession, but either to await trial before the governor, or to await their death after they had stood trial and made their confession. We can see from this treatise, as also from the diary of Perpetua, that prisons in the Roman world were dark and unpleasant. Moreover, food and clothing had to be supplied by friends and relatives. The first chapter of *To the Martyrs* indicates that the Church undertook to supply the physical needs of Christian prisoners; by contrast Tertullian offers his treatise as a contribution to their spiritual needs. Further, the circumstances of the prison could easily give rise to contention among the confessors—strife might arise even from the custom, to which Tertullian alludes here, of martyrs-designate offering the peace of the Church (in effect, for-

1. For the dating of *To the Martyrs* (197), see the general introduction, p. xvii, above. For the martyrdom of Perpetua and her companions, see *Spectacles,* n. 59, and *Apology,* nn. 16 and 13.

giveness) to those who had denied the faith under the pressure of pagan persecution. A half century later the correspondence of Cyprian, bishop of Carthage during the Decian persecution, would add vivid detail to the allusive generalities of Tertullian.

In the second place, the treatise reflects the strong sense that Christianity and paganism constituted opposing worlds. In chapter 2 Tertullian offers comfort to the prisoners on the grounds that they are now free to construct in the prison their own "Christian" world, removed as they are from the inescapable idolatry and degradation of pagan society. Strikingly, it is the contrast between the pagan and Christian world that legitimizes the introduction of "pagan martyrs" in chapter 4: if pagans have suffered thus, what should Christians not be willing to suffer?

Finally, the metaphors of soldier and athlete in chapter 3 reflect the fundamental conception of martyrdom generally held by the early Christians: confession of the Name played a climactic part in the Christian's warfare against the demonic, for the struggle to death was both combat and contest with Satanic power, and the Christian's death, like the death of Christ itself, was a decisive and major victory over the devil. It was above all in martyrdom that the Church confronted the evil powers that fed and controlled the idolatrous and degrading structures of the social and political life of paganism.

The Text

CHAPTER 1

(1) Blessed martyrs elect,[2] along with the nourishment for the body that our Lady Mother the Church from her breasts,[3]

2. The Latin Church adopted the word "martyr" from the Greek *martys* (stem *martyr),* meaning "witness." While the word might be used to refer to anyone who made a public confession of faith, especially in the face of hostile powers, in time its use came to be restricted to refer to those who had confessed and been punished, while the term "confessor" was given to those who had confessed but had not yet been punished. "Elect" here translates *designati,* "those appointed martyrs," which qualifies the confessors' right to the unrestricted use of the word "martyr." The word is carefully studied in Graham Clarke, ed. and trans., *The Letters of Cyprian of Carthage,* vol. 1, Ancient Christian Writers, vol. 43 (New York, N.Y.: Newman Press, 1984); see esp. the notes to *Epp.* 10 and 15.

3. For the image of "lady," see 2 John 1 and 5. The significance of the im-

as well as individual brethren from their private resources, furnishes you in prison,[4] accept also from me some offering that will contribute to the sustenance of the spirit. For it is not good that the flesh be feasted while the spirit goes hungry.[5] (2) Not that I am specially entitled to exhort you. Yet, even the most accomplished gladiators are spurred on not only by their trainers and managers but also from afar by people inexperienced in this art.

(3) In the first place, then, O blessed, "do not grieve the Holy Spirit"[6] who has entered prison with you. See to it that it remain with you there and so lead you out of that place to the Lord.[7] (4) Indeed, the prison is the Devil's house, too, where he keeps his household. But you have come to the prison for the very purpose of trampling upon him right in his own house.[8] For you have engaged him in battle already outside the prison and trampled him underfoot.[9] (5) Let him, therefore, not say: "Now that they are in my domain, I will tempt them with base hatreds, with defections or dissensions among themselves." Do not allow him the good fortune in his own kingdom of setting you against one another, but let him find you fortified by the arms of peace among yourselves, because peace among yourselves means war with him. (6) Some, not able to find this peace in the Church, are accustomed to seek it from the martyrs in prison. For this reason, too, then, you ought to possess, cherish and preserve it among yourselves that you may perhaps be able to bestow it upon others also.[10]

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age of "mother," applied to the Church, is assessed in David Rankin, *Tertullian and the Church* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995), 78–83 and 112.

4. As the state provided no support for those in prison, prisoners had to receive their sustenance from family or friends. Tertullian acknowledges here that the Christian community (Mother Church) and individuals supplied the needs of the martyrs-elect.

5. Cf. Mark 14:38.

6. Eph. 4:30.

7. In early Christian literature death is often referred to as a going to the Lord.

8. For the image of the martyr trampling the devil underfoot, see "The Martyrdom of Saints Perpetua and Felicitas," in Musurillo, *Acts,* 111.

9. I.e., in making their confession at their trial.

10. Martyrs were recognized as having the power to grant the peace of the Church to those who had lapsed, or to recommend to the bishop that it be

CHAPTER 2

(1) Nor let your separation from the world trouble you. For, if we reflect that it is the very world that is more truly a prison, we shall realize that you have left a prison rather than entered one. (2) The world holds the greater darkness, blinding people's hearts. The world puts on the heavier chains, fettering the very soul of a person. The world breathes forth the fouler impurities—human lusts. (4) Wherefore, O blessed, consider yourselves as having been transferred from prison to what we may call a place of safety. Darkness is there, but you are light;[11] fetters are there, but you are free before God.[12] It breathes forth a foul smell, but you are an odor of sweetness.[13] (5) There sadness may come upon the one who sighs for the pleasures of the world. The Christian, however, has renounced the world.

(6) Let us compare the life in the world with that in prison to see if the spirit does not gain more in prison than the flesh

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granted; it was a power that was sometimes exercised in advance of the martyr's anticipated death. The letters of Cyprian document the practice in the mid-third century; see *Epp.* 16–17. Indeed, in the "Martyrdom of Saints Perpetua and Felicitas," Perpetua learns from a dream that because of her prayer in prison her brother, who had died as a boy and a pagan, was transferred from a "place of darkness" to Paradise (Musurillo, *Acts,* 115–17); the account has, however, found numerous interpretations, for which see Cecil M. Robeck, Jr., *Prophecy in Carthage: Perpetua, Tertullian, and Cyprian* (Cleveland, Ohio: The Pilgrim Press, 1992), 42–56. In general, the martyr was seen as an imitator of Christ: in confession (and death) the martyr crushed the power of evil and gained thereby an authority analogous to that of Christ. On the theology of martyrdom, see Frend, *Martyrdom and Persecution,* 58–69.

11. Cf. Eph. 5:8; also Matt. 5:14 and 1 Thess. 5:5. In her diary Perpetua describes her reaction to the terrible darkness of the Carthaginian prison: "After a few days we were lodged in the prison, and I was terrified, as I had never before been in such a dark hole" (Musurillo, *Acts,* 109).

12. A topos familiar from classical literature (cf. Cicero, *On Moral Ends* [*De finibus*] 3.22.75), and applied elsewhere to Christian confessors in prison; cf. Cyprian, *Ep.* 39.2.

13. The phrase reflects the language of sacrifice; cf. Ezek. 20:41; Eph. 5:2. Tertullian's portrait of the prison corresponds with other portraits of prisons in the Roman world; cf. Musurillo, *Acts,* 109, and the earlier biblical account of Paul and Silas in prison (Acts 16: 23–34). Tertullian does not note the distinction evident in these sources between the inner and outer prison; see also Clarke, *Letters of Cyprian,* nn. 15 and 16 to *Ep.* 22.

loses there. (7) In fact, owing to the solicitude of the Church and the charity[14] of the brethren, the flesh does not miss there what it ought to have, while, in addition, the spirit obtains what is always beneficial to the faith: you do not look at strange gods; you do not participate in heathen holidays; you are not plagued by the foul fumes of the sacrificial banquets; you are free from inducements to sin, from temptations, from unholy reminiscences. (8) The prison now offers to the Christian what the desert once gave to the Prophets.[15] Our Lord himself quite often spent time in solitude to pray there more freely,[16] to be there away from the world. Let us drop the name "prison" and call it a place of seclusion. (9) Though the body is confined, though the flesh is detained, there is nothing that is not open to the spirit. In spirit wander about, in spirit take a walk, setting before yourselves not shady promenades and long porticoes but that path which leads to God.

CHAPTER 3

(1) Granted now, O blessed, that even to Christians the prison is unpleasant—yet we were called to service in the army of the living God in the very moment when we gave response to the words of the sacramental oath.[17] (2) Even in time of peace soldiers are toughened to warfare by toils and hardships: by marching in arms, by practicing swift maneuvers in the field. In like manner, O blessed, consider whatever is hard in your present situation as an exercise of your powers of mind and body. You are about to enter a noble contest[18] in which the living God

14. "charity": *agapen* (objective form of *agape);* here the word is transliterated from the Greek, but see *Apology,* n. 143.

15. Cf., e.g., 1 Kings 19:4–18 for the story of the prophet Elijah, who heard the voice of God in the desert.

16. Cf. Mark 1:35.

17. "Sacramental oath": *sacramentum verbi.* For the wide use of the word "*sacramentum"* in these selections, see *Spectacles,* n. 79. Here, in an obvious allusion to the baptismal covenant, the words evoke the image of the military oath of allegiance to the commander, as in *Spectacles* 24.

18. An early example of the detailed comparison between the athlete and the Christian, a comparison often repeated in early Christian literature. In terms of the comparison given here, the "superintendent" *(agonothetes)* presided over the "contest" *(agon),* the "trainer" *(xystarches)* was the director of the building where athletes exercised in winter, and the "crown" signified the win-

acts the part of superintendent and the Holy Spirit is your trainer, a contest whose crown is eternity, whose prize is angelic nature, citizenship in heaven, and glory for ever and ever. (4) And so your Master, Jesus Christ, who has anointed you with his Spirit and has brought you to this training ground, has resolved, before the day of the contest, to take you from a softer way of life to a harsher treatment that your strength may be increased. For athletes, too, are set apart for more rigid training that they may apply themselves to the building up of their physical strength. (5) And they do this, says the Apostle, to win a perishable crown. We are about to win an eternal one.[19]

CHAPTER 4

(1) We know from our Lord's teaching that, while the spirit is willing, the flesh is weak.[20] Let us, however, not derive delusive gratification from the Lord's acknowledgment of the weakness of the flesh. For it was on purpose that he first declared the spirit willing: he wanted to show that the flesh should be submissive to the spirit, the weaker to the stronger. (2) Let the spirit converse with the flesh on their common salvation.[21] The flesh will perhaps fear the heavy sword and the lofty cross and the wild beasts and the most terrible punishment of all—death by fire. (3) But let the spirit present to both itself and the flesh the other side of the picture: granted, these sufferings are grievous, yet many have borne them patiently, have even sought them for the sake of fame and glory; and this is true not only of men but also of women. (4) Lucretia stabbed herself in the

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ner, who received the "prize" *(brabium)*. The "master" *(epistates)* supervised the athlete's training, and anointed his body with oil before taking him to wrestle (or to the wrestling ground, the *scamna)* in preparation for the contest. The comparison here also makes allusion to the New Testament: for contest and crown, prize and athlete's training regimen, see 1 Cor. 9:24–27; 1 Tim. 6:12; 2 Tim. 2:5; 2 Tim. 4:7–8. See also Mark 12:25 (angelic nature), Phil. 3:20 (citizenship in heaven); 1 Pet. 1:4 (eternal glory). The image appears again in *Flight in Time of Persecution* 1.

19. Cf. 1 Cor. 9:25.

20. Cf. Matt. 26:41; Mark 14:38.

21. See the treatise *On the Resurrection of the Dead* chapters 6–10, 15, 17, 34, 56, where Tertullian elaborates the view that the flesh must be saved along with the spirit.

presence of her kinsfolk to gain glory for her chastity.[22] Empedocles leaped down into the fires of Mt. Etna; and Peregrinus not long ago threw himself upon a funeral pile.[23] The wife of Hasdrubal, too, with Carthage in flames, cast herself along with her children into the fire that was destroying her native city.[24]

(7) You may object: "But the fear of death is not so great as the fear of torture." Did the Athenian courtesan yield on that account to the executioner? For, being privy to a conspiracy, she was subjected to torture by the tyrant. But she did not betray her fellow conspirators, and at last bit off her own tongue and spat it into the tyrant's face to let him know that torments, however prolonged, could achieve nothing against her.[25] (9) Therefore, if earthly glory accruing from strength of body and soul is valued so highly that one despises sword and fire, then I may say the sufferings you endure are but trifling in comparison with the heavenly glory and divine reward.

CHAPTER 5
Omitted

CHAPTER 6

(1) Let us, however, turn to a simple contemplation of the ordinary lot of human beings. How often have people been

22. Lucretia, the Roman model of womanly conduct, killed herself after she had been violated by Sextus Tarquinius, the son of the tyrannical king Lucius Tarquinius Superbus. Cf. Livy, *History of Rome* 1.58–59.

23. The philosopher Empedocles of Acragas in Sicily (ca. 490–30 B.C.) killed himself by leaping into the flames of Mt. Aetna to demonstrate his divinity; cf. Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers* 8.2.67–69. The story is legendary. On the other hand, the sophist Lucian (second century A.D.) claims to have witnessed the death of Peregrinus, who had himself burned (A.D. 165) on a funeral pyre to illustrate his contempt of death; see Lucian, *The Passing of Peregrinus.*

24. When Carthage was finally taken by the Roman general Scipio (146 B.C.) the city was set on fire; Hasdrubal, the Carthaginian commander, begged for mercy from Scipio, but his wife, scorning her husband, killed her two sons and from the top of the burning temple of Eshmoun threw her sons, along with herself, into the flames. The story is told by Appian in his *Roman History* 8.19.130–31.

25. The story is briefly told in Pliny, *Natural History* 7.23.87, and in Pausanias, *Description of Greece* 1.23.1–2. Leaena refused to name her co-conspirators, Harmodicus and Aristogiton, who plotted (514 B.C.) to kill the Athenian tyrant Hippias and his brother Hipparchus.

burned to death in conflagrations! How often have wild beasts devoured people either in the forests or in the heart of cities after escaping from their cages! How many have been slain by the sword of robbers! (2) Furthermore, many a person is able to suffer in the cause of a mere human being what he hesitates to suffer in the cause of God. To this fact, indeed, our present days may bear witness. How many prominent persons have met with death in the cause of a man! Death came to them either from him, if they had opposed him, or from his enemies, if they had sided with him.[26]

26. Perhaps a reference to the many who died fighting for Clodius Albinus, the rival of Septimius Severus, in the decisive battle between the two near Lyons in A.D. 197, as well as to the massacre of Albinus' partisans in Rome and throughout the Empire. An account is given in Cassius Dio, *Roman History* 76.6, and Herodian, *History* 3.8. See *Apology*, n. 123. The treatise ends abruptly with these words.

5

THE CROWN

Introduction

The preceding treatises are all among the earliest of Tertullian's work, possibly written shortly after his conversion. *The Crown* belongs decisively to Tertullian's "Montanist" phase, and it invites, therefore, a brief comparison with the earlier writings. On the one hand, certain features of the treatise show a firm line of continuity with Tertullian's "Catholic" past. As in the case of *Spectacles*, the heart of Tertullian's argument in *The Crown* is based on the incompatibility between the baptismal vow and any form of action that can be linked with idolatry. Recalling here the tenor of his argument there, he contends that crowns, both in their origin and in the use to which pagans generally put them, are idolatrous. Here, as there, he distinguishes the legitimate use of things whose origin is ascribed to idols from their idolatrous use. Here, as there, he calls the Christian away from participation in an idolatrous world in order to realize a heavenly citizenship. Here, as in the earlier *To the Martyrs*, pagan examples serve to edify and challenge Christian behaviour.

But certain aspects of the argument mark the distance Tertullian traveled as he moved toward Montanism. Though the appeal to the Spirit played a very significant role in *Spectacles*, in *The Crown* Tertullian boldly claims that the Spirit reliably dis-

closes new truth to all believers. He pushes his conviction, expressed in *Apology* 21, that the Spirit of Christ is rational—for Christ is the *logos*, "reason"—to the point where he can argue not only that Word and Spirit created a rational world, but also that the believer who is led by the Spirit can act only rationally, and that because the believer has the Spirit, the believer can discern what in fact is rational in nature. Tertullian appealed in his early treatises to the argument from nature primarily as a witness to the pagans, who, he admitted, generally do not see clearly the truth in nature because of the perversion caused by the demonic. Removed from the authority of the demonic through baptism, the Spirit-filled Christian can trust his Spirit-guided exploration of nature. Thus in *The Crown* the argument from nature assumes an importance beyond what it found in the early treatises. It is, ultimately, the foundation on which the appeal to custom in this treatise is built: custom is authoritative precisely to the degree that it conforms to nature. The "dictates" of nature now become virtually divine commands, since nature represents the divine laws.

In both *Spectacles* and *The Crown* the central question is, "Where do the Scriptures forbid?" In *Spectacles* Tertullian answered the question, first, by demanding an appropriate exegetical methodology, then, later, by drawing explicitly upon scriptural injunctions against the immoralities evident in the shows. Certainly scriptural references are not absent in *The Crown*, but the argument from nature interpreted under the guidance of the Spirit has partially supplanted the argument from Scripture, becoming, as we have seen, a divine command, and it is shown to be such by appeal to Paul's own use of the argument in 1 Corinthians 11.

It is perhaps ironic that as Tertullian increasingly appealed to the authority of Spirit-guided reason, his own reasoning in his treatises became increasingly sophistic, sometimes even bizarre. The occasional extravagance of his reasoning has been somewhat attenuated in this selection by our abbreviation, but traces remain: one is surprised, for example, by the leap from the proposition that "whatever is not forbidden in Scripture is permitted" to Tertullian's own unexplained affirmation that "whatever is not permitted is forbidden."

It seems likely that the event that gave rise to the treatise occurred in 211, when, after the death of the emperor Septimius Severus, his two sons, Caracalla and Geta, co-rulers since 208, celebrated their accession to the rank of co-Augusti. On such occasions it was characteristic of emperors to make a money-gift (a "donative") to the soldiers. It is less certain where the Christian soldier made his confession. Although a legion of soldiers was, in fact, stationed in Lambese (in modern Algeria), modern scholars prefer to think that the incident occurred in Carthage, either among a cohort of soldiers from the Lambèse legion stationed in Carthage, or among a group of soldiers detailed for the proconsul in Carthage.[1] The treatise was written a "short time" after the event.

Like the earlier treatises, this one, too, brings vividly before us the anxieties of Christians living in a pagan context. Once more we see how that context engendered conflict among Christians, in this case over questions arising from the possibility of martyrdom. There were those who felt that every reasonable attempt should be made to divert the attention of pagans away from Christians. The soldier in question appeared to be inviting martyrdom—an attitude the Church quickly came to condemn. On another issue Tertullian's argument reveals vigorous debate and compromise in the early Church: Tertullian believes (cf. chapter 11) that Christians cannot join the army, but it is evident from *The Crown* that there were Christians in the army in the early third century, and even Tertullian himself seems to recognize that, if a Christian could not legitimately join the army, a soldier converted in the army might remain there, though with the greatest difficulty unless he compromised Christian principles.[2]

1. See Jacques Fontaine, ed., *Tertullien: Sur la couronne*, Érasme: Collection de textes latins commentés (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1966), 42. Regarding the date Barnes, *Tertullian,* 37–38 and 55, prefers 308, but acknowledges the possibility of 311. The suggestion that the episode took place in the praetorian camp in Rome seems unlikely, but see Yann LeBohec, "Tertullien, *De Corona,* I: Carthage ou Lambèse?" *Revue des études augustiniennes* 38 (1992): 6–18.

2. It is thought that Septimius Severus' use of the army for civilian police duties, requiring tasks that fell short of killing in battle, facilitated a Christian presence in the army.

We have seen in other treatises vivid vignettes of pagan life—we may recall the characterization of pagan festivals in the *Apology*, or of pagans in the circus in *Spectacles*. This treatise, too, gives us a brief insight into some of the pervasively idolatrous customs of paganism in many facets of life: in civic duties, at weddings, in elementary schools, at the manumission of slaves. In the treatise *On Idolatry* Tertullian develops the portrait in much more detail. He offers enough here to illustrate the truth of the Pauline dictum that if one were to escape the idolatry of this age, one would "have to go out of the world."[3]

The Text

CHAPTER 1

(1) A short time ago a largess, granted by our most excellent emperors, was distributed in the camp.[4] As the roll was called, the soldiers came forward crowned with laurel. One of them was nobly conspicuous when his name was called: he was the only one whose head was bare as he held the useless crown in his hand; by this characteristic mode of action alone he was at once known to everyone as a Christian. (2) Thereupon all began to single him out: those in the rear ranks mocked him, those in the front uttered threats. Since the murmur did not abate, his name and particular offense were reported to the tribune—for the soldier had already stepped out of his line.[5] The tribune at once asked him: "Why are you not wearing the

3. 1 Cor. 5:10.

4. For the occasion see the introduction to this treatise, above. For the "largess" (i.e., the donative) see also *Apology*, n. 122.

5. I follow Fontaine, *Sur la couronne* 44—the reading fits well the rapidity of the action narrated. Fabbio Ruggiero, ed., *Tertulliano, De Corona: Introduzione, testo, traduzione e note* (Milan: Arnaldo Mondadori, 1992), 63 n. 11, imagines that the soldier, who had no intention of receiving the donative, had stepped out of his customary position as a protest against the ceremony; when his name was called there was a murmur among the soldiers. The tribune noticed the murmur and had the soldier brought before him for questioning. During the empire a legion of the army was generally commanded by a legate aided by several junior officers called tribunes, who were usually from more or less distinguished families and whose responsibilities were chiefly administrative. Here the tribune was apparently presiding at the donative in place of the legate.

crown like everyone else?" The soldier replied: "Because I am a Christian."[6] The soldiers clamored for the punishment of the offender and the case was referred to a higher tribunal; the offender was led to the prefects.[7] (3) Glad to be rid of the burden, he let fall his heavy military cloak, he took off the uncomfortable boots he had worn as a scout,[8] and he returned the sword; the laurel crown in his hand already bestowed upon him the glory of martyrdom.[9] Now, hoping to be crowned more worthily with the white laurel crown of martyrdom, he awaited in prison the reward of Christ. (4) It was then that the gossips started: "Why does he have to make so much trouble for the rest of us Christians over the trifling matter of dress? Why must he be so inconsiderate and rash and act as if he were anxious to die? Is he the only brave man, the only Christian among all his fellow soldiers?"

Such people grumble because our soldier was endangering the long and comfortable peace they had been enjoying.[10] (6) Inasmuch as they produce the following objection: "But where in the Gospel are we forbidden to wear a crown?"—I will, at this time, turn my attention to this point, since it is the essence of the present contention. I will do this in order to enlighten those inquirers who are really concerned about their ignorance, as well as to refute those who try to defend such sinful conduct. By the latter I mean especially those laurel-crowned Christians who console themselves with saying: "It is merely a question of debate." As if conduct that may be made the subject of an investigation could be regarded as either no trespass at

6. An affirmation typical of Christian confessors; see *Apology* 2 and n. 16.

7. Only the Praetorian camp in Rome is known to have had two prefects. Tertullian may be using the term improperly; see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 132 n. 4. Clearly, the confessor's case was sent to a higher military court.

8. Under the emperors, "scouts" served as aids to the commanding general, and an elite corps of "scouts" acted as his bodyguard.

9. The reading of Fontaine, *Sur la couronne,* 47, which suggests that in the soldier's action the laurel wreath of the pagan rite has become the glorious sign of the approaching victory of the martyr.

10. After the persecution of 202–203, during which the martyrs Perpetua and Felicitas perished, Christians in North Africa were generally unmolested until Scapula became governor (212).

all, or at least a doubtful one! But I will show them that it is a real offense and not merely a doubtful one.

CHAPTER 2

(4) To be sure, it is very easy to ask: "Where in Scripture are we forbidden to wear a crown?" But, can you show me a text that says we should be crowned? If people try to say that we may be crowned because the Scriptures do not forbid it, then they leave themselves open to the retort that we may not be crowned because Scripture does not prescribe it. But "Whatever is not forbidden is, without question, allowed." Rather do I say: "Whatever is not specifically permitted is forbidden."

CHAPTER 3

(1) Now, how long shall we saw away along the same line on this question, when we have a long-standing practice, which by anticipation has all but settled the question? Even though no scriptural passage has prescribed it, it is strengthened by custom which certainly arose from tradition. How can anything become normal practice if it has not first been handed down to us? But, you tell me: "You must always have a written source if you are going to plead the force of tradition."

(2) Let us look into the matter, then, whether or not a tradition without a written source should be accepted. The answer will certainly be "No" if we cannot adduce examples of other observances that, without written source in Scripture,[11] rest solely on the basis of tradition. To begin, for instance, with baptism: when we are about to enter the water, and, as a matter of fact, even a short while before, we declare in the assembly,[12] when the president imposes his hand,[13] that we renounce the Devil, his

11. "Without written source in Scripture": *sine scripturae instrumento.* The phrase helps us to understand Tertullian's use elsewhere of *instrumentum* to connote the evidence capable of establishing a case. For other occasions where the word is used in reference to the Scriptures, see *Apology* 18, *instrumentum litteraturae*, translated "assistance of books" (p. 37); *Apology* 19, *instrumentis*, translated "records" (p. 39); see n. 29, below.

12. "Assembly": *ecclesia;* cf. *Spectacles*, n. 81.

13. "President": *antistes.* In his treatise *On Baptism* 17.1 Tertullian gives the "supreme right" of baptism to the "high priest" *(summus sacerdos),* who is the bishop *(episcopus),* but he acknowledges that presbyters, deacons, and even lay-

pomps, and his angels.[14] (3) After that, we are immersed in the water three times. Then, having stepped forth from the font, we are given a taste of a mixture of milk and honey, and from that day, for a whole week, we forego our daily bath. We also receive the sacrament[15] of the Eucharist at our early morning meetings, and then from the hand of none but those who preside. Further, we make offerings for the dead on their anniversary to celebrate their birthday of eternal life.[16] (4) We consider fasting, or kneeling during service, on Sundays to be unlawful.[17] Lastly, we make the sign of the cross on our foreheads at every turn.

CHAPTER 4

(1) Now, if you demand a precise scriptural precept for these and other practices of Church discipline, you will find none.

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persons can administer baptism. The treatise also notes the candidate's triple response during triple immersion (see *Spectacles*, n. 27), the anointing with oil, and the imposition of hands after the anointing (see *On Baptism* 4, 6, 7, 8). In a wide-ranging description of the baptismal customs that prevailed in the Roman Church of the early third century, Hippolytus, *Apostolic Tradition* 20–23, confirms some of the customs listed here as Tertullian knew them in the Carthaginian Church; see Gregory Dix, ed., *The Treatise on the Apostolic Tradition of St. Hippolytus of Rome* (reissued with corrections, preface, and bibliography by Henry Chadwick, London: Alban Press, 1992), 30–40. Hippolytus' account is summarized in Ernest Evans, *Tertullian's Homily on Baptism* (London: SPCK, 1964), xix–xxii.

14. On the phrase, see *Spectacles,* n. 28. This passage seems to imply a double renunciation of Satan—once in the Church (i.e., the assembly), and once in the baptistery; see Fontaine, *Sur la couronne*, 65, and Ruggiero, *De Corona,* 74 n. 8.

15. "Sacrament" *sacramentum.*

16. See n. 13, above. Baptism was generally, but not necessarily, by immersion; the mixture of milk and honey recalled the good land of the chosen people after their crossing the Jordan (cf. Ex. 3:8,17; Num. 13:27; Josh. 5:6). Pliny attests the early morning meetings of the Christians (see *Apology* 2; though *Apology* 39 indicates that the agape was an evening meal). For offerings for the dead, see Cyprian, *Ep.* 39.3; see also Augustine, *Confessions* 6.2, who speaks of cakes, bread, and wine brought to chapels built in honor of saints.

17. The practice of standing at prayer during the liturgy on Sundays, to which Tertullian witnesses here, was canonically prescribed by the Council of Nicaea (325); see Leo Donald Davis, S.J., *The First Seven Ecumenical Councils (325–787): Their History and Theology*, Theology and Life Series, vol. 21 (Wilmington, Del.: Michael Glazier, 1987; distributed by the Liturgical Press, Collegeville, Minn.), 67.

Tradition, you will be told, has created them, custom has strengthened them, and faith has encouraged their observance. And you will yourself understand (or someone who has experienced it will tell you) that reason will support tradition, custom, and faith. In the meantime, you will believe that there is some reason to which obedience is owed.

(2) I will add still one example from the Old Testament, since it is fitting to draw lessons from there, too. It is so customary among the Jews that their women are veiled that we can recognize them by this sign. What law prescribed that? (Here, I'm not considering St. Paul.)[18] If Rebecca lowered her veil when she recognized her betrothed in the distance,[19] this one modest action of an individual could not constitute a general law. In this case, or in any other one, I demand to be shown a law prescribing dress. (4) If I find nowhere such a law, it follows that it is tradition that has raised this fashion into a custom, which later was to find in the Apostle's command a justification from a reasonable interpretation.[20] Therefore, it will be clear that a non-written tradition can be defended, if it is confirmed by custom.

(5) Besides, since reason is, in fact, the basis of law, then whatever is based on reason will automatically become law, whosoever its author may be. Do you not believe that every one of the faithful is permitted to originate and establish a law, as long as it is pleasing to God, promotes discipline, and is helpful to salvation, for (6) the Apostle says: "If you are ignorant on any point, this will God reveal to you."[21] He himself was accustomed to give counsel, when he had no precept of the Lord, and to establish some rules on his own authority, since he was in possession of the Spirit of God, the guide to all truth.[22] Thus, a counsel and rule of his became equivalent to a divine precept through the support given by divine reason. (7) Ask, then, this divine reason, considering the authority of the custom itself, which must be revered, even if there should be no one to ex-

18. Cf. 1 Cor. 11:5.
19. Cf. Gen. 24:64–65.
20. I.e., on the basis of its reasonableness; cf. 1 Cor. 11:1–16.
21. See Phil. 3:15.
22. Cf., respectively, 1 Cor. 7:25; 1 Cor. 7:40; John 16:13.

plicate its reason—so, that, if God grant the reason, too, you may then learn, not whether you should observe a custom, but why.

CHAPTER 5

(1) The rational basis of Christian customs is strengthened when it is supported by nature, which is the prime rule by which all things are measured. Now, nature is the first to bring an exception against crown and head being adapted for each other. It seems to me that the Lord of nature, our God, so created the human being that it can enjoy the fruits of nature, by giving it specific bodily instruments—ears, eyes, mouth, nostrils, and hands.[23]

(2) Now what in flowers gives you enjoyment? For, it is the flowers of the field that form the peculiar, or at least the chief,[24] material of crowns. You answer rightly: "Either their fragrance, or their color, or both together." Now what other senses, save that of sight and smell, are supposed to smell and see? And what sense organs are supposed to accomplish that, if not the eyes and the nose? (4) But what do you have in your head to relish a flower, to feel a crown, except its band? It is just as much against nature to long for a flower with your head as to crave food with your ear or sound with your nose. But anything that is against nature deserves to be branded as monstrous among all people; we, surely, should also consider it as a sin of sacrilege against God, the master and author of nature.

CHAPTER 6

(1) If you demand a divine law, you have that common one prevailing all over the world, written on the tablets of nature, to which, also, the Apostle is accustomed to appeal. Thus he says concerning the veiling of women: "Does not nature teach you this?"[25] Again, in his letter to the Romans, he hints at the existence of natural law and a nature founded on law.[26] We come to

23. This argument was already sketched out in *Spectacles;* see *Spectacles* 2 and n. 17.

24. "Chief" because there were crowns made of gems and precious metals, too; cf. chapter 13, below.

25. See 1 Cor. 11:14.

26. Cf. Rom. 2:14.

the knowledge of God first by the teachings of nature. For instance, we call him "God of gods," we assume that he is benevolent, and we invoke him as judge.[27] Perhaps you have some doubt as to whether we should allow nature to be our guide in the enjoyment of God's creatures? To be sure, there is a danger that we should be led astray in the direction in which God's rival has corrupted, along with the human being itself, the whole of creation, which had been made over to mankind for certain services. Take, for instance, the pleasures derived from the spectacles: all the components that make up the spectacles come from God, but all have been changed by the Devil. But on this subject, I have written fully in Greek also, for the benefit of our lovers of the shows.[28]

CHAPTER 7

(2) But I see myself compelled to turn from the teaching of nature, which we share with mankind in general, to the specifically Christian teachings that alone must now be defended in relation to all the other kinds of crowns that seem to be intended for other uses, since they are made of different materials. I realize that I must deal with this matter with the greatest care and in detail, from its beginnings, through the successive stages of its growth, down to its present condition. (3) For this purpose I shall have to draw on pagan literature; profane things should be established from their own documents.[29]

Hesiod tells us that Pandora was the first woman, and the

27. Cf. *Testimony of the Soul* 2. On natural and divine revelation as a pervasive theme in Tertullian's work, see Robert D. Sider, "Literary Artifice and the Figure of Paul in Tertullian," in William S. Babcock, ed., *Paul and the Legacies of Paul* (Dallas, Tex.: Southern Methodist University Press, 1990), 116–17.

28. With the argument here, compare that in *Spectacles* 2. Tertullian was fluent in both Greek and Latin. None of the treatises he wrote in Greek has survived. The word "also" might suggest that the Greek treatise on *Spectacles* followed the Latin. The Carthaginian Church at this time must have been predominantly Latin-speaking, but for the evidence of a significant Greek-speaking element, see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 68–69.

29. "Documents" renders the Latin *instrumentis;* cf. n. 11, above. "Pagan" and "profane" both render the same Latin adjective, *saecularis,* meaning "worldly," "the things of the world," that is, the present fallen world—hence, "worldly literature," "worldly things," as opposed to the divine Scriptures and the holy life of the people of God; see *Spectacles,* n. 68.

first who ever wore a crown.[30] Moses tells us that Eve was the first woman and that she girt her loins with leaves rather than her temples with flowers.[31] Pandora, then, never existed. So we have to blush for the fictitious account of the origin of the crown. (4) We know for certain that there were other inventors or propagators of the custom.[32] Pherecydes relates that Saturn was the first to be crowned. Diodorus tells us that Jupiter was thus honored by the rest of the gods after his victory over the Titans. Callimachus tells us that Apollo put on a crown of laurel as a suppliant, after he had killed the serpent at Delphi. In some passages Bacchus is considered as the originator of the crown—that is, of the laurel crown, which he wore on the occasion of his triumphal return from India. If you want further information, look up Claudius Saturninus, (7) who has a book entitled *On Crowns,* which treats so completely of their origins, causes, varieties and ceremonies pertaining to them that you will see that there is not one beautiful flower, not one luxuriant leaf, no sod or vine-shoot that has not been consecrated to the head of someone or other.[33] All this makes it sufficiently clear to us how repugnant this custom of wearing a crown on the

30. For the creation of Pandora, the first woman, see Hesiod, *Works and Days* 59–105. She is known for having opened the box that contained all evils.

31. Cf. Gen. 1:26–27; 2:18–23; 3:7, 20.

32. I.e., the accounts that are about to follow, though from secular sources, nevertheless give certain knowledge and are therefore reliable, in contrast to the fictitious and therefore unreliable story about Pandora and the crown. This reading of the text, different from that of Arbesmann, but accepted by Fontaine, *Sur la couronne,* 95, finds strong support in the manuscript tradition.

33. It is probable that Tertullian found the information in this paragraph in the book *On Crowns* by Claudius Saturninus, who may have been the jurist of the second century A.D. mentioned in Justinian, *Digest* 48.19.16 (see the article "Claudius," no. 333 in *Paulys Realencyclopdie der Classischen Altertumswissenschaft*, vol. 3, pt. 2 [Stuttgart: J. B. Metzler, 1899], 2866). The references are far-ranging: Pherecydes (sixth century B.C.) was reputed to be the first writer of Greek prose—he wrote about the birth of the gods and the creation of the world; Diodorus, a Sicilian (first century B.C.) wrote a "Library of History"—a universal history from mythological times to 60 B.C.; Callimachus (third century B.C.), a Greek poet and scholar, was a prolific writer—among his works were four books of *Aetia* (poems on the origins of myths and cults). As for the myths, the Titans were the children of the first gods, Gaia and Uranus (earth and sky), whom they overthrew, and were, in turn, overthrown by their children under the leadership of Zeus (Jupiter), and hurled into the abyss. Apollo, seeking a

head should be to Christians. It was first invented and afterwards dedicated to the honor of those the world[34] calls "gods." (8) Now, if the Devil effects the false appearance of divinity—in this matter, too, a liar from the beginning[35]—without doubt he himself had also foreseen those in whom the false appearance of divinity would be effected[36] and whom idolatry honored. What opinion, then, should a people dedicated to the true God have of a thing introduced by the minions of Satan and from the beginning attached to their service and which even then was begun as worship of idols? Not, of course, that the idols really were anything,[37] but because whatever people offer to idols pertains to demons.

CHAPTERS 8–9

(1) Now I already hear the following objection. There are a great many other things invented by those whom the world considers to be gods. Yet we find these very things in our own present usages, in those of the early faithful, in the service of God,[38] and in the life of Christ himself, who certainly performed his work as man by no other than the normal agencies of human life.

Let us assume that to be so. (2) Let Mercury be the first who taught the use of letters; I admit they are necessary for both commercial intercourse and our relations to God. If Minerva is claimed to have built the first ship, then I recall that the apostles traveled by sea.[39] (3) If you claim that some one of the gods

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place to establish his oracle, killed the serpent Python at Delphi, where he established his priestess Pythia, but he had to do penance for killing the serpent, the offspring of a goddess. Bacchus is identified with Dionysus, whose exploits took him, according to legend, as far as India. Pliny, *Natural History* 16.4.9, concurs that Bacchus was the first to set a crown on his own head, but it was a crown of ivy, not laurel. Pliny, like Claudius Saturninus, shows a wide-ranging interest in crowns (see his *Natural History* 16.3–4).

34. "The world": *saeculum;* cf. n. 29, above.

35. Cf. John 8:44.

36. I.e., the human beings who had been made gods.

37. Cf. 1 Cor. 10:19.

38. "In the service of God": *in Dei rebus* (literally, "in the things of God"), apparently referring to objects and actions pertaining to the cult and enumerated in Chapter 9; see Ruggiero, *De Corona,* 27.

39. For Mercury as the inventor of letters, see Cicero, *On the Nature of the*

of the world[40] was the inventor of every single piece of furniture or of our ordinary utensils, I will have to admit that Christ reclined on a dining couch, presented a basin to wash the feet of his disciples, poured water into it from a jug, and girded himself with a linen cloth—a garment sacred to Osiris.[41] (4) I always give the same answer to this type of question, admitting, indeed, that we use along with others these articles, but stressing the distinction between their rational and irrational use, because the promiscuous employment of them conceals in a deceptive way the corruption of the creature.[42]

(5) We assert, then, that those things only that meet the necessities of human life by providing plain service, real assistance, and honorable comfort are fit for our own and our ancestors' use, as well as for the service of God and for Christ himself. To that extent they are granted to us by the inspiration of God, who, before anyone else, provided for, and taught and ministered to the enjoyment of the human being, his creature. On the other hand, things, I assert, that are out of this class are not fit for our use—and I mean especially those things that cannot be found either in the service of God or in the life of Christ. Now (1) no crown ever rested upon the head of a patriarch or prophet, Levite, priest, or ruler;[43] nor, in the new dispensation, do we read of an apostle, a preacher of the gospel, or bishop who wore a crown. Not even the temple of God, nor the ark of the covenant, nor the tabernacle of testimony, nor the altar of sacrifice, nor the candlestick was ever adorned with a crown.[44] If, perhaps, you object that Christ Himself was crowned, I will have a very simple answer for you: "By all means, you may wear *that* kind of crown."

Gods 3.22.56. Minerva (= Athena) was patroness of arts and manual skills. The role Tertullian assigns her here as inventor of ships may be reflected in Homer, *Iliad* 15.411–12.

40. "Of the world": *saeculi*—a telling description of the pagan gods; cf. n. 34, above.

41. Osiris, an Egyptian god, was the spouse of Isis; see *Apology*, n. 34. For the allusions to the foot-washing scene, see John 13:3–5.

42. Cf. *Spectacles*, nn. 13 and 19.

43. The reference is, apparently, to a community leader, who might be, e.g., a ruler of the synagogue; cf. Luke 8:41; John 3:1.

44. For these appurtenances of the Jewish cult, see Ex. 25:10–27:19 and Heb. 9:1–5.

CHAPTER 10

(1) Hence, when, to win approval for the wearing of crowns on the grounds of common usage, you declare that ornaments of the heathen gods are also found in the household of the true God, you are implicitly basing your argument on this premise: Whatever is not found in the service of God must not be applied to common usage. (4) Now, the substances used in the service of idols are pure as being creatures of God, and, to that extent, they are fit for common use. Yet it is the application of this use that makes all the difference. (5) For I kill a cock for my benefit, the same as Socrates did for Aesculapius,[45] and, if I find the odor of a place unpleasant, I burn some Arabian incense, but without the same ceremony, the same dress, and the same pomp with which it is done to idols. Now the crown is made to be an offering to idols. (6) With this ceremony, dress, and pomp it is offered to idols who originated it, and to whom its use most especially belongs simply because it is not found in the service of God—so that it cannot be shared. Rather, it is considered as belonging to those with whose early history, festivals, and services it is associated. (9) For crowns adorn the very doors, victims, and altars of idols; their ministers and priests wear them, also.[46]

(10) It now remains for us to examine the special grounds for wearing crowns. For, in showing them to be alien—or rather, even opposed—to Christian discipline, we shall also prove that reason does not in the least vindicate the use of this kind of attire.

CHAPTER 11

(1) Now, to come down to the very heart of this question about the soldier's crown, should we not really first examine the right of a Christian to be in the military service at all? In other words, why discuss the merely accidental detail, when the foundation on which it rests is deserving of censure? Are we to believe it lawful to take an oath of allegiance to a mere human

45. See Plato, *Phaedo* 118A; as the last request before his death, Socrates asked Crito to sacrifice a cock to Aesculapius, the god of healing.

46. For a similar argument used elsewhere, see *Spectacles* 4–12.

being over and above the oath of fidelity to God?[47] Can we obey another master, having chosen Christ? Can we forsake father, mother, and all our relatives, whom by divine law we must honor and love? (2) Is it likely we are permitted to carry a sword when our Lord said that he who takes the sword will perish by the sword?[48] Will the son of peace who is forbidden to engage in a lawsuit[49] espouse the deeds of war? (3) Will he stand guard before temples that he has renounced? Will he protect by night those very demons whom in the daytime he has put to flight by his exorcisms? Will he ask the watch-word[50] from his commander-in-chief—he who has already received one from God? Will his corpse be cremated according to military custom—when to him Christ remitted the eternal punishment by fire he had deserved?

(4) Yes, these and many other offenses can be observed in the discharge of military duties—offenses that must be interpreted as acts of desertion. To leave the camp of Light and enlist in the camp of darkness[51] means going over to the enemy. To be sure, the case is different for those who are converted af-

47. In the very compressed Latin, just three words, *humanum sacramentum divino*, represent in translation the contrasting expressions, "an oath of allegiance to a mere human being" and "an oath of fidelity to God," so that here the one word *sacramentum* denotes both the Christian's baptismal pledge and the oath of fidelity sworn in the classical period to the commanding general by each soldier. (In Tertullian's time the oath was sworn only to the emperor on his accession, on the anniversary of his accession, and at the beginning of every year; cf. Pier Angelo Gramaglia, *Tertulliano, La corona: Introduzione, traduzione, e note* [Rome: Edizione Paoline,1980] 188–91). On the military oath see the article "sacramentum" in Simon Hornblower and Antony Spawforth, eds., *Oxford Classical Dictionary*, 3d ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996).

48. Cf. Matt. 26:52.

49. Cf. 1 Cor. 6:7 and Matt. 5:40. For the expression "son of peace," see Luke 10:6 (RSV, but NRSV paraphrases: "If anyone is there who shares in your peace").

50. "Watchword": *signum.* The word denoted the military watchword received from the commanding officer and handed down to the soldiers by the centurions; in all probability it was thus intended to suggest the Creed as the Christian's watchword. But the word also evoked an image of the mark tattooed on a military recruit, and thus suggested as well the sign of the cross received at baptism; see Fontaine, *Sur la couronne,* 138–39.

51. For the light-darkness contrast, see 2 Cor. 6:14; Eph. 5:8; Col. 1:12–13; 1 Thess. 5:4–5.

ter they have been bound to military service. John admitted soldiers to baptism. There were also two most faithful centurions: the one whom Christ praised, and the other whom Peter instructed.[52] But once we have embraced the faith and have been baptized, we either must immediately leave military service (as many have done); or we must resort to all kinds of excuses in order to avoid any action that is also forbidden in civilian life, lest we offend God; or, last of all, for the sake of God we must suffer the fate that a mere citizen-faith[53] was no less ready to accept. (5) For military service offers neither exemption from punishment of sins nor relief from martyrdom. The gospel is one and the same for the Christian at all times whatever his occupation in life. Jesus will deny those who deny him and confess those who confess him.[54] (6) The state of faith admits no plea of compulsion. (7) Moreover, that kind of argument destroys the very essence of our sacramental oath, for it will be possible to maintain that inclination is a compulsion, too, since there is, indeed, some sort of compelling force in it.[55]

CHAPTER 12

(1) I will now return to the secondary point of the matter. Let us assume that military service is permitted up to the point of wearing a crown. We know from Claudius[56] that the laurel crown is sacred to Apollo and to Bacchus. (2) The myrtle belongs to Venus.[57] Moreover, when a soldier is crowned with an

52. Cf. Luke 3:14 (John); Matt. 8:5–10 and Luke 7:2–9 (Christ); Acts 10 (Peter).

53. I.e., the faith of one who was merely a Christian civilian, not a soldier. For a vivid account of such alternatives actually placed before soldiers a century later (299), see Lactantius, *On the Deaths of the Persecutors* 10, and Timothy D. Barnes, *Constantine and Eusebius* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1981), 18–19.

54. Cf. Matt. 10:32–33; Luke 12:8–9.

55. On the issues surrounding military service in the early Church, see Swift, *Early Fathers on War*, 68–69 (cf. *Apology*, n. 149). For an extensive bibliography on "War, Peace and Conscientious Objection," see Ruggiero, *De Corona,* xliv–xlviii, and for a collection of literary witnesses to the discussion of the theme in the first five centuries, see ibid. 133–59, in addition to Swift, *Early Fathers on War, passim.*

56. For Claudius see n. 33, above.

57. The myrtle, sacred to Venus, was worn to celebrate a bloodless victory.

olive wreath, he is guilty of idolatry through his devotion to Minerva. In all these relations we see the defiled and all-defiling superstitious character of the military crown. In fact, I think that the very motives for wearing it causes its defilement.

(3) Take the annual public pronouncement of vows.[58] What do you think of it? The first takes place in the general's quarters; the second, in heathen temples. In addition to the places, note the words, also: "We promise to give to you, then, O Jupiter, an ox with golden horns." What is the real sense of that pronouncement? Is it not a denial of the faith? Even though the Christian says nothing on that occasion with his mouth, he makes his response by having the crown on his head. The wearing of the laurel crown is likewise enjoined at the distribution of a largess, though, plainly, you do not attend this ceremony without making a profit. (4) Idolater! Do you not see that you are selling Christ for a few pieces of gold.[59] Will this be to "Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's and to God the things that are God's"? Is it not rather to render the person to God and take the denarius from Caesar?[60] Is the laurel of triumph made of leaves, or of corpses?[61] Is it adorned with ribbons, or with tombs? Is it anointed with perfumes, or with the tears of wives and mothers, some of them, perhaps, Christian women, for we know that Christianity has also spread among the barbarians. (5) There is yet another kind of military service—that of the bodyguard in the imperial household. These men, too, perform services in connection with the ceremonial observed in the imperial court. But even then you are

58. Tertullian refers to the vows offered for the welfare of the Emperor and the state at the beginning of each new year; cf. Tacitus, *Annals* 4.17.1 and 16.22.1; Pliny, *Ep.* 10.35; and n. 47, above.

59. An allusion to Judas; cf. Matt. 27:3–5.

60. Cf. Matt. 22:21; Mark 12:17; Luke 20:25. "Take the denarius from Caesar" refers to the donative emperors gave soldiers.

61. One occasion for a donative, at which the soldiers wore crowns, was the celebration of a general's victory, called a "triumph." In Rome, during the triumphal procession, a slave held a laurel wreath over the general's head. Some ancient authors considered that the soldiers following the triumphal chariot wore laurel crowns since they had to purify themselves from human slaughter before entering Rome; for the evidence see Gramaglia, *La corona,* 211–12 and n. 97.

still the soldier and servant of Caesar, when you owe yourself to God.

CHAPTER 13

(1) For state reasons, the various orders of the citizens also wear laurel crowns, and there are special crowns of gold for the magistrates, as at Athens and Rome. More elaborate even than these are the Etruscan crowns. Then, there are the golden crowns of the provincials; too large for human heads, they rather fit statues. However, your orders and your magistracies and the very name of your senate, the Church, all are Christ's. For you are his, inscribed in the Book of Life.[62] (2) And pay no attention to the state horses with their crowns.[63] Your Lord, when he wished to enter Jerusalem, did not even possess an ass of his own. (3) The rabble, too, wear crowns—now because of some great rejoicing for the successes of the emperors; now on account of special municipal festivals. Wantonness, indeed, tries to make its own any occasion of public gladness.[64] (4) But you are a resident alien[65] in this world and your city is the heavenly Jerusalem. You have your own citizen lists, your own calendar, and you have no part in the joys of this world.[66]

The bridegroom is decked with a crown at marriage, too, and that is the reason why we do not marry pagans, lest they drag us down into idolatry, with which their marriage ceremony begins. (5) You have the Apostle, too, bidding us to marry in the Lord.[67] There is a crowning, also, when a slave is granted

62. Cf. Phil. 4:3; Rev. 17:8.

63. I.e., those that draw the triumphal chariot of a victorious general, thus contrasting with the Lord's entry into Jerusalem on an ass (Zech. 9:9; Matt. 21:1–11).

64. Cf. *Apology* 35 (pp. 55–56) for the same sentiment.

65. "Resident alien": *peregrinus*, as in the Latin Vulgate of Heb. 11:13 and 1 Pet. 2:11.

66. Cf. Heb. 12:22–23; also Phil. 3:20. "Calendar": *fastos*, a register of festivals and special events.

67. Cf. 1 Cor. 7:39. In the Roman world not only did the bride and groom wear floral crowns, but their guests did so as well. The wearing of such crowns might originally have had an apotropaic purpose, or have been an extension of the sacrifice with which the nuptial ceremony began. Christians adopted the custom after the idolatrous associations had been lost; cf. Gramaglia, *La corona,* 209–10 and n. 91.

worldly freedom,[68] but you have been already redeemed by Christ and that at a great price.[69] How, then, can the world manumit the slave of another? Though the result might seem to be freedom, it really is not, but rather more like slavery. In the world all things are but semblance, and nothing is real. (6) If you really believe the freedom of the world to be real, so much so that you even seal it with a crown, you have lost the liberty of Christ, which you imagine to be slavery rather than freedom. Will there be any need for discussing the games as occasions of the wearing of crowns, when their very names condemn them, being both sacred to the gods and in honor of the dead?[70]

(7) I imagine that by now we have covered all the cases in which one might wear a crown, and they are all shown to be totally alien to us as Christians. They are foreign to us, unholy, forbidden, once for all forsworn in the solemn affirmation of the baptismal vow. For they surely are "the pomps of the Devil and his angels."[71] What are they but worldly positions and honors, festivals, insincere vows by the people, exhibitions of human servility, empty flatteries, and glory that brings bitterness in its train? And, at the base of them all, what is there but idolatry?

(8) Finally, the world places crowns upon brothels, latrines, bakeshops, elementary schools, and the very amphitheater; they crown, too, the place where the clothes are stripped from the slain gladiators, and the very biers of the dead. (9) But, surely, a Christian will not even defile the door of his house with laurel crowns if he only remembers how many gods the Devil has attached to doors.[72] For, we have Janus for the door itself, Limentinus for the threshold, Forculus and Carna for the partitions and hinges[73]—devils, all of them.

68. On *saecularis*, "worldly," see n. 34, above. Similarly, "world," just below, renders *saeculum*.

69. Cf. 1 Pet. 1:18–19; 1 Cor. 6:20.

70. Cf. *Spectacles* 6.

71. For the pomps of the Devil, see chapter 3 and n. 14, above. The sentence that immediately follows gives further definition of these "pomps": "worldly positions and honors," etc.

72. Cf. *Apology* 35 (p. 55–56).

73. As Tertullian shows from the Latin in this passage, the names of the gods

CHAPTER 14

(1) You see, then, surely, how unfitting it is for a Christian to put on his head this symbol of idolatry; in fact, I might have said, "put on Christ," since he is the head of a Christian man.[74] But even the head that submits to a veil (I mean woman's) has no room also for a band. She has the burden of her own lowliness to bear. (2) If the head of a woman should never be seen uncovered because of the angels,[75] much less should she ever wear a crown. A crown on the head of woman is merely beauty made seductive, the sign of complete wantonness. Therefore, a woman will be guided by the advice of the Apostle and avoid a too elaborate adornment, so that she is crowned not even by the skillful arrangement of her hair.[76]

(3) To what kind of a crown, I ask you, did Christ Jesus submit for the salvation of both sexes, he who is the head of man and the glory of woman and the husband of the Church?[77] It was made from thorns and thistles—a symbol of the sins which the soil of the flesh brought forth for us, but which the power of the Cross removed, blunting every sting of death since the

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reflect their essential attributes: Janus, "passage way," a god represented with two faces, one on the front and one on the back of his head, hence "looking two ways" (cf. "January"; the Latin word is etymologically related to the verb "to go," so that the noun *janua* has the sense of "passage-way"); Limentinus (from *limen),* "threshold"; Forculus (from *foris),* "door," "entrance"; and Carna (from *cardo),* "hinge." The passage reveals the great extent to which pagan life was invested with the sense of the presence of divinity. On the omnipresence of the gods in ancient life, see Tertullian, *On Idolatry* 16–23, and Fox, *Pagans and Christians,* 66–68 and 82–89.

74. Cf. 1 Cor. 11:3.

75. Cf. 1 Cor. 11:10.

76. Cf. 1 Tim. 2:9. For Tertullian's advice on female attire, see his two books *On the Apparel of Women.*

77. Allusions to 1 Cor. 11:3–7 (head) and Eph. 5:22–32 (husband). "The glory of the woman" renders *feminae facies,* literally, "the face of the woman," thus offering an expression parallel to "the head of the man." The meaning is not obvious, but several passages in the Latin Vulgate of the New Testament closely associate *facies* with "glory" (e.g., 2 Cor. 3:7; 4:6; 2 Thess. 1:9; Rev. 1:16), and Tertullian may intend the same association here, deriving the idea from the beauty of a woman's face. If so, Christ might be regarded as the beauty, i.e., the glory, of a woman.

head of the Lord bore its pain.[78] If, then, you owe your head to him as a debt for these favors, try as best you can to repay him in the fashion that he offered his head for yours.

CHAPTER 15

(1) Keep untainted, therefore, for God what is his; he will crown it if so he choose. And he will; in fact, he invites us to be crowned. To him who conquers he says: "I will give the crown of life."[79] Your destiny is to wear a diadem. For Christ Jesus has made us to be as kings to God and his Father,[80] so why bother with a flower that is destined to die? Yours is a flower from the root of Jesse, upon which the grace of the divine Spirit has rested in all its fullness, a flower untainted, unfading and everlasting.[81]

(3) Choosing this flower, the good soldier has advanced in rank in the heavenly army. Are you not ashamed, fellow soldiers of Christ, that you will be condemned, not by Christ, but by some soldier of Mithras? At the initiation, deep in a cavern, in the very camp of darkness, a crown is presented to the candidate at the point of a sword, as if in mimicry of martyrdom, and put upon his head; then he is admonished to resist and throw it off and possibly slip it on the shoulder of the god, saying: "Mithras is my crown." He is at once acknowledged as a soldier of Mithras if he throws the crown away, saying that in his god he has his crown. (4) And thenceforward he never puts a crown on his head, and he uses that as a sign of identification, if anywhere he be tested as to his oath of initiation.[82] Let us, then,

78. For thorns, the symbol of sins, see Gen. 3:18; for the sting of death, 1 Cor. 15:55.

79. Cf. Rev. 2:10; James 1:12.

80. Cf. Rev. 1:6; 5:10.

81. Cf. Isa. 11:1 and 1 Pet. 5:4.

82. Mithras was a deity (originally Indo-Iranian) who was adopted in the Roman world as, chiefly, a sun-god, with a mystery cult widely popular among soldiers of the second and third centuries A.D. This passage gives us some of the most precise information we have on a Mithraic initiation ceremony—initiation into the title of "soldier." The ceremony took place in a subterranean crypt—hence the darkness. The crown placed on the head symbolized the future victory of the initiate, a victory associated with the triumph of the solar god over the darkness. But the initiate refuses to wear the crown, indicating that di-

recognize the wiles of the Devil, who imitates some of God's things with no other design than to put us to shame by the faithfulness of his own servants and to condemn us.[83]

vinization is still premature. Mithraists were excused from wearing the crown, and it has been suggested that the Christian soldier who is the focus of interest in *The Crown* expected the same privilege. See Fontaine, *Sur la couronne*, 180–81. On Mithraism and initiation into the Mithraic mysteries, see M. J. Vermaseren, *Mithras, The Secret God,* trans. Therese and Vincent Megaw (New York, N.Y.: Barnes and Noble, 1963), 129–53.

83. Cf. *To the Martyrs* 4, and the introduction to that treatise.

6

FLIGHT IN TIME OF PERSECUTION

Introduction

Tertullian's conviction, expressed in this treatise, that a Christian must not run away from persecution did not in general receive the support of Christian leaders who either preceded or followed him. Indeed, even he in his earlier years had accepted the traditional wisdom of the Church that one might follow the command given to the apostles to "flee from town to town" in order to avoid arrest.[1] In its main contention, therefore, the treatise is not representative of early Christian thought.

Nevertheless, the treatise contributes much to our theme, for it offers a remarkable, if brief, insight into the anxieties that could be aroused among Christians in the early third century by the possibility of persecution by pagans. We learn that for these Christians the issue was not only whether or not they should, or would, flee, but whether they should even assemble for the liturgy, for numerous people meeting together at an appointed time was an obvious indication to pagans of Christian identity. But there is, perhaps, no more arresting sign of Christian anxiety than the indication Tertullian gives us here of the decision Christians might confront to buy their safety. Nearly half a century later, many Christians would, in order to avoid a

1. Cf. *To his Wife* 1.3.4.

terrible fate, obtain certificates as (false) evidence that they had publicly sacrificed to the pagan gods.[2] We gather from Tertullian's comments that here it was a question rather of Christians being bullied or blackmailed by pagans—an informer, some soldier, or some petty governor (cf. 12.3). Should one "buy off" a pagan who threatened to reveal one's Christian identity? (The question implies a less than creditable pagan moral habit!) Indeed, at a higher level, priests and bishops were ready to bargain, apparently with the governor, on behalf of a whole congregation.

It is appropriate, moreover, in this final selection to look beyond our central theme and to underscore certain characteristics that should enhance our appreciation of Tertullian's work. First, this text tells us something of Tertullian as author. We are assured that the argument here is well considered—the work is, in fact, the final, polished edition of an earlier, apparently hasty draft. Tertullian seems somewhat characteristically to have reconsidered his works: we have seen that *Spectacles* was published in both a Greek and a Latin edition; some believe that the *Apology* appeared in an earlier form than that represented by the received text;[3] and we know that the multi-volume work *Against Marcion* was edited several times.[4] Second, we see Tertullian at work here as "theologian," attempting to explain that most intractable of moral issues, the problem of pain: the evil that we suffer must be good in that it comes through the will of God, though the pain that we perceive as evil comes through the agency of the devil, who carries out God's will—in the case of persecution, to test and refine Christian faith. We note the appeal, as in *The Crown,* to the rational: what is good is rational, because it is divine, because it proceeds from God. Our failure to perceive the divine reason does not destroy the goodness of the divine act. Third, the treatise offers an interesting insight into Tertullian as biblical exegete. His attempt to place the scriptural injunction "to flee from city to city" within its cultural context and so to give it a relative value will arouse the inter-

2. See Cyprian, *Epp.* 20.2 and 30.3.

3. The evidence is complex and controversial; see Barnes, *Tertullian,* 13–14, 239–40, and on Tertullian's practice of revising his work, 325–27; see also *Apology* 19 and n. 82, above.

4. See *Against Marcion* 1.1.1–2.

est, and perhaps the admiration, of readers familiar with modern efforts to resolve the tension between the authority of Scripture and the cultural relativity of scriptural passages.

At the same time, the treatise reveals, more sharply than any other in this collection, the growing force of Montanism in Tertullian's life, but at the same time the ambiguity of Tertullian's relation during his Montanist phase to the incipient Catholic Church of the early third century. His Montanism stands out clear and pronounced from the beginning of the work: he speaks of the "Paraclete," cites Montanist oracles, and even declares Fabius (who is obviously a Catholic, but otherwise unknown) as generally guilty because he has failed to accept the Paraclete. On the other hand, he addresses Fabius as a brother, with whom, along with some others, he has had an apparently not acrimonious debate. Moreover, Tertullian has in view an audience whom he still regards as faithful Christians—these are not, as in the treatise *On Modesty,* addressed as "Psychics," with the implication that they are no longer fully Christian. The clergy are excoriated for their faithless leadership, but do not appear to be outside Tertullian's community. Thus Tertullian's identity with the Montanist community appears to have gained strength, but there is no sure indication that when he wrote *Flight In Time Of Persecuation* he had left the Catholic Church. It is possible to imagine that at this point Tertullian was part of a charismatic group still within the Church, though feeling increasingly estranged from it.[5]

5. Douglas Powell argues that Tertullian did not leave the Church of Carthage to become a Montanist, but formed a "little church" within the Church (*Vigiliae Christianae* 29 [1975]: 33–54). Similarly, Gerald Lewis Bray, *Holiness and the Will of God: Perspectives on the Theology of Tertullian* (Atlanta, Ga.: John Knox Press, 1979), 54–63, contends that "Montanism, though it was defended by Tertullian, [never] conquered his allegiance" (p. 63). This position has also been taken by David Rankin, *Tertullian and the Church,* 41–51. Rankin implies that the categories by which one determines position in relation to the Church were less clearly defined in early Christian antiquity than they later came to be, so that it was possible for Tertullian to be in the Church though almost totally estranged from it. What is an uncomfortable intellectual ambiguity for us was not necessarily a distressing existential ambiguity for Tertullian or the Catholic Church. The majority of scholars, however, accept that at some point Tertullian eventually made a formal break with the Church. Barnes, *Tertullian,* 42–48, 327–28, attempts to trace (with conjectural dates) Tertullian's path to Montanism.

For the conjectural date and circumstances of this treatise, see n. 6, below.

The Text

CHAPTER 1

(1) A short time ago, my brother Fabius, on the occasion of some news or other, you asked me whether flight was justified in time of persecution. On that occasion, I offered some arguments against it—arguments that did justice to the place and the time, and satisfied the earnest requests of certain people—and took the rough draft along with me. Now I intend to take up my pen and to resume my discussion of the topic in fuller detail. For, you see, your request caught my interest, and, besides, the conditions of the times made the question a pressing one. For, as bitter persecutions threaten us,[6] with all the more zeal should we pursue a solution to your question as to how a faithful Christian should conduct himself. It is particularly imperative that the matter be weighed among you people, who, perhaps, by not accepting the Paraclete, the guide to all the truth,[7] are still deservedly subject to the investigation of other matters as well.

(2) To take up in proper order the case you presented, it occurs to me that we should determine the origin of persecution—whether it comes from God or from the Devil; in that way, we will more easily get an idea of how to face it. (3) Let us come, then, to the nature of "persecution." At the outset, let me say that it never happens without God willing it, and it is fitting—even, at times, necessary—for him to do so, to the approval or condemnation of his servants. (4) In this sense a per-

6. If the treatise is dated 212 (see Quain, FOTC, vol. 40, 273), the fear of persecution may be related to the time when Scapula was governor, to whom Tertullian addressed a treatise, evidently in the midst of persecution. In this case the treatise follows shortly after *The Crown,* dated 211. Barnes originally dated the treatise 208/209 (*Tertullian,* 46–47), a view encouraged by the observation that Tertullian speaks much less stridently here as a Montanist than he does in *On Modesty,* generally acknowledged as one of his very latest works. In his Postscript, however, Barnes offers a revised date of "sometime after 208" (p. 328).

7. Cf. John 16:13.

secution is a "judgment," and the verdict is either approval or condemnation. To be sure, to God alone it belongs to judge, and this is his winnowing fan which even now cleanses the Lord's threshing floor—his Church, winnowing the mixed heap of the faithful and separating the wheat of the martyrs from the chaff of the ones who deny.[8]

(5) In still another sense, a persecution can be considered as a contest. And who decrees any contest if not the one who provides the crown and the prizes? Obviously the superintendent of the games and the one who sets the prize is the one who decides who is the winner of the contest.[9] The essence, then, of a persecution is the glory of God. And whatever concerns the glory of God will certainly flow from the will of God. But when is God more sincerely believed than in time of persecution? (6) When persecution strikes, the Church is mightily stirred; then the faithful are more careful in their preparations, greater attention is given to fasts and station days,[10] to prayers and humility, to mutual charity and love, to holiness and temperance. People have time for nothing but fear and hope. Therefore, it is clear that persecution, which works for the improvement of the servants of God, cannot be blamed on the Devil.

CHAPTERS 2–3

(1) On the other hand, it might seem that persecution stems from the Devil, who commits the evil acts that make up the persecution, if we reason as follows: evil is not from God but from the Devil, and a persecution is made up of evil actions (for what could be more evil than to treat the bishops[11] of the true God

8. Cf. Matt. 3:12.

9. For the language and imagery of the contest, see *To the Martyrs,* n. 18.

10. In Tertullian's Carthage station days were evidently set fasts on Wednesday and Friday of each week (see *On the Prayer* 14 and *On Fasting* 10 and 13). They are to be distinguished from the later "station days" on which Mass was celebrated in "station churches" in Rome.

11. "Bishops": *antistites*; cf. *The Crown,* n. 13. Here, it is possible that the word should be understood as "priest" rather than "bishop. " In the Vulgate Old Testament the word *antistites* appears in 2 Paralipomenon 29:34 (= 2 Chron. 29:34), where it has been translated "other priests" (NRSV). Note, also, that in this passage Tertullian plays on the ambiguity of the Latin *iniquitas, iniquus* (noun and adjective, respectively), which can connote both "evil" and "unjust";

and all the followers of truth as if they were the vilest criminals?). Still, we must realize that, as you cannot have a persecution without evil on the part of the Devil, nor a trial of faith without a persecution, the evil that seems required for the trial of faith provides the instrument of, but not the justification for, persecution. The real cause of the persecution is the act of God's will, choosing that there be a trial of faith; then there follows evil on the part of the Devil as the chosen instrument of persecution.

Thus, a persecution happens *through* the Devil, but not by him. Satan can have no power over the servants of the living God, unless the Lord permits it, either in order that the Devil may be destroyed by the victory of the faith of the elect in overcoming temptation, or that some people be shown, by their defection under fire, to have belonged to Satan. (7) Again, temptation may happen in order to humble a person, as the Apostle tells us that there was given to him a thorn, a messenger of Satan, to buffet him.[12] The Apostle himself handed Phygellus and Hermogenes over to Satan so that by being chastised they might not blaspheme.[13] And so you see that, far from possessing power in his own right, the devil can more easily be granted it by the servants of God. (1) It is therefore clear that in time of persecutions more than at other times we are approved or condemned, humbled or corrected. For when we are tried in the flame of persecution, then it is that we are tested for the steadfastness of our faith. (2) I do not see how anyone can have doubt of this, except those whose faith is worthless and cold and who with trembling assemble together. I have heard you say: "Just because we rush madly in crowds to church,[14] we arouse the curiosity of the pagans, and we fear lest we stir their

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but in the concluding sentences of 1.1 (omitted in this selection) Tertullian sets *iniquitas* in opposition to *iustitia,* "justice," so that the connotation of "injustice" inevitably emerges—hence here a double meaning, including the sense, "what is more unjust than to treat followers of truth like criminals."

12. Cf. 2 Cor. 12:7.

13. Cf. 2 Tim. 1:15 (Phygellus and Hermogenes turned away from Paul); 1 Tim. 1:20 (Hymenaeus and Alexander delivered to Satan).

14. "Church": *ecclesia,* but the notion of assembling in a liturgical context seems to remain paramount.

opposition." Do you not realize that God is the Lord of all? If he wills it, you will suffer persecution; if he does not, the pagans will not utter a word against you.

CHAPTER 4

(1) Now we can go on to your query, and, as a result of this preliminary discussion, conclude that we must not flee in time of persecution. For, if persecution comes from God, we cannot run from it, precisely because it comes from God. And this for two reasons: we may not, and, we cannot. We may not, because what comes from God is good. There are, to be sure, many things that happen by God's will, which, incidentally, bring harm to someone. But the precise reason why a thing is good is that it proceeds from God, because it is divine, because it is rational. For everything divine is rational, and what is rational and not at the same time good? What good thing is not divine? Now, if something that comes from God is good indeed in its natural state but seems to be evil to human perception, then, surely, the thing *is* really good, and human senses must be in error. (3) Therefore, if persecution is an intrinsic good, it would be a sin to refuse what is good. As a matter of fact, we cannot really avoid persecution, since it comes from God, and no one can escape what God has willed.

CHAPTER 5

(1) But someone may say: "I flee lest I perish by denying my faith. God if he wishes can bring me back before the judge, even if I run away." First answer me this: Are you certain you will succumb, if you stay and face persecution, or are you uncertain? If you are certain, then you have already denied the faith. If, on the other hand, you are uncertain, why not presume you could be a confessor? (2) Let us recognize his power who is able to protect us if we do not flee. (3) Would we not be showing more strength and trust in God if we were to say: "I will do my part; I will not run away; if God so wills, he will protect me"? The holy martyr Rutilius time and again fled persecution from place to place, even spending money to buy his way out of danger—as he thought he was doing. While enjoying the security he had provided for himself, he was unexpectedly caught,

haled before the judge, and worn out with torments (which I suspect were a punishment for his flight!); and, finally, being cast into the fire, he paid to the mercy of God the suffering he had been unwilling to bear.[15]

CHAPTER 6

(1) "But," someone might say, "in fleeing from city to city, he was merely following the precept of Christ." Yes, that is an argument that was adduced by a certain individual, who had himself fled, though the Lord's command applies to certain persons, times, and circumstances. We read: "When they begin to persecute you, flee from city to city."[16] I maintain that that text applies only to the persons of the apostles, and to their times and circumstances; you can see this from the following words, which certainly refer exclusively to the apostles: "Do not go in the direction of the Gentiles, nor enter a city of the Samaritans, but rather go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel."[17] (3) Indeed, it would seem that the precise circumstances of the apostles even required the injunction to flee, since their first obligation was to preach to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.

(4) It was not his idea that they should secretly flee into some city, but openly proclaim the Gospel everywhere, and, for that very action, expose themselves to persecutions everywhere, until they should fulfill their teaching. For the command to flee was restricted to the confines of Judea. But for us now, there is no restriction to the boundaries of Judea for our preaching, now that the Holy Spirit has been poured out upon all flesh.[18] (6) If the restriction concerning setting foot in the ways of the Gentiles and entering into the cities of the Samaritans has come to an end, why should not the command to flee come also to an end, since it was enunciated at the same time? Accordingly, from that time on, once they had covered Israel, the

15. Nothing else is known of the martyr Rutilius.

16. Matt. 10:23.

17. Matt. 10:5–6. In debate with those who know the Scriptures, Tertullian characteristically practices contextual exegesis, as he appears to be doing here. Thus "the following words" (for *subsequentes sensus)* should refer to a passage that follows the text under discussion; in fact, the command not to go in the direction of the gentiles precedes the command to flee from city to city—possibly an inadvertent mistake.

18. Cf. Acts 2:17.

apostles turned to the Gentiles; they did not flee from city to city, nor did they hesitate to suffer. (7) Since, therefore, even in the times of the apostles a time limit was set to the command to flee, it surely would not be right for us to prolong a practice which ceased with our teachers.

CHAPTER 7

(1) Let us examine next whether or not the other commands of the Lord are in accord with a lasting precept to flee from persecution. (2) Does he not tell us: "Do not be afraid of those who kill the body, but can do no harm to the soul, but rather be afraid of him who can destroy both soul and body in hell"?[19] Moreover, what is his answer to cowards? "He who thinks more of his own life than of me is not worthy of me and he who does not take up his cross and follow me, cannot be my disciple."[20] And finally, in the Apocalypse, it is not flight that he offers to the fearful, but some portion among the rest of the damned in the pit of brimstone and fire, which is the second death.[21]

CHAPTER 8

(1) Christ himself fled from violence on occasion, but he did it for the same reason for which he had commanded the apostles do so—namely, until he should fulfill his ministry of teaching.[22] When he had done that, he not merely stood firm to face his persecutors, but he refused to ask of his Father assistance in the form of the angelic hosts, and he even objected when Peter reached for his sword. He likewise said that his soul was troubled unto death and his flesh weak.[23] He did this to show you by the weakness of his body and the timidity of his soul that both of these substances were in him truly human,[24] and that

19. See Matt. 10:28.

20. See Luke 14:26; Matt. 10: 37–39.

21. Cf. Rev. 21:8.

22. Perhaps inferred from such passages as John 7:1–10 and Luke 4:29–30, though there may also be an allusion to the flight of the Christ-child to Egypt (Matt. 2:13–15).

23. Cf. Matt. 26:38 and 41 (the troubled soul and weak flesh); John 18:10–11 (Peter's sword); Matt. 26:53–54 (angelic hosts).

24. The statement appears to refer primarily to certain Docetic groups who believed that the real Christ was entirely spiritual, but inhabited a body that was phantasmic, with the result that the real Christ never suffered on the cross. See

both of them were in themselves unequal to the task without the strength of the Spirit. (2) Thus you may learn what it is you have to work with, and which should be subordinate to which—that is, the weak to the strong, and not be doing what you now do, begging off on the score of the weakness of the flesh, while paying no attention to the strength of the Spirit.

CHAPTER 9

(1) Now, it is certain that the apostles were true to every word of the teaching of God. Can you show me any place in which they have reinstated the divine command to flee from city to city? They could never have adduced a precept of flight; that would have been so contrary to their own practice. Were they not writing their letters to the churches from, above all, prison, or from islands whither they had gone, precisely because they had confessed the faith?[25] (2) Paul tells us that we must stand firm and be girt for battle. He points out our weapons, too, which would hardly be of use to runaways.[26] (3) Further, John tells us that we must cast out fear. "There is no fear in love; but perfect love casts out fear."[27]

(4) Yet, who will flee from persecution, if not the person who fears? And who will fear, if not the one who loves not? If you ask counsel of the Spirit, what will the Spirit approve more than that word from the Spirit? For all are exhorted almost to martyrdom—not to flight. Hence, I shall mention this, too; it says:[28]

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the article on "Docetism" in the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity*. But there were various contemporary theories on the nature of Christ's flesh; these Tertullian reviews and attacks in his treatise *On the Flesh of Christ*. His classic exposition of the human and divine nature of Christ is found in his treatise *Against Praxeas*.

25. Several, but not all, of the Pauline letters purport to be written from prison; the Apocalypse was attributed to John, writing from the island of Patmos, to which he had been banished (cf. Rev. 1:9).

26. Cf. Eph. 6:13–17.

27. See 1 John 4:18.

28. Tertullian cites two Montanist oracles here; a version of the second is found in *On the Soul* 55.5. Additional Montanist oracles may be found in other writings of Tertullian and in other sources as well. For a collection see Ronald Heine, *The Montanist Oracles and Testimonia,* NAPS Patristic Monograph Series, vol. 14 (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 1989); for the oracles cited here see pp. 72–73. Montanism emerged in Phrygia (central Asia Minor) about 170 under Montanus, Maximilla and Priscilla; for a brief history of Montanism, see

"If you are held up to infamy, that is good. He who does not suffer ignominy before men will know it before God. Never be ashamed, because it is your very righteousness that sets you before the public gaze. Why are you ashamed of what is to your glory? You gain power, when you are before the eyes of men." So also the Spirit tells us elsewhere: "Do not then ask to die on bridal beds, or in miscarriages, or from gentle fevers; rather, seek to die a martyr that he may be glorified who suffered for you."

CHAPTER 10

(1) Some will turn to the worldly wisdom of the Greek proverb: "One who turns and runs away lives to fight another day."[29] And runs away again in the next battle? When is a person going to win, if one runs away defeated? I will give you a worldly answer to that one: "Is it such a terrible thing to die?"[30] (2) O Christian, are you afraid of a human being?—you whom the angels should fear, since you will be their judge;[31] you who should be feared by the demons, since you have received power over the devils, too;[32] you who should be feared by the whole world, since the world will be judged by you, too.[33] You have put on Christ, you have been baptized into Christ,[34] yet you flee be-

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Grant, *Augustus to Constantine,* 131–44, and for an interesting demographic study, see William Tabernee, *Montanist Inscriptions and Testimonia: Epigraphic Sources Illustrating the History of Montanism,* NAPS Patristic Monograph Series, vol. 16 (Macon, Ga.: Mercer University Press, 1997), 553–69. See also the article on "Montanism" in the *Encyclopedia of Early Christianity,* 778–80.

29. This Greek proverb is quoted by Aulus Gellius, *Attic Nights* 17.21.31. This passage from Tertullian is quoted by Erasmus, who cites numerous variations on the proverb in antiquity; see Erasmus, *Adages* 1.10.40, trans. R. A. B. Mynors, The Collected Works of Erasmus, vol. 32 (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1989), 252.

30. See Virgil, *Aeneid* 12.646. "Worldly" translates *de saeculo.*

31. Cf. 1 Cor. 6:2. The concept expressed here, that the redeemed will judge the angels, is pervasive in Tertullian's reflection on ethics and eschatology; see Sider, "Literary Artifice," 118, (cf. *The Crown,* n. 27).

32. Cf. Matt. 10:1 and 8; Mark 6:7; Luke 9:1; also Mark 16:17.

33. An allusion to 1 Cor. 6:2, with, perhaps, an echo of John 16:11 to suggest that as the world stood condemned in its rejection of Christ, so in the trial of the Christian the world is being judged.

34. Cf. Gal. 3:27.

fore the Devil! (3) Is that person not better off who, trusting in the protection of God, says: "He is the Lord, all things are his; let him do what he will, I shall not run away"?

CHAPTER 11

(1) Thus should every servant of God both think and act, even if one is in a lower station of life. But when those in authority—I mean deacons, presbyters, and bishops—take flight, when the leaders run away, who of the common crowd can hope to persuade anyone to stand firm in battle? (2) Christ said that he is a wicked shepherd who flees when he sees the wolf and leaves the flock to be devoured.[35] Such a shepherd will be banished from the farm. Thus Zechariah threatens: "Arise, O sword, against the shepherds."[36] And against them Ezekiel and Jeremiah thunder with similar recriminations, in that they not merely batten upon their sheep and fatten themselves, but they themselves disperse the flock and, without a leader to guide them, leave them prey to all the beasts of the field.[37] For this is what happens when the Church is deserted by the clergy in time of persecution. (3) But if it is not fitting that the leaders of the flock should flee when the wolves descend upon the sheep, then those who have been given charge over the Church cannot flee in time of persecution.

CHAPTER 12

(1) That, I think, should be a sufficient answer to the question that you raised, my brother. But the person who raises the question as to flight in time of persecution must go on to ask the next one, namely, if we cannot flee, then may we buy our safety when persecution comes? I will also have a few suggestions for you on this point, declaring that we can no more buy our safety than we can run away when persecution strikes. And the key to my answer lies in the payment: just as flight is getting your security without money, so buying your security with money is flight. This, surely, is the counsel of fear. Because you fear, you pay, and when you pay, you flee. As regards your feet, you have stood still; as regards the money you paid, you have run away.

35. Cf. John 10:12.
36. Cf. Zech. 13:7.
37. Cf. Ezek. 34:2–16; Jer. 23.1–2.

(3) What kind of person is the one who misprizes the goods that were bought at so high a price? Far better that you run away than to become so mean that you should not prize yourself for as much as the Lord was willing to pay for you. The Lord indeed ransomed mankind from the angels who rule over the world, from the powers and spiritual hosts of wickedness,[38] from the darkness of this world,[39] from eternal judgment, from eternal death. And for a human being you bargain with an informer, or some soldier, or some petty thief of a ruler, passing money from up your sleeves, as they say, as if he were stolen goods, whom Christ redeemed before the whole world—and also set free! (4) We can have nothing but contempt for such a denier. What does the extortioner say? "Give me money!" You pay him so that he may not betray you, wishing not to be handed over; you have denied that you are what you have been unwilling to have made public, that is, a Christian. (5) Oh yes, perhaps you have admitted you are a Christian to some individual, but, in refusing to do so before many, you have denied Christ.

(6) Finally, what example do you use to justify your redeeming yourself by money? When did the apostles, dealing with the matter, ever gain with money their freedom from the troubles of persecution? When Felix the governor hoped to get some money from the disciples for Paul, and even took the matter up privately with Paul himself,[40] he got not one coin either from Paul or from the faithful. (8) Look at the situation of the kingdoms and empires as arranged by God. Every day they plan for future income, from the registration of property, taxes in kind, gifts, and taxes payable in money; but never up to this time has there been procured any such income by bringing the Christians under some sales tax for the person and the sect. We are bought with blood, we are paid for in blood, we owe no money for our head, because Christ is our Head.[41] (9) Since, therefore, Caesar has made no law that makes us a tribute-paying sect, how can anyone quote the text to me: "Render to Caesar the things

38. "Spiritual hosts of wickedness": *spiritalibus nequitiae,* apparently echoing Eph. 6:12. For similar language see *Apology,* n. 105.

39. Cf. Eph. 6:12.

40. Cf. Acts 24:23–26.

41. Cf. Eph. 5:23.

that are Caesar's"?[42] A soldier, be he informer or personal enemy, extorts money from me by threats, exacting nothing on Caesar's behalf—in fact, doing quite the opposite when for a bribe he lets me go, Christian that I am, and guilty by human law.

CHAPTER 13

(1) For the sake of charity I will give to everyone who asks, but not under duress. Christ said: "To the one who asks,"[43] but the man who uses intimidation does not ask. The man who threatens harm if you do not pay is not "asking" for money, he is extorting it. It is not alms he looks for who comes not to be pitied, but to be feared. I will give out of pity, but not out of fear. I will not give when the receiver thinks that he is doing me a favor and, looking at his loot, says "guilt money." Christ said also: "To the man who would take your tunic, grant your cloak also."[44] But that refers to the one who wants to snatch away my property, not my faith. I will grant my cloak to the one who asks, if he does not threaten with betrayal; if he threatens, I will take back my tunic, too.

(3) Finally, it is a small matter if one or two individuals are freed in this way. Whole churches have imposed taxes on themselves *en masse*. I do not know if it is a case more for sorrow than for shame, when you have Christians added to the tax lists of privileged soldiers[45] and spies, along with petty shopkeepers, porters, bath-thieves, gamblers, and panderers! Did the apostles establish the episcopacy in this fashion with such foresight, so that they might enjoy their rule in safety on the pretense of providing similar freedom to their flocks?

CHAPTER 14

(1) You may ask me: "How, then, shall we gather together? How shall we celebrate the solemn rites of the Lord's festival?"[46]

42. See Matt. 22:21

43. See Matt. 5:42; Luke 6:30.

44. See Matt 5:40; Luke 6:29.

45. "Privileged soldiers": *beneficiarii*. These soldiers were privileged because they had been released from regular duties to serve in an administrative office at higher pay.

46. "Solemn rites of the Lord's festival": *dominica sollemnia*. In classical literature *sollemnia* implied religious rites, often associated with a festival; cf. Lucretius, *On the Nature of Things* 5.1162.

To be sure, just as the apostles also did, protected by faith, not by money. If this faith can remove a mountain,[47] it can much more remove a soldier. Let your protection be wisdom, not a bribe. And even if you buy off the interference of the soldiers, will you then at once have security, also, from the people? All you need for your protection is to have both faith and wisdom. Finally, if you cannot gather together by day, you have the night, the light of Christ illuminating its darkness.[48] Can you not come and go one by one and by different ways, if where there are three you have a gathering of the faithful?[49] It is better that sometimes you do not see the vast crowds of your brethren than that you submit to the payment of ransom.

(2) Keep pure for Christ his virgin bride;[50] let no one make money out of her. The man who is afraid to suffer cannot belong to him who suffered for us. And so, "many are called but few are chosen."[51] It is not asked who is ready to follow the wide road, but who the narrow path.[52] (3) And, therefore, the Paraclete is needed, the guide to all truth,[53] the source of all endurance. Those who have received him have learned neither to flee from persecution nor basely to buy their freedom, for they have the one who will be at our side, ready to speak for us when we are questioned,[54] as well as to assist us when we suffer.

47. Cf. Matt. 17:20; Mark 11:22–23; 1 Cor. 13:2.

48. Cf. John 1:5; Eph. 5:14; 1 Thess. 5:5–8.

49. "Gathering of the faithful": *ecclesia*; for the "church of three" see Matt. 18:20, and for Tertullian's reflection elsewhere on the concept, see Rankin, *Tertullian and the Church,* 74–76.

50. Cf. Eph. 5:24–28.

51. Cf. Matt. 22:14.

52. Cf. Matt. 7:13–14.

53. Cf. John 16:13.

54. Cf. Matt. 10:19–20; Mark 13:11. "To speak . . . to assist": Tertullian, proficient in Greek, evidently plays on the semantic ambiguity of the Greek *paraklētos,* "advocate"—in the narrow sense, "speaking for," and in the wider sense, "helping," "assisting."

APPENDIX

For the following translation of the correspondence between Pliny and Trajan on the problems arising from the judicial investigation of the Christians, I have adopted the text of R. A. B. Mynors, ed., *C. Plini Caecili Secundi epistularum libri decem*, Scriptorum Classicorum Bibliotheca Oxoniensis (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1963), 338–40. In general I have chosen to translate freely rather than literally. For readers wishing to consult commentaries, two may be cited in particular:

1. On the Latin text, A. N. Sherwin-White, *The Letters of Pliny: A Historical and Social Commentary* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1966), 690–712.
2. On the text in English translation, Wynne Williams, trans., *Pliny: Correspondence with Trajan from Bithynia (Epistles X)* (Warminster, Wiltshire: Aris & Phillips, Ltd., 1990), 138–44.

LETTER 96, BOOK 10: PLINY TO TRAJAN

My lord, it is my custom to refer to you all matters about which I have any doubts. Who, after all, is in a better position both to overcome my hesitation and to instruct my ignorance? I have never had anything to do with the judicial investigations of Christians, and I therefore do not know either what are the usual terms of punishment, or how far to push the investigation. Several considerations seemed to me especially perplexing: whether age offered a basis for some distinction, or whether no difference at all was to be observed between the very young and those fully adult; whether pardon should be granted on the condition of repentance, or whether it was of no avail for one who had been a Christian to cease to be one; whether the name itself is punishable, even where there are no criminal acts, or whether it is the offences associated with the name that should be punished.

Meanwhile, I have taken the following course: in the case of those who were being denounced before me as Christians, I asked the ac-

cused whether in fact they were Christians. If they confessed, I advanced threats and asked them a second time and even a third. If they persisted, I had them executed, for I had no doubt that, regardless of what their confession might imply, at least their stubbornness and inflexible obstinacy should be punished. Others were infected with the same madness, but since they were Roman citizens I designated that they should be sent to Rome.

Soon, as often happens, the very process of investigation stimulated the accusation, and it appeared in several forms. An anonymous sheet was posted containing many names. I thought that I should dismiss the case of those who denied that they were or had been Christians: I would ask them to call upon the gods and upon your image, repeating after me my words (for I had your image along with the likenesses of the gods brought in for this very purpose); also to sacrifice with incense and wine; moreover, to curse Christ—for they say that none of those who are truly Christian can be compelled to do such things.

Others were accused by an informer. These said that they were Christians, and then denied: they said that they had indeed been Christians, but had ceased to be so, some, three years ago, some, several years ago, some even twenty years ago. These, too, all worshiped your image and the likenesses of the divinities, and cursed Christ. They affirmed, however, that the full extent of their fault or error had been this: it was their practice to meet before sunrise on a set day, and in antiphonal chant to sing a hymn to Christ as to a god, and to bind themselves with an oath to do nothing evil—to commit neither theft nor armed robbery nor adultery, not to go back on their word, or to refuse to surrender on request money that had been deposited in safe-keeping with them. When they had done this, it had been their custom to leave and to come together again for a meal, but one that was common and quite innocent. They had ceased to do so after my edict, in which, following your instructions, I had forbidden fraternal societies. And so I thought it was even more necessary for me to seek the truth from two female slaves, who were called "deaconesses," and I even applied torture, but found nothing but misguided and excessive superstition.

For this reason I have deferred the investigation and hurried to you for advice. I thought the matter worth referring to you, especially because of the large number of those whose lives are endangered, for many of every age, of every social class, and even of both sexes are being and will be called into danger, since this superstition has spread like a contagious infection not only through the cities, but also through the villages and the countryside. It is likely, however, that it can be checked and cured. At the very least, it is quite clear that peo-

ple have begun to attend in considerable numbers the temples that were but recently almost deserted; the sacred rites, for some time interrupted, are being performed, and everywhere merchants are selling the flesh of sacrificial victims, for which hitherto few buyers would be found. One can easily gather from this what a lot of people can be cured if you offer an opportunity for repentance.

LETTER 97, BOOK 10: TRAJAN TO PLINY

Dear Pliny, you have followed the right course in examining the cases of those who were brought before you as Christians. It is not possible to establish an inflexible rule that will hold in all cases. Christians must not be sought out. If they are brought before you and convicted, they must be punished, but with this proviso, that those who will deny that they are Christians—and will do so openly, that is, by offering prayers to our gods—should obtain pardon as a result of their repentance, even though their past may be suspected. But accusations on sheets anonymously posted should have no place whatever in any charge. Such a procedure would set the worst kind of precedent, and is out of harmony with the spirit of our age.

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AMONG THE VOICES THAT COME ACROSS the centuries from early Christianity, few speak with sharper accents, or in more highly colored tones, than that of Tertullian. First in the Latin-speaking West to leave a major corpus of writings, Tertullian is also the first in the West to address in both treatise and tract the issues confronted by Christians in their encounter with the surrounding pagan world.

Tertullian belonged to an era when Roman imperial power was at its height and paganism could proudly claim the blessings of the widespread Roman civilization. Though it was an officially tolerant world, unofficially it was suspicious of the politically incorrect: challenging social structures was an act of unthinkable bravado. Tertullian took on the challenge.

Before his conversion, Tertullian appears to have participated fully in his contemporary pagan culture. A Carthaginian, his education was thoroughly Roman; he was fluent in Latin and Greek, and widely read in literature, philosophy, rhetoric, and medicine. His conversion to Christianity brought to him a radically new vision of the world, while his pagan education provided him with the tools to express that vision with almost unparalleled power. He possessed a logic that penetrated through misty ambiguities to the heart of things; he practiced a formulaic style that sharpened inherent contrasts; and he refined a narrative art that enriched theology with vignettes of the pagan and Christian worlds of his day.

Tertullian is a primary source for a modern understanding of the issues that once confronted—and still confront—Christians living in a non-Christian world. Unfortunately, his writings have often been cast aside as too difficult to read. In this volume, Robert D. Sider undertakes a judicious pruning of the original texts and brings a fresh accessibility to the important writings of Tertullian.

ROBERT D. SIDER is professor emeritus of classical languages at Dickinson College and adjunct professor of history at the University of Saskatchewan. A leading expert on Tertullian, he is the author or editor of many works, including the popular text *Ancient Rhetoric and the Art of Tertullian*.

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